

# FRENCH IDIOMS AND PROVERBS

A COMPANION TO DESHUMBERT'S  
"DICTIONARY OF DIFFICULTIES"

BY

DE V. PAYEN-PAYNE

PRINCIPAL OF KENSINGTON COACHING COLLEGE  
ASSISTANT EXAMINER TO THE UNIVERSITY OF LONDON

*FOURTH REVISED AND ENLARGED EDITION*

[Fifth Thousand]

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# FRENCH IDIOMS AND PROVERBS

*“Omne epigramma sit instar apis; sit aculeus illi,  
Sint sua mella, sit et corporis exigui.”*

MARTIAL.

[Thus Englished by Archbishop Trench:

*“Three things must epigrams, like bees, have all;  
Its sting, its honey, and its body small.”]*

[And thus by my friend, Mr. F. Storr:

*“An epigram’s a bee: ’tis small, has wings  
Of wit, a heavy bag of humour, and it stings.”]*

*“Celebre dictum, scita quapiam novitate insigne.”*

ERASMUS.

*“The genius, wit, and spirit of a nation are discovered in its proverbs.”—*  
BACON.

*“The people’s voice the voice of God we call;  
And what are proverbs but the people’s voice?”*

JAMES HOWELL.

*“What oft was thought, but ne’er so well expressed.”*

POPE, *Essay on Criticism*.

*“The wit of one man, the wisdom of many.”—*LORD JOHN RUSSELL (*Quarterly Review*, Sept. 1850).

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*“Tant ayme on chien qu’on le nourrist,  
Tant court chanson qu’elle est aprise,  
Tant garde on fruit qu’il se pourrist,  
Tant bat on place qu’elle est prise.  
Tant tarde on que faut entreprise,  
Tant se haste on que mal advient,  
Tant embrasse on que chet la prise,  
Tant crie l’on Noel qu’il vient.”*

VILLON, *Ballade des Proverbes*.

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## PREFACE

In this edition I have endeavoured to keep down additions as much as possible, so as not to overload the book; but I have not been sparing in adding cross-references (especially in the Index) and quotations from standard authors. These quotations seldom give the first occasion on which a proverb has been used, as in most cases it is impossible to find it.

I have placed an asterisk before all recognised proverbs; these will serve as a first course for those students who do not wish to read through the whole book at once. In a few cases I have added explanations of English proverbs; during the eleven years I have been using the book I have frequently found that pupils were, for instance, as ignorant of “to bell the cat” as they were of “attacher le grelot.”

I must add a warning to students who use the book when translating into French. They must not use expressions marked “familiar” or “popular” except when writing in a familiar or low-class style. I have included these forms, because they are often heard in conversation, but they are seldom met with in serious French literature. A few blank pages have been added at the end for additions. Accents have been placed on capitals to aid the student; they are usually omitted in French printing.

In conclusion, I have to thank Mr. W. G. Lipscomb, M.A., Headmaster of Bolton Grammar School, Mr. E. Latham, and especially M. Georges Jamin of the École Lavoisier, Paris, for valuable suggestions; while M. Marius Deshumbert, and Professor Walter Rippmann, in reading through the proof sheets, have made many corrections and additions of the greatest value, for which I owe them my sincere gratitude.

DE V. PAYEN-PAYNE.

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# **FRENCH IDIOMS AND PROVERBS**

*Expressions to which an Asterisk is prefixed are Proverbs.*

## A.

### A

*Il ne sait ni A ni B* = He does not know B from a bull's foot; He cannot read; He is a perfect ignoramus.

*Être marqué à l'A* = To stand high in the estimation of others.

[This expression is supposed to have originated in the custom of stamping French coin with different letters of the alphabet. The mark of the Paris Mint was an "A," and its coins were supposed to be of a better quality than those stamped at provincial towns. But as this custom only began in 1418 by command of the Dauphin, son of Charles VI., and as the saying was known long previous, it is more probable that its origin is to be sought in the pre-eminence that A has always held in all Aryan languages, and that the French have borrowed it from the Romans. Compare MARTIAL, ii. 57, and our A i, at Lloyd's.]

### Abandon

*Tout est à l'abandon* = Everything is at sixes and sevens, in utter neglect, in confusion.

[Also: *Tout va à la dérive.*]

### Abattre

*\*Petite pluie abat grand vent* = A little rain lays much dust; Often quite a trifle calms a torrent of wrath.

[Compare:

"Hi motus animorum atque haec certamina tanta  
Pulveris exigui jactu compressa quiescunt."

VERGIL, *Georgics*, iv. 86-7.]

*Abattre de l'ouvrage* = To get through a great deal of work.

### Aboi

*Être aux abois* = To be reduced to the last extremity;**Abondance**  
To be at bay.

[Compare BOILEAU: “Dès que j’y veux rêver, ma veine est aux abois.”]

\**Abondance de biens ne nuit pas* = Store is no sore;**Abonder**  
One cannot have too much of a good thing.

*Parler avec abondance* = To speak fluently.

*Parler d’abondance* = To speak extempore.

*Il abonde dans mon sens* = He is entirely of the same**Abord**  
opinion as I am; He has come round to my  
opinion.

*Il a l’abord rude, mais il s’adoucit bientôt* = He**Aboutir**  
receives you roughly at first, but that soon passes  
off.

*A (or, De) prime abord* = At first sight; At the first  
blush.

*Les pourparlers n’ont pas abouti* = The preliminary**Absent**  
negotiations led to nothing.

\*“*Les absents ont toujours tort*” = When absent, one**Absurde**  
is never in the right.

“When a man’s away,  
Abuse him you may.”

[NÉRICAULT-DESTOUCHES, *L’obstacle imprévu*, i. 6.]



*L'homme absurde est celui qui ne change jamais* = **Accommodement**  
The wise man changes his opinion—the fool  
never.

[BARTHÉLEMY, *Palinode*. 1832.]

*Il est avec le ciel des accommodements* = One can **Accommoder**  
arrange things with heaven.

[Compare MOLIÈRE, *Tartufe*, iv. 5:

“Le ciel défend, de vrai, certains contentements,  
Mais on trouve avec lui des accommodements.”

The scene in which Orgon, hidden beneath the table, learns  
Tartufe's hypocrisy.]

*Un méchant accommodement est mieux que le  
meilleur procès* = A bad arrangement is better than  
the best lawsuit.

*Je l'accorderai comme il faut* = I will give him a **Accord**  
good hiding.

*Il s'accommode de tout* = He is satisfied with  
everything; He is easy to please.

*D'accord* = Granted.

**Accorder**

*Accordez mieux vos flûtes, si vous voulez réussir* = **Accoutumer**  
You must agree better among yourselves if you  
wish to succeed.

[Generally in bad sense. “Mettez, pour me jouer, vos flûtes mieux  
d'accord.”—MOLIÈRE, *L'Etourdi*, i. 4.]

*S'accorder comme chien et chat* = To live a cat and  
dog life.

*Chose accoutumée n'est pas fort prisee* = Familiarity breeds contempt. **Accrocher**

[The Latin version of a sentence in PLUTARCH'S *Morals* runs: "Nimia familiaritas contemptum parit."

Fais feste au chien, il te gastera ton habit.

"Jamais trop compagnon à nul ne te feras

Car bien que moins de joye moins d'ennuy tu auras."]

*Un homme qui se noie s'accroche à tout* = A drowning man catches at a straw. **Acheter**

*Il a accroché sa montre* (pop.) = He has "popped" his watch.

[Other popular synonyms are the following:—

*Il a mis sa montre au clou* (pop.) = His watch is up the spout.

*J'ai porté ma montre chez ma tante* (pop.) = My watch is at my uncle's.]

*Acheter à vil prix* = To buy dirt cheap, for a mere song. **Achever**

*Acheter chat en poche* = To buy a pig in a poke.

*Acheter par francs et vendre par écus* = To buy in the cheapest market and sell in the dearest; To sell at a high profit.

*C'est un voleur achevé* = He is an arrant thief. **Achoppement**

*La pierre d'achoppement* = The stumbling-block. **Acquérir**

*\*Le bien mal acquis ne profite jamais* = Ill-gotten gains benefit no one; Cheats never prosper; Ill got, ill spent. **Acquit**

*Faire quelque chose par manière d'acquit* = To do **Acte**  
something for form's sake, perfunctorily.

[This is a shortened form of *faire quelque chose pour l'acquit de sa conscience* = to do something to satisfy one's conscience.]

*Donner l'acquit* = To break (at billiards).

*Pour acquit* = Received (on bills).

*Faire acte de présence* = To put in an appearance.     **Adieu**

*Sans adieu* = I shall not say good-bye; I shall see you **Adresse**  
again soon.

["Adieu" is shortened from "Je vous recommande à la grâce de Dieu."  
Comp. "Sans adieu, chevalier, je crois que nous nous reverrons  
bientôt."—LESAGE.]

*Le trait est arrivé à son adresse* = The shaft (or, **Adresser**  
arrow) hit the mark; He took the hint.

*Vous vous adressez mal; Vous vous adressez bien* **Advenir**  
(ironic.) = You have come to the wrong person;  
You have mistaken your man.

\**Advienne que pourra* = Happen what may.     **Affaire**

*Cela fera parfaitement l'affaire* = That will do **Affamer**  
capitally; That will suit down to the ground.

*C'est son affaire* = That is his business, his look-out.

*Ça, c'est mon affaire* = That is my business; It is no  
business of yours.

*Il est sûr de son affaire* = He will pay for it; He will catch it.

*Je ne dis pas mes affaires aux autres* = I do not tell others my plans (or business); I keep my concerns to myself.

*J'entends votre affaire* = I see what is to be done for you.

*Ils parlent affaires* = They are talking business.

*Ils parlent boutique* = They are talking shop.

*C'est une triste affaire* = It is a sad business.

*S'attirer une mauvaise affaire* = To get into a mess, scrape.

*Quand on a de l'esprit, on se tire d'affaire* = When one has brains, one gets out of any difficulty.

[Distinguish between *se tirer* and *s'attirer*.]

*Si quelque affaire t'importe, ne la fais pas par procureur* = If you want a thing done, do it yourself.

*L'affaire a été chaude* = It was warm work (referring to a fight).

*Une affaire d'honneur* = A duel.

*Où sont mes affaires?* = Where are my things?

*Les affaires ne vont pas (ne marchent pas)* = Trade is dull, slack.

*Je suis dans les affaires* = I am in business.

[“Les affaires? C’est bien simple, c’est l’argent des autres.”—ALEX. DUMAS fils, *La Question d’Argent*, ii. 7.]

*Mêlez-vous de vos affaires* = Mind your own business.

*Avoir affaire* = To be occupied.

*Avoir affaire à quelqu'un* = To have to speak to (to deal with) a person.

[Sometimes as a threat:

*Il aura affaire à moi* = He will have to deal with me.]

*Avoir affaire de quelqu'un* = To need a person.

[“J’ai affaire de vous, ne vous éloignez pas.”]

*Avoir son affaire* = To have what suits one. *J’ai mon affaire* = I have found what I want. *J’ai votre affaire* = I have got the very thing for you. *Il aura son affaire* (ironic.) = He will catch it.

*C’est toute une affaire* = It is a serious matter; It means a lot of bother (or, trouble).

*C’est une affaire faite* = It is as good as done.

*Son affaire est faite* = He is a dead man (of one dying); He is done for; He is a ruined man.

*Faire son affaire* = (of oneself) To succeed. *Il fait tout doucement son affaire* = He is getting on slowly but surely.

(Of others) To punish. *S’il le rencontre, il lui fera son affaire* = If he meets him he will give it to him, will “do” for him.

*Il a fait ses affaires dans les vins* = He made his money in the wine trade.

*J’en fais mon affaire* = I will take the responsibility of the matter; I will see to it; I will take it in hand.

*Vous avez fait là une belle affaire* (ironic.) = You have made a pretty mess of it.

*Une affaire de rien* = A mere nothing, a trifle.

*Il est hors d’affaire* = He is out of danger.

*Être au dessous de ses affaires, être au dessus de ses affaires* (ironic.) = To be unable to meet one’s

liabilities, to be unsuccessful.

*Quelle affaire! En voilà une affaire!* (ironic.) = What a to-do! What a row about nothing!

*La belle affaire!* = Is that all? (i.e. it is not so difficult or important as you seem to think).

*Il n'y a point de petites affaires* = Every trifle is of importance.

*Ceux qui n'ont point d'affaires s'en font* = Those who have no troubles invent them; Idle people make business for themselves.

*Les affaires sont les affaires* = Business is business; One must be serious at work.

*Ce scandale sera l'affaire de huit jours* = That scandal will be a nine days' wonder.

*Dieu nous garde d'un homme qui n'a qu'une affaire* = God save us from the man of one idea.

[Because he is always talking of it, and tires every one. Compare "Beware of the man of one book."]

*Chacun sait ses affaires* = Every one knows his own business best.

\**A demain les affaires sérieuses* = I will not be bothered with business to-day; Time enough for business to-morrow.

[The saying of Archias, governor of Thebes, on receiving a letter from Athens warning him of the conspiracy of Pelopidas; he would not even open the letter. Soon after, the conspirators rushed in and murdered him and his friends as they were feasting.]

*Il vaut mieux avoir affaire à Dieu qu'à ses saints* = It is better to deal with superiors than subordinates.

[Two quotations from La Fontaine are proverbial:—

"On ne s'attendait guère  
A voir Ulysse en cette affaire."

*La Tortue et les deux  
Canards.*

"Le moindre grain de mil

Serait bien mieux mon affaire.”

*Le Coq et la Perle.*]

\**Ventre affamé n’a point d’oreilles* = A hungry man **Afficher** will not listen to reason.

[LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, ix. 18.]

*Défense d’afficher* = Stick no bills.

**Affront**

*C’est un homme qui s’affiche* = He is a man who tries to get talked about (generally in a disparaging sense).

[Être *affiché* is also said of a man who has been “posted” at his club.]

*Faire affront à quelqu’un* = To shame some one in **Affût** public.

*Le fils fait affront à sa famille* = The son is a disgrace to his family.

*Boire (essuyer or avaler) un affront* = To pocket an insult.

*Être à l’affût* = To be watching for a favourable **Âge** opportunity; To be on the look-out. (See [Aguets](#).)

*Il est entre deux âges* = He is middle-aged.

**Agir**

*Il est président d’âge* = He is chairman by seniority.

*Le bas âge* = Infancy.

*Le bel âge* = Childhood; youth.

[Some idea is generally understood after *le bel âge*. Thus “childhood” is not always the right translation. For an author *le bel âge* would be after thirty, for a politician later still, and so on. Chicaneau, in Racine’s *Plaideurs*, calls sixty *le bel âge pour plaider* (i. 7).]

*La fleur de l’âge* = The prime of life.

*Le moyen âge* = The Middle Ages.

*Il s'agit de...* = The question is...; The point is... **Agiter**

*Il s'agit de votre vie* = Your life is at stake.

*Il ne s'agit pas de cela* = That is not the point.

*Il s'agit bien de cela* (ironic.) = That is quite a secondary consideration.

*Qui s'agite s'enrichit* = If you wish to get rich, you **Agonie** must work (hustle); No pains, no gains.

*Même à travers l'agonie la passion dominante se fait* **Aguets** *voir* = The ruling passion is strong in death.

[“Elle a porté ses sentiments jusqu’à l’agonie.”—BOSSUET.

“And you, brave Cobham! to the latest breath  
Shall feel your ruling passion strong in death.”

POPE, *Moral Essays*, i. 262.]

*Il est aux aguets* = He is on the watch; He is in **Aide** ambush. (See [Affût](#).)

\**Un peu d'aide fait grand bien* = Many hands make **Aider** light work.

*Bon droit a besoin d'aide* = Even a good cause needs **Aiguille** support.

\**Aide-toi, le ciel t'aidera* = God helps those who help themselves.

[LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, vi. 18, *Le Chartier embourbé*, copying RÉGNIER, Sat. xiii.:

“Aydez vous seulement et Dieu vous aydera.”

Lat.: Dii facientes adjuvant.



ÆSCHYLUS, *Persae*, 742: Σπεύδοντι σαυτῶ χῶ θεὸς ξυνάψεται.

SOPHOCLES, *Camicii*, frag. 633, in Dindorf's edition: Οὐκ ἔστι τοῖς μὴ δρῶσι σύμμαχος Τύχη.

Another Greek saying was: Σύν, Αθηνᾶ καὶ χεῖρα κίνει = With Minerva on your side, yet use your own hand.

Cromwell is reported to have said at the battle of Dunbar: "Trust in God, but keep your powder dry."

The Basques say: "Quoique Dieu soit bon ouvrier, il veut qu'on l'aide."]

*De fil en aiguille* = Bit by bit; One thing leading to **Aiguillon** another.

[“De propos en propos et de fil en eguille.”—RÉGNIER, Sat. xiii.]

*Raconter de fil en aiguille* = To tell the whole matter from the beginning.

*Disputer sur la pointe d'une aiguille* = To raise a discussion on a subject of no importance; To split hairs.

\**Chercher une aiguille dans une botte de foin* = To look for a needle in a bundle (bottle) of hay.

*A dur âne dur aiguillon* = In dealing with obstinate **Aile** natures one must use severe measures.

*Il en a dans l'aile* = He is winged (hurt). **Aimer**

*Le ministère a du plomb dans l'aile* = The ministry is nearing its end, is winged.

*Il ne bat plus que d'une aile* = He is almost ruined; He is on his last legs.

*Voler de ses propres ailes* = To act (or, shift) for oneself.

*J'en tirerai pied ou aile* = I will get something out of it.

[Idiom derived from carving a bird—to get a leg or a wing off it.]

*C'est la plus belle plume de son aile* (or, *le plus beau fleuron de sa couronne*) = It is the finest gem of his crown.

\**Qui aime bien châtie bien* = Spare the rod and spoil the child.

[*Proverbs* xiii. 24.]

*Aimer quelqu'un comme la prune de ses yeux* = To love somebody like the apple of one's eye.

*Quand on n'a pas ce que l'on aime il faut aimer ce que l'on a* = If you cannot get crumb you had best eat crust.

[This sentence is found in a letter from Bussy Rabutin to Madame de Sévigné, May 23, 1667.

“Quoniam non potest id fieri quod vis, id velis quod possit.”—TERENCE, *Andria*, ii. 1, 6. “When things will not suit our will, it is well to suit our will to things.”—Arab proverb.

“Let not what I cannot have  
My peace of mind destroy.”

COLLEY CIBBER, *The Blind Boy*.]

\**Qui aime Bertrand, aime son chien* = Love me, love my dog.

[“Qui me amat, amat et canem meum.”—S. BERNARD, *In Fest. S. Mich. Serm.*, i. sec. 3.]

\**Qui aime bien, tard oublie* = True love dies hard.

*Qui m'aime me suive* = Peril proves who dearly loves.

[Words attributed to Philippe VI. when at a Council during his war with Flanders, the Connétable de Châtillon alone stood by him, saying all times were suitable to the brave.]

*En plein air; Au grand air* = In the open air.

**Algèbre**

*Être entre deux airs*  
*Être dans un courant d'air* } = To be in a draught.

*Avoir toujours le pied en l'air* = To be always on the go.

*Il parle en l'air* = He talks without thinking of what he is saying, at random, not seriously.

*Je vais prendre l'air du bureau* = I am just going to look in at the office.

*Prendre un air de feu* = To go near the fire for a few minutes to warm oneself.

*A votre air on ne vous donnerait pas vingt-cinq ans* = From your looks I should take you for less than five-and-twenty.

*Vivre de l'air du temps* = To live upon nothing (i.e. to eat very little).

*Elle a quelque chose de votre air* = She takes after you; She looks somewhat like you.

*Il a un faux air d'avocat* = He looks something like a barrister.

*Cela en a tout l'air* = It looks uncommonly like it.

*Il a un air (or, l'air) comme il faut* = He has a very gentlemanly manner.

*C'est de l'algèbre pour lui* = It is Greek to him. **Allemand**

[“C'est de l'hébreu pour moi.”—MOLIÈRE, *L'Étourdi*, iii. 3.]

*Chercher une querelle d'Allemand* = To pick a quarrel about nothing, without rhyme or reason.

[This saying has been accounted for as follows:—During the thirteenth century there lived in Dauphiné a very powerful family of the name of Alleman. They were bound together by close ties of relationship;

and if any one attacked one member of the clan, he had the whole to reckon with. From the vigour with which they resented any wrong, no matter how slight, arose the expression *Une querelle d'Alleman*. See M. Jules Quicherat's article on *La famille des Alleman* in the *Revue historique de la noblesse*, Part vi.]

\**Tant va la cruche à l'eau qu'à la fin elle se casse* = **Allumer**  
The pitcher that often goes to the well gets broken  
at last.

[This has been travestied: *Tant va la cruche à l'eau qu'à la fin elle s'emplit*. The Germans have an equivalent: *Der Krug geht so lange zum Brunnen, bis er bricht*.]

\**Doucement va bien loin* = Fair and softly goes far;  
Slow and sure wins the race.

[The Italian equivalent is: *Chi va piano va sano e va lontano*.  
"Qui trop se hâte en cheminant  
En beau chemin se fourvoye souvent."

"On en va mieux quand on va doux."—LA FONTAINE, *Les Cordeliers de Catalogne*.]

*Il y allait du bonheur de ma famille* = The happiness  
of my family was at stake.

*Ce jeune homme ira loin* = That young man will  
make his way in the world, has a future before  
him.

*Au pis aller* = Should the worst come to the worst.

*Un pis aller* = A makeshift.

*Aller son petit bonhomme de chemin* = To jog along  
quietly.

*Cela va tout seul* = There is no difficulty in the way.

*Cela va sans dire* = That is a matter of course; It  
stands to reason.

*Cela va de soi* = That follows naturally.

*Il ne reviendra pas, allez!* = Depend upon it, he will  
not return!

*Va pour mille francs!* = Done! I'll take £40.

*Aller cahin-caha*        } (lit.) To limp along.  
*Aller clopin-clopant*   } (fig.) To rub along  
quietly, neither very well nor very ill.

*Elle le fait aller* = She makes him do what she likes.

*Le rouge va bien aux brunes* = Red suits dark women well.

*Allons!* = Come, now!

*Allons donc!* = You are joking.

*“Il n'est bois si vert qui ne s'allume”* (CLÉMENT **Alors** MAROT) = There is nothing so difficult that cannot be done in time.

*Alors comme alors* = Wait till that happens, and then **Ambre** we will see what is to be done.

*Fin comme l'ambre* = As sharp as a needle. **Amener**

[This is said to have originated in the scent of ambergris, which is of a subtle, penetrating nature.]

*Cette preuve est amenée de bien loin* = That proof is **Ami** very far-fetched.

\**Qui prête à l'ami perd au double* = “For loan oft **Amitié** loses both itself and friend.”

[*Hamlet*, i. 3.]

\**On connaît les amis au besoin* = A friend in need is a friend indeed.

[Also: *C'est dans le malheur qu'on connaît ses amis.*

*"Chacun se dit ami, mais fou qui s'y repose  
Rien n'est plus commun que le nom  
Rien n'est plus rare que la chose."*

LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, iv.  
17.

*"Amicus certus in re incerta cernitur."*—ENNIUS.

*"Nihil homini amico est opportuno amicus."*—PLAUTUS.

*"Vulgare amici nomen, sed rara est fides."*—PHAEDRUS, iii. 9.

*"Les amis sont comme les parapluies, on ne les a jamais sous la main  
quand il pleut."*—THÉODORE DE BANVILLE.

Un véritable ami est un bienfait des dieux.  
Prosperity gains friends, adversity tries them.  
Friends and mules fail us at hard passes.  
In times of prosperity friends will be plenty,  
In times of adversity not one in twenty.]

*Mieux vaut ami en voie que denier en courroie* = A  
friend at court is better than money.

*Il ne faut prendre de son ami tout ce qu'on peut* =  
Friends are like fiddle-strings, they must not be  
screwed too tight.

*"Les amis de l'heure présente  
Ont la nature du melon,  
Il en faut essayer cinquante  
Avant qu'on rencontre un bon."*

CLAUDE MERMET (1550-  
1605).

= Trust not a new friend nor an old enemy;  
Acquaintances are many, but friends are few.

*Faites mes amitiés à votre frère* = Remember me **Amour**  
kindly to your brother.

*Faites-le pour l'amour de moi* = Do it for my sake. **Amuser**

*L'Amour force toutes les serrures* = Love laughs at  
locksmiths.

*Vivre d'amour et d'eau fraîche* (or, *claire*) = To live  
on bread and cheese and kisses.

*\*On revient toujours à ses premières amours* = One always returns to one's first love; Who loves well, forgets ill.

[C. G. ÉTIENNE, *Joconde*, iii. 1.]

*Jamais l'amour ne se paye que par l'amour* = Love can neither be bought nor sold, its only price is love.

["Amour au cœur me poind  
Quand bien-aimé je suis,  
Mais aimer je ne puis  
Quand on ne m'aime point.  
Chacun soit adverti  
De faire comme moi,  
Car d'aimer sans party  
C'est un trop grand esmoy."]

CLÉMENT  
MAROT.

Lieb ohne Gegenlieb ist wie eine Frage ohne Antwort.]

*On dirait qu'il le fait pour l'amour du bon Dieu* = He does it with such bad grace that one would say he did it for conscience' sake.

["Qui que tu sois, voici ton maître,  
Il l'est, le fut, ou le doit être."]

VOLTAIRE, *Inscription pour une statue de l'Amour dans les Jardins de Maisons.*

"A l'Amour on résiste en vain;  
Qui n'aima jamais aimera demain."

DE BENSERADE, *L'Amour*, ed. 1690, p. 234.]

*Amuser le tapis* = To talk a great deal without **An** coming to the point; To talk time away.

*Ne vous amusez pas en route* = Do not lose an instant on the way.

*Je m'en moque comme de l'an quarante* = I don't **Âne** care a straw for it.

[There was a superstition that the world would come to an end in 1040; after it had passed, this saying arose. The French also say "Je m'en moque comme de Colin-tampon." Colin-tampon is the name given to the Swiss roll of the drum; and as the other soldiers in the

French army paid no attention to it out of jealousy and esprit de corps, this saying arose. Another variant is “Je m’en soucie autant qu’un poisson d’une pomme.”]

*Bon an, mal an* = One year with another; On an average.

*Ressembler à l’âne de Buridan* = Not to know what **Ange** to do.

[Jean Buridan was a dialectician of the fourteenth century, and Rector of the University of Paris. One of his most famous dilemmas was that of the donkey equally hungry and thirsty, which was placed halfway between a pail of water and a load of hay. If the animal had no free-will, it would remain motionless between two equal attractions, and so die of hunger and thirst.]

*Contes de Peau d’Âne* = Nursery tales.

[A name derived from a tale of Perrault, in which the heroine is so called.]

*Pour un point (or, Faute d’un point) Martin perdit son âne* = For want of a nail the shoe was lost (or, the miller lost his mare); Be careful of trifles.

[This is said of a person who loses something valuable through a trifle. The Abbey of Asello (Latin *asellus* = little ass) was taken from the Abbot Martin on account of his punctuation of a sentence over the gateway. Instead of: *Porta patens esto, nulli claudaris honesto* (Gate be open, and be closed to no honest man), he punctuated: *Porta patens esto nulli, claudaris honesto* (Gate, be open to none, be closed to an honest man). His successor corrected the mistake, and added: *Uno pro puncto caruit Martinus Asello.*]

*Il fait l’âne pour avoir du son* = He simulates stupidity to gain some material advantage.

*Brider un âne par la queue* = To do anything in exactly the wrong manner; To get hold of the wrong end of the stick.

*Il n’y a point d’âne plus mal bête que celui du commun* = What is everybody’s business is nobody’s business.

[Walton, *Compleat Angler*, Part i. chap. ii.]



*Être aux anges* = To be delighted, in raptures, in the **Anguille** seventh heaven.

*Un ange bouffi* = A chubby child.

*Échapper comme une anguille* = To be as slippery as **Anonyme** an eel.

*Quand on veut trop serrer l'anguille, elle s'échappe*  
= "Much would have more and lost all"; He who is too greedy loses everything. (See [Embrasser](#).)

*Vouloir rompre l'anguille au genou* = To attempt an impossibility.

*Il est comme l'anguille de Melun* (more correctly, *Languille de Melun*), *il crie avant qu'on l'écorche*  
= He is like the eel of Melun, he cries out before he is hurt.

[An actor, called Languille, was once acting the part of St. Bartholomew at Melun, when he was so frightened at the entry of the executioner to flay him alive, that he rushed off the stage yelling.]

*Il y a quelque anguille sous roche* = There is a snake in the grass; I can smell a rat.

[Lat. *Latet anguis in herba*.]

*Société anonyme* = Limited Liability Company **Anse** (because the names of the shareholders are unknown to the public).

*Faire danser l'anse* (or, *le manche*) *du panier* = To **Antan** make dishonest profits on marketing (of servants); To gain a market-penny.

*Faire le pot (or, panier) à deux anses* = To put one's arms akimbo.

[Often said of a gentleman who has a lady on each arm.]

*“Où sont les neiges d'antan?”* = Where are the **Apache** snows of yester-year?

[Antan is an old French word derived from *ante* and *annus*. The quotation is the refrain of François Villon's famous “Ballade des Dames du temps jadis.”]

*C'est un apache* (pop.) = He is a hooligan. **Apothicaire**

*C'est un apothicaire sans sucre* = He is unprovided **Apôtre** with the necessities of his profession.

[Druggists in France formerly sold sugar which they used almost in every preparation. Hence one who had no sugar was badly stocked.]

*Faire le bon apôtre* = To put on a saintly look; To **Apparence** pretend to be holy.

[“Tout Picard que j'étais, j'étais un bon apôtre Et je faisais claquer mon fouet tout comme un autre.”

RACINE, *Plaideurs*, i. 1.]

*Pour sauver les apparences* = For the sake of **Appartenir** appearances.

*Selon toute apparence* = In all probability.

*A tous ceux qu'il appartiendra* (legal) = To all whom **Appât** it may concern.

*\*C'est un trop vieux poisson pour mordre à l'appât* **Appel**  
= He is too old a bird to be caught with chaff.

*Faire l'appel* = To call the roll.

**Appeler**

*Manquer à l'appel* = To be missing, absent.

*Battre l'appel* = To call to arms.

*Il appelle les choses par leur nom* = He calls a spade **Appétit**  
a spade.

[“J’appelle un chat un chat, et Rolet un fripon.”—BOILEAU, *Satires*, i.  
52.]

*Voilà ce que j’appelle pleuvoir* = This is what I call  
raining with a vengeance.

*Bon appétit* = Good appetite; I hope you will enjoy **Apprendre**  
your meal.

\**L’appétit vient en mangeant* = One leg of mutton  
helps down another; The more one has the more  
one wants; Begin to eat, you’ll soon be hungry.

[“As if increase of appetite had grown  
By what it fed on.”

*Hamlet*, i.  
2.

“L’appétit vient en mangeant, disait Angeston, mais la soif s’en va en  
buvant.”—RABELAIS, *Gargantua*, i.]

\**Il n’est chère que d’appétit* = Hunger is the best  
sauce.

[“Ἡ ἐπιθυμία τοῦ σίτου ὄψον.”

XENOPHON, *Cyrop.* i. 5,  
12.]

\**Pain dérobé réveille appétit* = Stolen joys are  
sweet.

*Les malheurs s’apprennent bien vite* = Ill news flies **Apprenti**  
fast (or, apace).

*Vous apprendrez avec plaisir....* = You will be glad to hear....

\**Ce n'est pas à un vieux singe qu'on apprend à faire des grimaces* (fam.) = One does not teach one's grandmother to suck eggs. (See [Remontrer](#).)

[The Greek equivalent was, "To teach an eagle to fly," or "to teach a dolphin to swim."—ZENOB. ii. 49.

The Romans said, "Sus Minervam docet." Cf. CICERO, *De Oratore*, ii. 57.]

\**Apprenti n'est pas maître* = One must not expect **Appui** from a beginner the talent of an old hand; You must spoil before you spin.

*Mur à hauteur d'appui* = A wall breast high (so that **Appuyer** one may lean against it).

*Faites la proposition, j'irai à l'appui de la boule* = You make the proposal, and I will support it.

[This idiom comes from the game of bowls, when by hitting your partner's ball you may drive it nearer the goal, though unable to approach yourself.]

*Vous vous appuyez sur un roseau* = You are trusting **Après** to a broken reed.

\**Après lui il faut tirer l'échelle* = One cannot do **Araignée** better than he has; No one can come up to him in that; That takes the cake.

[Comp. MOLIÈRE, *Médecin malgré lui*, ii. 1.]

\**Jeter le manche après la cognée* = To throw the helve after the hatchet; To give up in despair.

\**Après nous le déluge* = A short life and a merry one; We need not bother about what will happen

after we are gone.

[These words were attributed to Madame de Pompadour (1721-1764) in reply to those who remonstrated with her for her extravagance —“When I am gone, the deluge may come for all I care.” (See DESPREZ, *Essai sur la Marquise de Pompadour*, a preface to his *Mémoires de Madame du Hausset*.) The same idea occurs in the Greek proverb quoted by Cicero (*De Finibus*, iii. 19), “Ἐμοῦ θανόντος γαῖα μιχθήτω πυρί.” Milton suggests Tiberius as saying, “When I die, let the earth be rolled in flames.”—*Reason of Church Government*, i. 5.]

*Avoir une araignée dans le (or, au) plafond* = To **Arbre**  
have a bee in one's bonnet.

*\*Entre l'arbre et l'écorce il ne faut pas mettre le* **Arc**  
*doigt* = One must not interfere in other people's  
quarrels.

[This proverb has been travestied by Molière, who makes Sganarelle say: “Apprenez que Cicéron dit qu'entre l'arbre et le doigt il ne faut pas mettre l'écorce.”—*Le Médecin malgré lui*, i. 2.]

*L'arbre ne tombe pas au premier coup* = Everything  
requires time and exertion; Rome was not built in  
a day.

*Quand l'arbre est tombé tout le monde court aux  
branches* = When the tree falls every one goes to  
it with his hatchet.

*Il s'est toujours tenu au gros de l'arbre* = He has  
always sided with the stronger side.

*Débander l'arc ne guérit pas la plaie* = To cease **Arçon**  
doing mischief does not undo the harm one has  
done.

*Être ferme sur les arçons* = (lit.) To have a firm seat **Argent**  
in the saddle; (fig.) Not to waver in one's

principles.

*Il a vidé les arçons* = He was unhorsed.

*L'argent est un bon passe-partout* = Gold goes in at **Arme**  
any gate, except heaven.

[“Amour fait moult  
Mais argent fait tout.”]

*Être cousu d'argent* = To be made of money; To be  
rolling in riches.

*Il est chargé d'argent comme un crapaud de plumes*  
= He is penniless.

*Y aller bon jeu bon argent* = To set about a thing in  
earnest.

*\*Point d'argent, point de Suisse* = No money, no  
Swiss; No pay, no piper.

[In the Middle Ages the Swiss were the chief mercenaries of Europe,  
and occasionally had to resort to severe measures to obtain their  
pay. Compare RACINE, *Plaideurs*, i. 1. One day when the Swiss  
were asking for their pay from the king the French Prime Minister  
said: “The money we have given these Swiss would pave a road  
from Paris to Basle.” To which the Swiss commander replied: “And  
the blood we have shed for France would fill a river from Basle to  
Paris!”]

*Payer argent comptant* = To pay ready money; To  
pay in hard cash.

[Synonyms are: *En beaux deniers comptants* or, *en espèces sonnantes  
et trébuchantes*.]

*Prendre quelque chose pour argent comptant* = To  
take something for gospel.

*Je suis à court d'argent* (fam. *à sec*) = I am short of  
money (fam. hard up, broke).

*\*Qui n'a pas argent en bourse, ait miel en bouche* =  
He who has not silver in his purse should have  
honey on his tongue.

*\*Argent emprunté porte tristesse* = He who goes a-borrowing goes a-sorrowing.

*Représenter les armes de Bourges* = To look stupid. **Arracher**

[The arms of Bourges are an ass sitting in an armchair.]

*Les armes sont journalières* = Victory is fickle.

*On se l'arrache* = (of persons) He is the rage; (of **Arracheur** things) There is a regular scramble for it.

*Mentir comme un arracheur de dents* = To lie **Arranger** unblushingly; To lie like an epitaph.

*Comme vous voilà arrangé!* = What a sight you **Arrêt** look!

*Je l'ai arrangé de la bonne manière* = I gave him what he richly deserved.

*Arrangez-vous* = That is your business; Settle it among yourselves.

*Mettre un officier aux arrêts* = To put an officer **Arriver** under arrest.

*Garder les arrêts* = To keep to one's quarters.

*Lever les arrêts* = To release from arrest.

*C'est un homme qui arrivera* = He is sure to get on **Article** in the world.

*\*Un malheur n'arrive jamais seul* = Misfortunes never come singly; It never rains but it pours.

\**Cela arrive comme marée en carême* = That comes just in the nick of time (lit. as *sea-fish* in Lent).  
See [Carême](#).

*Être à l'article de la mort* (or, *à l'agonie*) = To be at **Assembler** death's door.

[Lat. *In articulo mortis*.]

\**Qui se ressemble, s'assemble* = Birds of a feather **Assiette** flock together; Like will to like.

*Il n'est pas dans son assiette* = He is not in his **Attache** normal state of mind; He is out of sorts; He is not up to the mark.

*Son assiette dîne pour lui* = He pays for his dinner whether he is present or not.

*C'est un casseur d'assiettes* = He is a swaggerer (a Mohock, in eighteenth century parlance).

*C'est un pique-assiette* = He is a parasite, a sponge.

*L'assiette des impôts* = The assessment of taxes.

*Le pauvre homme est toujours (comme un chien) à Attacher l'attache* = The poor man is a very slave, is compelled to work hard and constantly.

\**Attacher le grelot* = To bell the cat. **Attaquer**

[LA FONTAINE, *Conseil tenu par les rats*. For an explanation of the phrase see [Grelot](#).]

\**Attaquer le taureau par les cornes* = To seize the **Atteinte** bull by the horns.



*Porter atteinte (à l'honneur de)* = To sully (the fair **Atteler** name of).

*Porter atteinte (aux droits de)* = To infringe (the rights of).

*C'est une charrette mal attelée* = They are a badly-**Attendre** matched pair.

*Une question n'attendait pas l'autre* = Question **Attraper** quickly followed after question.

*Je m'y attendais* = That is just what I expected.

*Attendez-vous-y* = You may depend upon it; (or, ironic.) Don't you wish you may get it!

\**Tout vient à point à qui sait attendre* = Everything comes to the man who waits; Time and patience change the mulberry leaf into a silk gown.

*On peut s'attendre à tout, surtout à l'inattendu* = One may expect anything, especially the unexpected.

*Attrape qui peut!* = Scramble for it! **Audience**

*Attrape!* = 1. Catch! 2. Take that! 3. It serves you right.

*Audience à huis clos* = A case heard in camera. **Aune**

*Les hommes ne se mesurent pas à l'aune* = Men are **Aurore** not to be judged by their size.

[M. Thiers, who was very short, used to say: “Les liqueurs précieuses se conservent dans de petits flacons” = Rich wares in small parcels.]

*Savoir ce qu'en vaut l'aune* = To know a thing to one's cost.

*Mesurer les autres à son aune* = To measure other people's peck by one's own bushel.

*Tout le long de l'aune* = By the yard; Plenty of it.

*\*Travail d'aurore amène l'or* = Early to bed and **Aussitôt** early to rise, makes a man healthy, wealthy, and wise.

[The late H. Stacy Marks, R.A., parodied this: “Early to bed and early to rise, No use—unless you advertise.”]

The German equivalent is, “Morgenstund hat Gold im Mund”—The morning hour has gold in its mouth.

This is also found in Italian: “Le ore del mattino hanno l'oro in bocca.”]

*Aussitôt dit, aussitôt fait* = No sooner said than done. **Autant**

*Cela est fini ou autant vaut* = It is as good as **Autel** finished.

*\*Autant de têtes, autant d'avis* = So many men, so many minds.

[“Quot homines, tot sententiæ.”—TERENCE, *Phormio*, ii. 4. Also: “Autant de gens, autant de sens.”]

*Autant lui en pend au nez* (or, *à l'oreille*) = He will get just the same (in bad sense).

*Autant vaut être mordu d'un chien que d'une chienne* = One evil is as bad as the other.

*Autant dire mille francs* = We may as well say £40.  
(See [Aller](#).)

*Autant vaut celui qui tient que celui qui écorche* =  
The receiver is as bad as the thief.

[A hexameter of Phocylides says:

ἄμφοτεροι κλώπες, καὶ ὁ δεξάμενος καὶ ὁ  
κλέψας.]

*C'est toujours autant de gagné* = That's always so  
much to the good. (See [Prendre](#).)

\**Qui sert à l'autel doit vivre de l'autel* = Every man **Autour**  
must live by his profession.

*Il en prendrait sur l'autel* = He would rob a church.

*Tourner autour du pot* = To beat about the bush. **Autre**

[German: "Wie die Katze um den Brei laufen."]

*Il ne faut pas confondre autour avec alentour* = One  
must not mix up two things entirely different.

[The *gamin* of Paris adds to this saying: "ni intelligence avec  
gendarme."]

*Comme dit l'autre* = As the saying is. **Avaler**

[Or: *Comme on dit*.]

*Nous parlions de choses et d'autres* = We were  
speaking of different things.

*C'est tout un ou tout autre* = It is either one thing or  
the other.

*L'un vaut l'autre* = One is as bad as the other.

*Il en sait bien d'autres* = He knows more than one  
trick.

*C'est une autre paire de manches* = That is quite  
another thing; That is a horse of another colour.

*Il n'en fait pas d'autres* = That is always the way  
with him; He is at it again.

*Allez conter cela à d'autres* = Tell that to the marines.

[Often shortened to “À d'autres.”]

*Nous autres Anglais sommes très réservés* = We English are very reserved.

[“Nous autres ignorants estions perdus si ce livre ne nous eust relevé du boubier.” MONTAIGNE, *Essais*, ii. 4, speaking of Amyot's translation of Plutarch.]

\**Autres temps, autres mœurs* = Manners change with the times.

*J'en ai vu bien d'autres* = I have outlived worse things than that.

*Faire avaler des couleuvres à quelqu'un* = To say **Avancer** very humiliating things to a man who, on account of his inferior position, is obliged to put up with them; To make any one swallow a bitter pill.

*Votre montre avance de dix minutes* = Your watch is **Avant** ten minutes fast.

[Compare: “Votre montre retarde de dix minutes” = Your watch is ten minutes slow.]

*Cela m'avance bien!* (ironic.) = What good is that to me?

*Vous voilà bien avancé!* (ironic.) = Here you are in a pretty mess! What good have you gained by that?

*Je n'en suis pas plus avancé* = I am none the wiser (or, nearer).

*Vous allez trop avant* = You are going too far. **Avare**

*Ils sont arrivés bien avant dans la nuit* = They arrived very late at night.

\**A père avare, enfant prodigue* = A miserly father **Avec**  
has a spendthrift son.

[“A femme avare, galant escroc.”

LA FONTAINE, *Contes*, ii.]

*Avec ça!* (colloquial) = Nonsense!

**Averti**

\**Un bon averti* (or, *prévenu*) *en vaut deux* = A man **Aveu**  
well warned is twice a man; Forewarned,  
forearmed.

*C'est un homme sans aveu* = He is a vagabond.

**Aveugle**

[In feudal times a vassal had to make an *avowal* to his lord of the lands  
he held, placing them under his lord's protection. A man who had  
no property could not do so.]

\**Rien ne soulage comme un aveu sincère* = Open  
confession is good for the soul.

*Crier comme un aveugle (qui a perdu son bâton or, son chien)* = To yell with all one's might.

[A variant is: *Crier comme un sourd*, although deaf people generally  
speak very quietly.]

*Il est toujours du bon avis* = His opinion is always **Aviser**  
good.

*Il y a jour d'avis* = There is no hurry; There is plenty  
of time for consideration.

\**Avis au lecteur* = A note to the reader; A word to the  
wise; *Verb. sap.*

(*Il*) *m'est avis qu'il cherche à vous tromper* =  
Somehow I think he wants to deceive you.

*\*Deux avis valent mieux qu'un* = Two heads are better than one.

[The Greeks said: εἷς ἀνὴρ, οὐδεὶς ἀνὴρ = One man, no man.]

*Sauf avis contraire* = Unless I hear (or, write) to the contrary.

*C'est un avisé compère* = He is a cunning fellow.     **Avoir**

*On y avisera* = We will see to it.

*Il ne s'avise jamais de rien* = He never thinks of anything; He has no initiative.

*On ne s'avise jamais de tout* = One never thinks of everything.

*Ne vous en avisez pas* = You had better not.

*Un fou avise bien un sage* = Good advice often comes whence we do not expect it.

*Un verre de vin avise bien un homme* = A glass of wine puts wit into a man.

[The French use *avoir* frequently where we use *to be*, as in—*Avoir* **Avril**  
*faim, soif, chaud, froid, raison, tort, pitié, honte, peur, soin, besoin, mal* = To be hungry, thirsty, hot, cold, right, wrong, sorry, ashamed, afraid, careful, in want, ill.]

*J'aurai raison de son entêtement* = I will master his obstinacy.

*J'en ai bien envie* = I should like it very much.

*Elle n'a pour tout bien que sa beauté* = She has nothing but her beauty in her favour; Her face is her fortune.

*J'en ai pour deux heures* = I shall be two hours over it.

*J'en ai pour six mois à m'ennuyer* = I am looking forward to (or, in for) six months' boredom.

*Vous avez la parole* = It is your turn to speak.

*Vous avez la main* = It's your turn to play (at cards).

*Vous avez le dé* = It's your turn to play (at dice).

*Il ne fera cela qu'autant que vous l'aurez pour agréable* = He will never think of doing it if you object to it.

*Avoir de quoi* (pop.) = To be in easy circumstances.

*J'ai de quoi payer* = I have enough money to pay.

*Il y a de quoi* = (lit.) There is good reason; (ironic.) There is no reason.

*Je vous demande pardon.—Il n'y a pas de quoi* = I beg your pardon.—Pray do not mention it.

*J'ai beau dire, il en fera à sa tête* = It is of no use my talking, he will do as he likes.

*C'est un homme que j'ai dans la main* = He is a man I hold in the hollow of my hand, *i.e.* I can make him do what I like.

*Qu'avez vous? J'ai que je m'ennuie* = What is the matter with you? The matter is that I am bored to death.

*Vous en aurez* = You will catch it.

*Contre qui en avez-vous?* = Against whom have you a grudge?

*Il n'est rien de tel que d'en avoir* = There is nothing like money to make one respected.

*Quand il n'y en a plus, il y en a encore* = The thing is inexhaustible; It is easy to get more.

*Il n'y a qu'à pleuvoir* = It may happen to rain; What if it rains?

*Je vais lui dire cela.—Non, il n'aurait qu'à se fâcher*  
= I will tell him that.—No, don't, he might get angry.

*C'est un homme comme il n'y en a point* = He is a man who has not his match; There is no equal to him.

*En avril*  
*Ne te découvre pas d'un fil*  
= Change not a clout  
Till May be out.

[En mai  
Fais ce qu'il te plaît.]

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## B.

- B** *Être marqué au b* = To be either hump-backed, one-eyed, lame, or a stutterer.  
[i.e. *bossu, borgne, boiteux, ou bègue.*]
- Bâcler** *Bâcler son ouvrage* = To do one's work quickly and badly; To "polish off" (or, scamp) one's work.  
[Also: *travailler à dépêche-compagnon.*]
- Badiner** \*"*On ne badine pas avec l'amour*" = Love is not to be trifled with.  
[This is the title of one of Alfred de Musset's *Proverbes*. See [Porte](#).]
- Bagage** *Quel est le bagage de cet auteur?* = What works has that author written? What is that author's output?  
*Plier bagage* = To pack up and be off.
- Bagatelle** *Bagatelles que tout cela* = That is all stuff and nonsense.  
*Vive la bagatelle!* = Away with care!
- Bague** *Cette place est une bague au doigt* = That position is a sinecure.  
[*C'est une bague au doigt* is said of any advantageous possession of which one can dispose easily. Quitard derives it from the custom of the seller of land giving to the purchaser as his title a ring on which both had sworn.]

## **Bruit**

*Faire plus de bruit que de besogne* = To be more fussy than industrious.

\**Grand bruit, petite besogne* = The more hurry, the less speed; Great cry, little wool.

\**Qui a bruit de se lever matin peut dormir jusqu'au soir* = A good reputation covers many sins.

*Les tonneaux vides sont ceux qui font le plus de bruit*  
= The worst wheel makes the most noise.

## **Brûler**

*Il s'est brûlé la cervelle* = He blew his brains out.

*Ils tirèrent sur lui à brûle-pourpoint* = They fired at him point-blank (so as to burn his doublet).

*Il m'a posé cette question à brûle-pourpoint* = He asked me that question quite unexpectedly.

*Brûler une station (une étape)* = To run through a station (or, a halting-place) without stopping.

*Brûler le pavé* = To dash along at full speed, to "scorch."

*Brûler à petit feu* = To wait impatiently, to be on thorns.

*Cherchez bien, vous brûlez* = Search well, you are getting warm.

[Said to children who are looking for a hidden object, and are getting near it.]

*Nous avons brûlé nos vaisseaux* = There is no going back now; We mean to fight to the last.

[Agathocles, tyrant of Syracuse, on landing in Africa 317 B.C., burnt his vessels in order to force his soldiers to conquer or to die. William of Normandy (1066) and Cortez (1518) did the same.]

*Un acteur qui brûle les planches* = An actor who plays with spirit, "go."

*Brûler la politesse* = To behave rudely by leaving a person abruptly.

**Buisson**

\**Il n'y a si petit buisson qui ne porte ombre* = There **Buse** is no man, however humble, who cannot aid (or, injure) his superior.

*Trouver buisson creux* = To find the birds flown.

\**On ne saurait faire d'une buse un épervier* = One **But** cannot make a silk purse out of a sow's ear.

[“Que l'en ne puet fere espervier  
En nule guise d'ung busart.”

GUILLAUME DE LORRIS, *Roman de la Rose*,  
3839.

Also: *D'un goujat on ne peut pas faire un gentilhomme* = It takes three generations to make a gentleman; and *D'un sac à charbon il ne saurait sortir blanche farine.*]

*De but en blanc* = Point-blank; Abruptly.

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## C.

- Ça**                    *Ça a sa petite volonté* (fam.) = It has a will of its own (in speaking of children, etc.).  
*C'est toujours ça* = That is something, at any rate.  
*Pas plus que ça?; Rien que ça?* = Is that all?  
[This is generally used ironically: *e.g.* Le cocher m'a demandé vingt francs pour aller de la Place de la Concorde à Longchamp!—Rien que ça?]
- Cabinet**            *Cet avocat a un bon cabinet* = That barrister has a good practice.
- Cachet**             *Courir le cachet* = To go from house to house giving private lessons.  
[This expression comes from the custom of the master giving to the pupil a number of tickets (called *cachets*) at the first lesson, for which the pupil pays, and gives one back at the end of each lesson.]
- Cadet**                *C'est le cadet de mes soucis* = That is the least of my cares; That is the last thing I worry about.
- Cadran**              *Il a fait le tour du cadran* = 1. He has slept the clock round. 2. He has worked for twelve hours at a stretch.
- Cage**                 \**La belle cage ne nourrit pas l'oiseau* = Fine clothes do not fill the stomach.

**Caisse**      *Il tient la caisse* = (lit.) He keeps the cash account;  
(fig.) He holds the purse-strings.

*Il fait la caisse* = He is making up his cash account.

*Quel est l'état de votre caisse?* = How much cash  
have you in hand?

**Cale**      *Être à fond de cale* (fam.) = To be hard up, at the end  
of one's resources.

[Also more pop.: *battre la dèche*. See [Sec](#) and [Argent](#).]

**Campagne**      *En rase* (or, *pleine*) *campagne* = In the open country.

*Battre la campagne*. (See [Battre](#).)

*Se mettre en campagne* = (lit., of a general) To take  
the field; (fig.) To canvass or look out for a post;  
To start working.

**Camus**      *Rendre un homme camus* = To stop a man's mouth;  
To make a man look small.

*Il demeura tout camus* = He had not a word to say  
for himself; He was "stumped."

**Canard**      *Cette nouvelle n'est qu'un canard* = That story is all  
humbug.

[Canard is an absurd tale mocking the credulity of listeners. Littré  
derives the word from the phrase *vendre à quelqu'un un canard à  
moitié* = to half sell a duck to any one, i.e. not to sell it at all, and  
so, to cheat. A *moitié* was suppressed and *un canard* came to mean a  
cheat, a sell. Many other explanations are given of this word.]

**Cane**      *Faire la cane* = To run away; To show the white  
feather.

[This expression literally means to bob down, like a duck, to escape being shot. The verb *caner* (= to funk) is more often used now, or the less familiar *caponner*. “To show the white feather” arises from the fact that white feathers in game-cocks show impurity of breed.] **Capable**

*Il prend un air capable* = He puts on a bumptious **Cape** look.

*C'est un homme capable de tout* = He is a man that would stick at nothing.

*Rire sous cape* (or, *sous sa coiffe*) = To laugh in **Caque** one's sleeve (generally of women. See [Barbe](#).)

*N'avoir que la cape et l'épée* = To be titled but penniless (generally used of young officers who have nothing but their pay).

*Roman de cape et d'épée* = A romantic, melodramatic tale (e.g. DUMAS, *Les Trois Mousquetaires*).

\**La caque sent toujours le hareng* = What is bred in **Caractère** the bone will never come out of the flesh.

["You may break, you may shatter the vase, if you will,  
But the scent of the roses will hang round it still."

MOORE, *Farewell*.]

*Il a le caractère bien fait* = He is always good-**Carat** tempered.

*Il a le caractère mal fait* = He cannot take a joke.

*C'est un sot à vingt-quatre carats* = He is an out-**Carême** and-out fool, an A 1 fool.

["Enfin quoique ignorante à vingt et trois carats."

LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, vii, 15.]



*\*Cela arrive comme mars en carême* = That comes regularly, like clockwork. **Carpe**

*\*Cela arrive comme marée en carême* = That comes very seasonably, just at the right time.

*Une face de carême* = A sad, pale, woe-begone face (like that of one who has fasted all Lent).

*Prêcher sept ans pour un carême* = To do a great deal for little good.

*Muet comme une carpe* = As dumb as an oyster. **Carré**

*Bâiller comme une carpe* = To yawn one's head off.

*Elle fait la carpe pâmée* (fam.) = She turns up the whites of her eyes; She pretends to be ill; She looks like a dying duck in a thunderstorm.

[Also: *Faire des yeux de merlan frit.*]

*Une partie carrée* = A party composed of two ladies and two gentlemen. **Carreau**

*C'est une tête carrée* = He is an obstinate fellow.

*C'est un valet de carreau* = He is a contemptible fellow, a snob. **Carte**

*Coucher sur le carreau* = To sleep on the floor.

*Il l'a laissé sur le carreau* = He killed him (or, left him for dead on the ground).

*Il est resté sur le carreau* = He was killed on the spot, left for dead on the ground.

[Formerly the floors of rooms were paved with square tiles or bricks called *carreaux*. Kitchens are still so paved in France, and often ground-floor rooms in the country.]

*Battre les cartes* = To shuffle the cards.

**Carton**

*Donner les cartes* = To deal the cards.

*Brouiller les caries* = (fig.) To sow discord.

*Elle lui a tiré les cartes* = She told his fortune (by cards).

*Il a vu le dessous des cartes* = He has been behind the scenes; he is in the secret, “in the know.”

*Jouer cartes sur table* = To play openly; To act frankly.

*Donner carte blanche* = To give full permission; To grant a person full liberty to act according to his judgment.

*Je connais la carte du pays* = I know the country well.

*C'est un homme qui ne perd pas la carte* = He is a man who keeps his wits about him, who has an eye to the main chance.

*C'est un château de cartes que cette maison* = This is a jerry-built house.

*Rester dans les cartons* = To be pigeon-holed.

**Cas**

*Des objets de carton* = (fig.) Gimcrack things.

*C'est bien le cas de le dire* = One may indeed say so. **Casser**

*Il n'est pas dans le cas de vous nuire* = He is not in a position to harm you.

*Le cas échéant* = In such a case; If such should be the case.

*C'est le cas ou jamais* = It is now or never.

*Nous en faisons grand cas* = We value it very highly.

*Tout mauvais cas est niable* = A man may be expected to deny a deed that he knows to be wrong.

*Un en-cas* = Something prepared in case of need.

[Formerly this was said of a slight meal placed in a bedroom *in case* one should wake in the night and need food. Now it rather refers to anything that can be used *in case* guests arrive unexpectedly. Also of a parasol that can be used as an umbrella *in case* it rains. The latter is more usually called *un en-tout-cas*.]

*Une noce à tout casser* (pop.) = A rare old **Cataplasme** jollification.

*Vous me cassez la tête avec votre bruit* = You split my head with your noise.

*Je ne me casse pas la tête avec (or, pour) de telles bagatelles* = I don't worry my head (or, rack my brains) over such trifles.

*Il nous cassait l'encensoir sur le nez* = He was smothering us with flatteries.

[To 'incense' any one would be to honour or praise him, but to break the censer against his nose would be overdoing it.]

*Les fatigues ont cassé cet homme* = Hardships have broken that man down.

*J'ai cassé une croûte* = I just had a snack.

*Cet homme casse les vitres* = That man speaks out boldly, to bring matters to a crisis; That man does not pick and choose his words.

*On ne fait pas d'omelettes sans casser des œufs* = Nothing is done without trouble and sacrifice.

[A saying attributed to Napoleon I. in defence of the great mortality caused by his wars.]

*Payer les pots cassés* = To stand the racket.

*Se casser le nez* = 1. To fall on one's face. 2. To knock up against an obstacle. 3. To fail in an enterprise.

*C'est comme un cataplasme sur une jambe de bois* = **Catholique**  
A nod is as good as a wink to a blind horse.

*Cet individu n'a pas l'air catholique* = That man **Cause**  
does not look very trustworthy.

*Votre vin est trop catholique* = Your wine is too weak, (i.e. baptised with water).

*Il parle en connaissance de cause* = He knows what **Caution**  
he is talking about.

*Je ne veux pas y aller et pour cause* = I do not want to go there, and for a very good reason.

*J'ai toujours pris fait et cause pour vous* = I have always stood up for you, taken up the cudgels in your defence.

*Il a eu gain de cause* = He gained the day.

*Un avocat sans cause* = A briefless barrister.

*Vous êtes hors de cause* = You are not concerned in the matter; This has nothing to do with you.

*Il est sujet à caution* = He is not to be relied upon. **Ce**

[*Caution*, meaning "bail," implies that he cannot be trusted except on bail.]

*A ce que je vois* = As far as I can judge.

**Ceinture**

*Ce que je sais, c'est que c'est un voleur* = All I know  
is that he is a thief.

*Sur ce il s'en alla* = After that he went away.

*Ce que c'est que de nous!* = What poor mortals we  
are!

*\*Bonne renommée vaut mieux que ceinture dorée* = **Cela**  
A good name is better than riches; He who has lost  
his reputation is a dead man among the living.

[*Ceinture* here refers to the purse which was in, or attached to, the  
girdle. Compare Proverbs xxii. 1, "A good name is rather to be  
chosen than great riches," and

"The purest treasure mortal times afford  
Is spotless reputation; that away,  
Men are but gilded loam or painted clay."

SHAKESPEARE, *Richard II.* i. 1.]

*C'est parler cela* = That is what I call talking. **Cent**

*C'est ceci, c'est cela* = It is sometimes one thing,  
sometimes another.

*Pour ça, non!* = Not a bit of it; Certainly not.

*Il est comme cela* = That is his way.

*C'est bien comme cela!* = That is just it!!

*C'est cela même!* = That's the very thing!

*Pour cela même* = For that very reason.

*N'est-ce que cela?* = Is that all?

*En un mot comme en cent* = Once and for all. **Cervelle**

*Je vous le donne en cent* = I bet you 100 to 1 you  
will not guess it.

*\*Cent ans bannière, cent ans civière* = Up to-day,  
down to-morrow; Every dog has his day.

[*Bannière* is here used as the mark of nobility. Also: *Aujourd'hui chevalier, demain vacher*. German: *Heute mir, morgen dir*. Latin: *Hodie mihi, cras tibi*.]

*Cent ans de chagrin ne paient pas un sou de dettes* =  
Worrying will not pay your debts.

*Le scélérat se brûla la cervelle* = The scoundrel blew **Chacun**  
his brains out.

[Also, more pop., “se faire sauter le caisson.”]

\**A la cour du roi chacun pour soi* = Every man for **Chair**  
himself and the devil take the hindmost. (See  
[Sauver](#).)

*Chacun cherche son semblable* = Like will to like.  
(See [Pot](#) and [Tel](#).)

[“Entre gens de même nature  
L’amitié se fait et dure  
Mais entre gens de contraire nature  
Ni amour ni amitié dure.”]

*Cela fait venir la chair de poule* = That makes one’s **Chaise**  
flesh creep.

*Je l’ai vu en chair et en os* = I saw him in flesh and  
blood.

*Ni chair ni poisson* = Neither fish, flesh, nor fowl.

*Être assis entre deux chaises* = To fall between two **Chambre**  
stools. (See [Chasser](#).)

*Il y a bien des chambres à louer dans sa tête* = He is **Chameau**  
an empty-headed fellow.

*Rejeter le moucheron et avaler le chameau* = To**Champ**  
strain at a gnat and swallow a camel.

*Il est fou à courir les champs* = He is as mad as a**Chance**  
March hare.

*Nous prendrons la clef des champs* = We shall take  
the key of the street (i.e., run away).

*Un rien le met aux champs* = A trifle throws him into  
a passion, bewilders him.

*Être aux champs* = To be put out, bewildered, angry.

*Prendre du champ* = To take a run (before leap); To  
have room before one (for an effort).

[“Ils prirent du champ et coururent l’un sur l’autre avec furie.”—  
CHATEAUBRIAND, *Dernier des Abencérages*, 185.]

*Chance vaut mieux que bien jouer* = Luck is better**Chandelle**  
than wit or brains.

*Il n’est chance qui ne retourne* = The luck must  
change.

\**A chaque saint sa chandelle* = Honour to whom**Change**  
honour is due; Every lawyer must have his fee.

*Il vous doit une belle chandelle* = He ought to be  
very grateful to you.

[An allusion to the custom of burning candles before the altars of  
Saints, as a mark of gratitude, considered due to them.]

*Voir des chandelles* (or, *mille chandelles*) = “To see  
stars.” (See [Étoile](#).)

*Donner une chandelle à Dieu et une au diable* = To  
try and keep in with both parties.

*Le jeu ne vaut pas la chandelle* = The game is not worth the candle; It is not worth while.

[i.e., when the stakes are not sufficient to pay for the candle burnt during the game.]

\**C'est une économie de bouts de chandelle* = That is penny-wise and pound-foolish; That is spoiling the ship for a ha'porth (halfpennyworth) of tar; That is a cheese-paring policy.

*Brûler la chandelle par les deux bouts* = To burn the candle at both ends.

*Donner le change* = To put off the scent, to mislead. **Changer**

*Vous ne me ferez pas prendre le change* = You will not impose upon me, put me on the wrong scent.

[Expressions taken from hunting, where the dogs leave the track of the game they have raised, to run on another scent.]

*Je lui ai rendu le change* = I paid him back in his own coin. (See [Monnaie](#).)

*Changer son cheval borgne contre un aveugle* = To **Chanson** lose in an exchange.

*Il en a l'air et la chanson* = He looks it every inch; **Chanter** He has both the appearance and the actuality.

*C'est l'air qui fait la chanson* = Words depend much on the tone in which they are spoken; It is not so much what you say as the way in which you say it.

\**Il chante toujours la même chanson* = He is always **Chapeau** harping on the same string.

["Cantilenam eandem canere."]



“Chorda qui semper oberrat eadem.”

HORACE, *Ars Poet.*,  
356.]

\**Tel chante qui ne rit pas* = The heart may be sad  
though the face be gay.

*C'est comme si je chantais* = It is like talking to the  
air, preaching in the desert.

*Je lui ai chanté sa gamme* = I lectured him severely.

*Une porte mal graissée chante* = One must pay well  
to keep persons quiet.

*Elle chante à faire pitié* = She sings most  
wretchedly.

*Chanter juste* = To sing in tune.

*Si ça vous chante* (fam.) = If you are in the mood for  
it.

*Voici la reine, chapeau bas!* = Here is the Queen, **Chapelet**  
hats off.

*Le chapelet commence à se défiler* = The association **Chapon**  
is beginning to break up.

*Défiler* (or, *dire*) *son chapelet* = To say all one has to  
say.

*Il n'a pas gagné cela en disant son chapelet* = He  
did not get that for nothing.

\**Qui chapon mange, chapon lui vient* = He that has **Charbonnier**  
plenty shall have more.

\**Charbonnier est maître chez lui* (or, *chez soi*) = **Charge**  
Every one is master in his own house; An  
Englishman's house is his castle.

[In the *Commentaires de Blaise de Monluc, Maréchal de France* (ed. Alphonse de Ruble, pour la Société de l'Histoire de France, tome iii. p. 482, Paris, 1867), in a remonstrance to the king he says: “car chacun est roy en sa maison, comme respondit le charbonnier à votre ayeul.” M. de Ruble appends this note: “François I<sup>er</sup>, à la suite d’une chasse qui l’avait séparé de sa suite, se perdit dans une forêt et chercha un asile dans la cabane d’un charbonnier. L’homme était absent; le roi ne trouva que la charbonnière, s’empara du meilleur siège et demanda à souper. La femme voulut attendre l’arrivée de son mari. A son retour, celui-ci reprit brusquement son siège et offrit un simple escabeau au roi: ‘Je prendz cette chaise,’ dit-il, ‘parce qu’elle est à moi:

Or, par droit et par raison,  
Chacun est maître en sa maison.’

Le roi, charmé de n’être point reconnu, obéit à son hôte. On soupa d’un quartier de chevreuil tué en cachette, on médit du roi, des tailles qu’il venait d’ordonner et surtout de sa sévérité pour la chasse. Le lendemain, François se fit connaître. Le charbonnier se crut perdu, mais le roi le rassura, et, pour prix de son hospitalité, lui accorda de grandes faveurs, entre autres le droit de chasser. A son retour à la cour, il rapporta le récit de son aventure et surtout le proverbe qu’il venait d’apprendre.” Also in *La Belle Arsène, comédie-féerie de C. S. Favart*, acted before the king in 1773, we find this proverb (Act iv. Sc. 2).]

*Cela est à ma charge* = I have to pay for it; That falls **Charité** on me.

*Cela m’est à charge* = That is a burden to me.

*C’est entendu, à la charge d’autant* (or, *de revanche*)  
= I will do the same for you; One good turn deserves another.

*\*Charité bien ordonnée commence par soi-même* = **Charlemagne**  
Charity begins at home.

[“Proximus sum egomet mihi.” = I myself am nearest to myself.—  
TERENCE.]

*La charité, s’il vous plaît!* = Please give me a penny!

*Faire Charlemagne* = To leave off a winner, without **Charrette** giving one's adversaries a chance of revenge.

[Génin explains this as a shortened form of *faire comme Charlemagne*, who died without losing any of the conquests he had made.]

*Mettre la charrette (or, charrue) devant les bœufs* = **Chasser**  
To put the cart before the horse.

[Lucian says: ἡ ἄμαξα τὸν βοῦν ἔλκει = The waggon drags the ox.]

*Mieux vaut être cheval que charrette* = Better lead than be led.

*Faire un chassé-croisé* = To go to and fro in all **Chat** directions; to exchange places; to play at “puss in the corner.”

“*Chassez le naturel, il revient au galop*” = What is bred in the bone will never come out of the flesh.

[DESTOUCHES, *Le Glorieux*, iii. 5. Comp. HORACE, *Ep. I.*, x. 24: “naturam expellas furca, tamen usque recurret,” and LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, ii. 18:

“Tant le naturel a de force!  
Il se moque de tout...  
Qu'on lui ferme la porte au nez  
Il reviendra par les fenêtres.”

Frederick the Great wrote to Voltaire (19th March 1771): “Chassez les préjugés par la porte, ils reviendront par la fenêtre.”

Also: *Qui naquit chat court après les souris.*]

\**Qui deux choses chasse, ni l'une ni l'autre ne prend*  
= Between two stools one falls to the ground.

*Ne chassez pas deux lièvres à la fois* = Do not have too many irons in the fire.

*Il chasse de race* = He is a chip of the old block.

*Un clou chasse l'autre* = One idea drives away another.

\**A bon chat bon rat* = A Roland for an Oliver; Tit for **Château** tat; Diamond cut diamond.

\**Chat échaudé craint l'eau froide* = A burnt child dreads the fire; Once bit, twice shy.

[The Jewish Rabbis said: "One bitten by a serpent is afraid of a rope's end."

Hesiod says: "Even a fool after suffering gets him knowledge"; the Italians: "Can scotato da l'acqua calda ha paura poi della fredda" = A dog burnt by hot water afterwards fears cold.]

*J'appelle un chat un chat* = I call a spade a spade.  
(See [Appeler](#).)

*Avoir un chat dans la gorge* = To have phlegm (or, frog) in the throat; To be hoarse.

\**Nous avons d'autres chats (or, chiens) à fouetter* = We have other fish to fry.

*Il n'y a pas là de quoi fouetter un chat* = It is not worth getting angry about.

\**Ne réveillons pas le chat qui dort* = Let sleeping dogs lie.

\**Le chat parti les souris dansent* = When the cat's away the mice will play.

\**La nuit tous les chats sont gris* = At night one may easily be mistaken; At night beauty is of no account; When candles are away, all cats are grey.

\**Chat botté n'attrape pas de souris* = A muffled cat catches no mice.

*Comme chat sur braise* = Like a cat on hot bricks.

*Il n'y a pas un chat* = There is not a soul.

*Aller comme un chat maigre* = To run like a lamplighter. (See [Verrier](#).)

*Faire des châteaux en Espagne* = To build castles in **Chaud** the air.

[This expression is found from the thirteenth century. The explanation that would ascribe it to the followers of the Duc d'Anjou when he became Philippe V. of Spain must therefore be incorrect. The phrases "Châteaux en Asie, en Albanie" were also used, so that it comes to mean "to build castles in foreign countries, where one is not," and hence "to indulge in illusions."—LITTRÉ, s.v.

"Chatiaus en Espagne."—GUILLAUME DE LORRIS, *Roman de la Rose*, l. 2530.

"De quoi sert-il de bastir des chasteaux en Espagne puisqu'il faut habiter en France?" *St. François de Sales*, lettre 856.]

*Pleurer à chaudes larmes* = To cry bitterly. **Chaudron**

\**Tomber de fièvre en chaud mal* = To fall out of the frying-pan into the fire.

*Cela ne me fait ni froid ni chaud* = That is indifferent to me.

*Il a les pieds bien chauds* = He is in very easy circumstances.

\**Petit chaudron, grandes oreilles* = Little pitchers **Chausser** have long ears.

Chauffer

*C'est un bain qui chauffe* = There is a shower coming on.

[When it feels close, or when the sun is seen for a few minutes through the clouds, it is looked upon as a sign of rain.]

*Ce n'est pas pour vous que le four chauffe* = All these preparations are not for you.

*Les cordonniers sont les plus mal chaussés* = The **Chauve** shoemaker's wife goes the worst shod.

*Chauve comme mon genou* (fam.) = As bald as a **Chef** coot, as a billiard ball.

*Elle a une grande fortune de son chef* = She has a **Chemin** large fortune in her own right.

*Faire une chose de son chef* = To do a thing on one's own responsibility.

*Chemin faisant* = On the way.

**Cheminée**

*Le chemin de velours* = The primrose path.

*En tout pays il y a une lieue de mauvais chemin* = (fig.) In every enterprise difficulties have to be encountered.

*Il ne faut pas y aller par quatre chemins* = You must not beat about the bush; You must go straight to the point; You must not mince matters; It's no good shilly-shallying.

\**Qui trop se hâte reste en chemin* = The more haste, the less speed; Slow and sure wins the race. (See [Hâte.](#))

\**Le chemin le plus long est souvent le plus court* = The longest way round often proves to be the shortest; A short cut may be a very long way home.

*Prendre le chemin de l'école* (or, *des écoliers*) = To take the longest way (a roundabout way).

\**À chemin battu il ne croît pas d’herbe* = (fig.) There is no profit in an affair in which many are engaged.

*Se frayer un chemin avec les coudes* = To elbow one’s way through a crowd.

*Il faut faire une croix à la cheminée* = “We must **Cheval** chalk it up” (of an event that seldom happens.)

*Sous le manteau de la cheminée* = Secretly, *sub rosa*.

\**À cheval donné on ne regarde pas à la bride* (or, *à **Chevalier** la dent*) = One does not look a gift-horse in the mouth.

[Late Latin: “Si quis det mannos, ne quaere in dentibus annos.”]

*On loge à pied et à cheval* = Good entertainment (accommodation) for man and beast.

*L’œil du maître engraisse le cheval* = Matters prosper under the master’s eye.

[“Il n’est pour voir que l’œil du maître.”]

LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, iv.  
21.]

*Il est aisé d’aller à pied quand on tient son cheval par la bride* = It is easy to stoop from state when that state can be resumed at will.

*Il n’est si bon cheval qui ne bronche* = The best horse may stumble; Accidents will happen.

[Also: *Il n’est si bon charretier qui ne verse*.]

*Il a changé son cheval borgne contre un aveugle* = He has changed for the worse; He has made a bad bargain.

*Monter sur ses grands chevaux* = To ride the high horse.

[A reference to the big war horses used by knights in battle.]

*Je lui ai écrit une lettre à cheval* = I wrote him a severe letter.

*Il est toujours à cheval sur l'étiquette* = He is a stickler for etiquette.

*Il est bon cheval de trompette* = He is not easily dismayed.

*Un cheval à deux fins* = A horse for riding or driving.

*J'ai une fièvre de cheval* = I am in a high fever.

*Un chevalier d'industrie* = A swindler, a man who **Cheveux** lives by his wits.

*Cette comparaison est tirée par les cheveux* = That **Cheville** comparison is somewhat far-fetched.

*On ne peut prendre aux cheveux un homme rasé* =  
One cannot get blood from a stone. (See [Huile](#).)

*En cheveux* (of a woman) = Bareheaded.

[Of a man: *tête nue*.]

*Les cheveux en brosse* = Hair cut short (standing up like the bristles of a brush).

*Prendre l'occasion aux cheveux* = To take time by the forelock. (See [Balle](#).)

*Avoir mal aux cheveux* (fam.) = To have a head (*i.e.* a head-ache in the morning after a drinking bout.)

*Vous ne lui allez pas à la cheville* = You are a pigmy **Chèvre** compared with him; You are no match for him at all.

*La cheville ouvrière* = The mainspring, pivot.



\**Ménager la chèvre et le chou* = To run with the hare**Chez**  
and hunt with the hounds.

[The French refers to the tale of the man in charge of a wolf, a goat, and a cabbage. He came to a river which he had to cross; but the ferry-boat was so small that he could only take one of his charges with him. His difficulty was to get them across, for if he left the wolf and goat together, the wolf would eat the goat; and if he left the goat with the cabbage the goat would eat it.]

\**Où la chèvre est attachée il faut qu'elle brouste* =  
One must put up with the inconveniences of one's  
position if one can get nothing better; We must not  
expect more from life than life can give us.

\**Il n'y a pas de petit chez soi* = There is no place**Chien**  
like home; Home is home, be it ever so humble;  
East, west, home is best.

[Also: *Un petit chez soi vaut mieux qu'un grand chez les autres.*

“My house, my house, though thou art small,  
Thou art to me the Escoriall.”

GEORGE HERBERT, *Jacula Prudentium*.]

*C'est le chien de Jean de Nivelle, il s'enfuit quand***Chiffon**  
*on l'appelle* = The more you call him, the more he  
runs away, like John de Nivelle's dog.

[Jean de Nivelle was the eldest son of Jean II., Duc de Montmorency, and was born about 1423. Having been summoned to appear before the Judges at Paris for having espoused the cause of the Duke of Burgundy against the wishes of the king, Louis XI., and of his father, who disinherited him, he fled to Flanders, where his wife had property. He therefore became an object of scorn to the people for refusing to answer the summons of his king, and they called him *chien*: the saying ought to run: *C'est ce chien de Jean de Nivelle*. La Fontaine evidently thought the phrase referred to a real dog when he wrote:—

“Une traîtresse voix bien souvent vous appelle,  
Ne vous pressez donc nullement,  
Ce n'était pas un sot, non, non et croyez m'en.  
Que le chien de Jean de Nivelle.”

Compare the Italian:—

Far come il can d'Arloito que chiamoto se la batte.]

*\*Qui veut noyer son chien l'accuse de la rage* =  
Give your dog a bad name and hang him.

[Quos Jupiter vult perdere prius dementat.]

*Je jette ma langue aux chiens* = I give it up (of  
riddles, etc.).

[Also: *Je donne ma langue aux chats*.]

*Nous sommes sortis entre chien et loup* = We went  
out at dusk, between the lights.

[i.e. when you could easily mistake a wolf for a dog; or, as others say,  
between the time when the watch-dog is let loose and the time when  
the wolf comes out of the wood.]

*Un chien regarde bien un évêque* = A cat may look at  
a king.

*Il fait un chien de temps* (or, *un temps de chien*)  
(fam.) = It is wretched weather.

*C'est saint Roch et son chien que ces deux  
personnes-là* = These two persons are inseparable.

*\*Bon chien chasse de race* = Like sire, like son; Cat  
after kind.

*C'est le chien du jardinier qui ne mange pas de  
choux et n'en laisse pas manger aux autres* = He is  
a dog in the manger.

*Écorcher son chien pour en avoir la peau* = To  
sacrifice something important for a small return.

*Chien qui aboie ne mord pas* = His bark is worse  
than his bite.

[Also: *Tel fiert qui ne tue pas*, and *Chat miauteur ne fut jamais bon  
chasseur, non plus qu'homme sage caqueteur*.]

*Autant vaut être mordu d'un chien que d'une chienne*  
= As well be hanged for a sheep as a lamb; What is  
the use of choosing between two evils?

*On l'a reçu comme un chien dans un jeu de quilles* =  
He was as welcome as a dog at a wedding.

*\*Il ne faut pas se moquer des chiens (or, du loup)  
avant qu'on ne soit hors du bois* = Do not holloa  
before you are out of the wood.

*Il n'attache pas ses chiens avec des saucisses* = He is  
a regular miser.

*Chien hargneux a toujours l'oreille déchirée* =  
Quarrelsome folk are always in the wars.

*Jamais bon chien n'a rongé bon os* = A good dog  
rarely gets a good bone; Men rarely get their  
deserts.

*Se regarder en chiens de faïence* = To look at one  
another without talking (like stuck pigs).

*Nous causions chiffons (of women)* = We were **Chiffonner**  
chattering about dress.

*Elle a une petite mine chiffonnée* = She has irregular **Chômer**  
features, but her expression is pleasing.

*\*Chômer les fêtes avant qu'elles ne soient venues* = **Chose**  
To count one's chickens before they are hatched.

[“Laissons venir la fête avant que la chômer.”

MOLIÈRE, *Le Dépit Amoureux*, i.  
1.]

*C'est un saint qu'on ne chôme point* = He is in no  
great repute.

[“L'honneur est un vieux saint que l'on ne chôme plus.”

RÉGNIER, *Satires*, xiii.]

*Dites bien des choses de ma part à votre frère* = **Chou**  
Remember me kindly to your brother.

*Rester tout chose* = To be confused.

*Il était tout chose* = He was out of sorts; out of spirits; cast down.

*Monsieur Chose* (or, *Machin*) = “Mr. What’s-his-name.”

*On l’envoya planter ses choux* = He was dismissed. **Ciel**

*Aller planter ses choux* (or, *garder les dindons*) = To retire into the country.

*Chou pour chou* = Taking one thing with another.

[The whole expression is: *Chou pour chou, Aubervilliers vaut bien Paris* = Aubervilliers is as good as Paris, if it come to counting cabbages, i.e., each thing has its particular merits. Aubervilliers is a suburb of Paris, noted for its market gardens.]

*Bête comme (un) chou (un pot, une cruche, une oie)*  
= As stupid as an owl.

*Mon petit chou* = My little darling.

[This has nothing to do with a cabbage, but with a kind of puff pastry filled with cream, in the shape of a cabbage.]

*Faire ses choux gras d’une chose* = To enjoy a thing that others despise.

*Remuer ciel et terre* = To move heaven and earth; To **Circuler** leave no stone unturned.

*Circulez, Messieurs!* = Move on, please! (cry of **Clair** policemen).

*Parler clair et net* = To speak plainly. **Classe**

*Je n’y vois pas clair* = I cannot see, it is too dark.

*Clair comme le jour* (or, *comme le soleil en plein midi*) = As plain as a pikestaff; As clear as noonday.

*À la rentrée des classes* = When school reopens. **Clef**

*Mettre la clef sous la porte* = To run away from one's creditors; "To bolt."

*La clef dont on se sert est toujours claire* = One does not get rusty in what one does every day.

*Un pas de clerc* = A blunder; A false step. **Cliché**

*Il ne faut pas parler latin devant les clercs* = Do not correct a specialist on his subject.

[“Les plus grands clercs ne sont pas les plus fins.”

RÉGNIER, *Satires*, iii.]

*Ses plaisanteries ne sont que des clichés* = His jokes are stereotyped. **Clin**

*En un clin d’œil* = In a twinkling. **Cloche**

\**Qui n’entend qu’une cloche n’entend qu’un son* = **Clocher (subst.)**  
One should hear both sides of a question.

*Il est temps de fondre la cloche* = The time for action has arrived.

*Déménager à la cloche de bois* (fam.) = To shoot the moon; To leave a house without paying one's rent or one's creditors.

*Il n'a jamais perdu son clocher de vue* = He has **Clocher (verb)**  
never been out of his parish.

*Il faut placer le clocher au milieu du village* = What  
is meant for the benefit of all should be within  
reach of all.

[e.g. a lamp in the middle of the table.]

*Avoir la maladie du clocher* = To be homesick.

[Also more often: *Avoir le mal du pays*.]

*Ce n'est pas mal, mais il y a encore quelque chose* **Clou**  
*qui cloche* = It is not bad, but there is still  
something wrong.

\**Toute comparaison cloche* [or, *pèche*] =  
Comparisons are odious.

*Cela ne vaut pas un clou à soufflet* = That is not **Cocagne**  
worth a straw (lit. a tin-tack).

*Je lui ai rivé son clou* (pop.) = I shut his mouth; That  
was a poser for him.

[“Vous avez fort bien fait de lui river son clou.”

REGNARD, *Le Distant*, iv.  
7.]

*Un clou chasse l'autre* = One idea drives away  
another.

*Le clou de l'Exposition* = The chief attraction of the  
Exhibition.

*C'est un pays de cocagne* = It is a land flowing with **Coche**  
milk and honey.

[“Paris est pour le riche un pays de cocagne;  
Sans sortir de la ville il trouve la campagne.”

BOILEAU, *Satires*,  
vi.]

*Le mât de cocagne* = The greasy pole.

*C'est la mouche du coche* = He is a regular **Cochon** busybody.

[LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, vii. 9, imitated from Æsop.]

*Nous n'avons pas gardé les cochons ensemble* (pop.) **Cœur**  
= We have not been dragged up together.

[The reply to a man who presumes upon acquaintance, and needs putting down.]

*À contre cœur* = Reluctantly.

**Coiffer**

*À cœur joie* = To one's heart's content.

*De gaieté de cœur* = Out of sheer wantonness.

*Il l'a fait de bon cœur* = He did it willingly.

*Dîner par cœur* = To go without a dinner; To dine with Duke Humphrey.

[Humphrey, Duke of Gloucester, son of Henry IV., was renowned for his hospitality. At his death it was reported that he would have a monument in S. Paul's, but he was buried at S. Alban's Abbey. S. Paul's was at that time the common lounge of the town, and when the promenaders left for dinner, those who had no dinner to go to, used to say they would stay behind and look for the monument of the Good Duke. A similar saying was, "To sup with Sir Thomas Gresham," the Exchange, built by him, being a place of resort.]

*Vous l'avez blessé au cœur* = You have wounded his feelings.

*C'est un crève cœur* = It is a heart-rending thing.

\**Loin des yeux, loin du cœur* = Out of sight, out of mind.

*Il a cela à cœur* = 1. He is striving hard to do it. 2. He takes a lively interest in it.

*Cela me tient au cœur* = I have set my heart upon it.

*Il a mal au cœur* = He is feeling sick.

*Il a une maladie de cœur* = He has heart disease.

*Elle fait la bouche en cœur* = She puts on a captivating look; She purses up her lips.

*Elle a le cœur gros* = She is ready to cry; She is heavy-hearted.

*Si le cœur vous en dit* = If you feel like it; If you have a mind to.

*Je veux en avoir le cœur net* = I must clear that up.

*Il a le cœur sur les lèvres* = 1. He always says what he thinks (and this is always something good and kind); He is open-hearted. 2. He feels sick.

*Être plein de cœur* = To be full of generosity; To be noble-minded; To have a high sense of one's duties towards others.

*Avoir le cœur sur la main* = To be open-hearted, frank.

*Un serrement de cœur* = A sinking at the heart; A feeling of oppression and sadness.

*Voilà l'homme dont elle est coiffée* = There is the **Coin** man with whom she is smitten.

*Être né coiffé* = To be born with a silver spoon in one's mouth (literally, with a caul).

*Coiffer sainte Catherine* = To remain an old maid.

*Cet homme mourra au coin d'un bois (or, d'une **Collier** haie)* = That man will die in a ditch.



*Il est franc du collier* = (of a horse) He pulls freely; **Comble**  
(of a man) He never shirks his work.

*Reprendre le collier de misère* = To return to  
drudgery, to the old routine.

*Le feu détruisit le bâtiment de fond en comble* = The **Comité**  
fire completely gutted the building.

*Elle est au comble de ses désirs* = She is at the very  
height of her wishes.

*Pour comble de malheur, il tomba malade* = To  
crown his misfortune, he fell ill.

*Venez demain, nous serons en petit comité* = Come **Comme**  
to-morrow, there will be only a few intimate  
friends.

*Comme ci, comme ça* = So-so; indifferently. **Commencer**

*Je ne l'ai pas dit, mais c'est tout comme* = I did not  
say so, but it is just as if I did.

*C'est tout comme* = It comes to the same thing.

*\*N'a pas fait qui commence* = The beginning is not **Commode**  
everything.

[“Qui commence le mieux ne fait rien s'il n'achève.”

CORNEILLE.  
]

*A moitié fait qui commence bien* = Well begun is half  
done; A good beginning is half the battle.

[“Unes vespres bien sonnées sont à demy dictes.”

RABELAIS, *Gargantua*,  
cxl.

Also: *Matines bien sonnées sont à moitié dites.*

*Barbe bien savonnée est à moitié rasée.*]

\**Qui commence mal finit mal* = A bad day never has a good night.

*Le patron n'est pas commode* (fam.) = The master **Compagnie** (boss) knows all our tricks, is not easily taken in, is very strict, is not an easy customer to deal with.

*Il m'a faussé compagnie* = He gave me the slip; He **Compagnon** did not keep his appointment.

*Vous me traitez comme si j'étais compagnie* = You treat me as if I were somebody.

*Il n'y a si bonne compagnie qui ne se quitte* = The best of friends must part.

*Traiter quelqu'un de pair à compagnon* = To treat **Compas** any one as an equal; To be "hail-fellow-well-met" (cheek by jowl) with any one.

\**Qui a compagnon a maître* = One is often obliged to give way to the wishes of those with whom one is associated.

*Avoir le compas dans l'œil* (fam.) = To have a good **Compère** eye for distances.

*C'est un rusé compère* = He is a sly dog, a cunning **Compliment** old fox. (See [Fin](#) and [Mouche](#).)

[Other equivalents are: *un fin* (or, *fûté*) *matois* (vide MOLIÈRE, *George Dandin*, i. 2, *ad fin.*), *une fine mouche*.]

*Sans compliment* = Really; sincerely; I mean really  
what I say. **Compte**

*Voici votre argent, voyez si vous avez votre compte* = **Compter**  
Here is your money, see if it is right.

*Erreur n'est pas compte* = Errors excepted.

*Je renonce à ce commerce, car je n'y trouve pas mon compte* = I am giving up this business, for I make nothing by it.

*Ne l'offensez pas, car vous n'y trouverez pas votre compte* = Do not offend him, for you would get more than you cared for.

*Nous nous amusons à bon compte* = We amuse ourselves at a small cost.

*Vous êtes loin du compte* = You are out in your reckoning.

*On peut toujours à bon compte revenir* = There is no harm in examining an account twice.

*Je mets cela en ligne de compte* = I take that into account.

*Faisons un compte rond* = Let us make it even money.

*Pour se rendre compte de la chose* = To get a clear idea of the matter.

*Nous sommes de compte à demi dans l'entreprise* = We are partners on equal terms in the venture; We are going halves in the venture.

*À chacun son compte* = To give every one his due.

*Au bout du compte* = Upon the whole; After all.

*Enfin de compte* = (lit.) When the addition is made;  
(fig.) When all is told; When all is said and done.

*Il a son compte* (or, *Son compte est réglé*) = 1. (lit.)  
He has his due. 2. (pop.) He is done for. (See  
[Affaire](#).)

*Il lui compte les morceaux* = He grudges him the  
very food he eats.

\**Qui compte sans son hôte compte deux fois* = He  
who reckons without his host must reckon again;  
Don't count your chickens before they are hatched.  
(See [Chômer](#) and [Peau](#).)

*Comptez dessus* = Depend upon it.

*Vous pouvez faire des commandes en mon nom*  
*jusqu'à concurrence de 5,000 francs* = You can  
order goods in my name to the amount of £200.

*Il conduit bien sa barque* = (fig.) He plays his cards  
well.

*Tous ses camarades lui firent la conduite* = All his  
companions saw him off.

*C'est le diable à confesser* = It is terribly hard to do. **Confession**

*On lui donnerait le bon Dieu sans confession* = They  
would trust him to any extent (because of his  
saintly appearance).

*En connaissance de cause* = Knowingly.

**Connaître**

*Je suis en pays de connaissance* = I am among people I know, among old friends.

*Il est connu comme le loup blanc* = He is known to **Conseil** everybody.

*Il gagne à être connu* = He improves upon acquaintance.

*Je ne le connais ni d'Ève ni d'Adam* = I do not know him from Adam.

*Je ne le connais ni de près ni de loin* = I do not know him at all.

*En chiffres connus* = In plain figures.

*Vous y connaissez-vous en vins?* = Are you a judge of wine?

*Je m'y connais* = I understand all about it; I am an authority on it.

*Connu!* (fam.) = That is an old tale.

*Je la connais, celle-là* (pop.) = That is nothing new; I've been "had" before.

*\*À parti pris pas de conseil* = Advice is useless to **Conseiller** one who has made up his mind.

*\*La nuit porte conseil* = Sleep upon it; Time will show a plan.

*Il a bientôt assemblé son conseil* = He makes up his mind without consulting any one.

*"Aimez qu'on vous conseille et non pas qu'on vous* **Consentir** *loue"* = Prefer advice to praise.

[BOILEAU, *Art Poétique*, i. 192.]

*\*Qui ne dit mot consent* = Silence gives consent. **Conséquence**

*Cela ne tire pas à conséquence* = That is of no importance. **Conte**

*Des contes à dormir debout* = Tedious, nonsensical tales; Old wives' tales. **Contentement**

*\*Contentement passe richesse* = Enough is as good as a feast. **Conter**

*Il vous en conte de belles* = He is deceiving you finely; He is telling you fine tales. **Contrôle**

*Vous êtes porté sur le contrôle* = Your name is placed on the roll. **Contrôler**

*Une chaîne contrôlée* = A hall-marked chain. **Convertir**

*Vous prêchez un converti* = You are talking to a man who thinks with you. **Coq**

*Il est comme un coq en paille* = He is in clover. **Coquille**

[Lit. one kept separately from the others to be fattened; *paille* is its food. *Comme rats en paille* is sometimes used.]

*Il est le coq du village* = He is the cock of the walk.

*Des coq-à-l'âne* = Cock and bull stories; Disconnected rigmaroles.

*À qui vendez-vous vos coquilles?* = Tell that to the **Cor** marines. (See [Autre](#).)

[CHARLES D'ORLÉANS, *Rondeau*, 148.]

*Rentrer dans sa coquille* = To draw in one's horns.

*Il fait bien valoir ses coquilles* = He praises his goods too much.

*À cor et à cri* = With hue and cry; Vehemently. **Corde**

*Demander à cor et à cri* = To clamour for.

*Être au bout de sa corde* (or, *son rouleau*) = To be at **Cordeau** the end of one's tether; To have no more to say.

*Vous verrez beau jeu si la corde ne rompt* = You will see fine fun if no accident happens, if no hitch occurs.

*Cette affaire a passé à fleur de corde* = That business only just succeeded.

*Cet homme file sa corde* = That man will bring himself to the gallows.

*Il ne faut pas parler de corde dans la maison d'un pendu* = We must not make personal remarks; We must not allude to the skeleton in the cupboard. (See [Boiteux](#).)

*Il a de la corde de pendu dans sa poche* = He has the devil's own luck.

[A piece of the rope with which a man had been hanged was, and is even now, considered as a charm against ill-luck. Archbishop Trench adduces other proverbs in reference to the man whose luck never forsakes him, so that from the very things which would be another man's ruin, he extricates himself not only without harm but with credit: *e.g.* the Arabic: "Cast him into the Nile, and he will come up with a fish in his mouth"; the German: "Würf er einen

Groschen aufs Dach, fiel ihm ein Taler herunter” = If he threw a penny on to the roof, a dollar would come back to him.]

*Il tient la corde* = He is leading; He is first favourite.

*Vous touchez la corde sensible* = You are touching the sore point.

*Ne touchez pas cette corde* = (fig.) Do not speak of that.

*Cela est usé jusqu’à la corde* = (lit.) That is worn threadbare; (fig.) That is thoroughly hackneyed.

*Aux États-Unis les rues sont tirées au cordeau* = In **Cordon** the United States the streets are perfectly straight.

*Cordon, s’il vous plaît* = Open the door, please (to **Corne** porters in Paris).

*Ne faites pas de cornes à ce livre* = Do not dog’s-ear **Corneilles** that book.

*Bayer aux corneilles* = To stare (or, gape) about **Corps** vacantly.

*C’est un drôle de corps* = He is an odd fellow, a **Corsaire** queer fish.

*Nous verrons ce qu’il a dans le corps* = We will see what he is made of.

*Il s’est jeté à corps perdu dans cette affaire* = He threw himself headlong (or, with might and main) into the matter.

*Je le saisis à bras le corps* = I seized him round the waist (in a struggle).



*Ils se sont battus corps à corps* = They fought hand to hand.

*Je l'ai fait à mon corps défendant* = I did it reluctantly, in self-defence.

*Prendre du corps* = To get fat.

*Il a l'âme chevillée dans le corps* = He has as many lives as a cat.

\**À corsaire, corsaire et demi* = Set a thief to catch a **Corvée** thief.

[“Ars deluditur arte.”—CATO.

“A trompeur, trompeur et demy.”—CHARLES D'ORLÉANS, *Rondel*, 46.]

\**Corsaires contre corsaires ne font pas leurs affaires*  
= Dog does not eat dog. (See [Loup](#).)

[“Corsaires contre corsaires,

L'un l'autre s'attaquant ne font pas leurs affaires.”—

LA FONTAINE, *Tribut envoyé par les animaux à Alexandre*, imitating R  gnier, *Satire* xii., *ad fin.*, who took it from the Spanish *De corsario a corsario no se llevan que los barriles*.]

*C'est une vraie corv  e!* = What a nuisance! What a **C  te** bore!

[*Corv  e* originally referred to feudal forced labour. It is now a military term, and means “fatigue duty”; hence, any unpleasant task.]

*On lui compterait les c  tes* = He is nothing but skin **C  t  ** and bone.

*  tre sur le c  t  * (or, *flanc*) = To be on one's back, ill. **Coton**

*Mettre les rieurs de son c  t  * = To turn the laugh against a man.

*Vous   tes du bon c  t  * = You are on the right side.

*Vous êtes du côté du manche* = You are on the winning side.

*Donner à côté* = To miss the mark.

*Depuis sa faillite il file un mauvais coton* (fam.) = **Coucher**  
Since his failure, his health (or, reputation) has entirely broken down.

*On est plus couché que debout* = Life is short **Coude**  
compared with eternity.

*Je l'ai couché en joue* = I aimed at him.

*Coucher dans son fourreau* = To go to sleep without undressing; To turn in all standing (nav.).

*\*Comme on fait son lit, on se couche* = As you make your bed, so you must lie on it.

*Se coucher comme les poules* = To go to bed with the sun, very early.

*Coucher sur la dure* = To lie on the ground, on the floor.

*Il ne se mouche pas du coude* (fam.) = 1. He is no **Coudée** fool. 2. He does things in grand style. (See [Pied](#).)

*Il a mal au coude* (fam.) = He is very lazy. (See [Main](#).)

*Avoir les coudées franches* = (lit.) To have elbow-**Coudre** room; (fig.) To have full scope.

*On ne sait quelle pièce y coudre* = One does not **Coule** know how to prevent (or, cure) it.

*C'est un homme à la coule* (pop.) = He is a smart, **Couler** knowing chap.

[Compare: *Il la connaît dans les coins, celui-là* = He knows his business in every corner.]

*Ce qu'il dit coule de source* = What he says comes **Coulisse** from the heart, comes fluently from his lips.

*Cela coule de source* = That follows naturally.

*Couler à fond* = (of ships) To founder; (of persons) To be ruined.

*\*Il faut laisser couler l'eau* = What can't be cured must be endured.

*Faire les yeux en coulisse* = To make sheep's eyes; **Coup** To ogle.

*\*Faire d'une pierre deux coups* = To kill two birds **Coupe** with one stone.

*Cette démarche a porté coup* = That step told, had its effect.

*Sans coup férir* = Without striking a blow.

*Il a fait un bon coup* = He has made a good bargain.

*Il vient de faire un mauvais coup* = He has just committed a crime.

*Pour le coup il ne m'échappera pas* = This time he will not escape me.

*J'irai à coup sûr* = I shall go to a certainty.

*C'est donner un coup d'épée dans l'eau* = It is an unsuccessful attempt. (See [Eau](#).)

*Il m'a porté un coup fourré* = He struck me a blow in the dark.

[This is a term derived from fencing; *un coup fourré* is a blow struck at an adversary at the same moment that he strikes.]

*Le coup vaut la balle* = It is worth trying.

*Il faut toujours qu'elle donne son coup de patte* = She always makes sarcastic (or, unpleasant) remarks.

*C'est un coup monté* = It is a pre-arranged affair.

*On lui a monté le coup* = They induced him to do it; They deceived him.

*Il a bu un coup de trop* = He has had a drop too much.

*C'est venu après coup* = It came too late, after the event.

*Faire les cent coups* = To amuse oneself noisily; To play all sorts of tricks.

*Être aux cent coups* = To be half mad (distracted) with anxiety; To be in the greatest difficulties.

*C'est un coup qui porte* = That is a home-thrust.

*Avoir un coup de marteau* = To be a little touched.

*J'ai écrit trois lettres coup sur coup* = I wrote three letters one after the other.

*Un coup de sang* = A rush of blood to the head.

*Un coup de Jarnac* = A treacherous blow; A blow below the belt.

[In a duel before the whole Court in 1547, Gui Chabot, Seigneur de Jarnac, wounded his adversary, La Châtaigneraie, with an unfair stroke. La Châtaigneraie refused to survive such an affront, tore off the bandages placed over his wound, and bled to death.]

*Un coup de fouet* = (lit.) A crack of a whip; (fig.) A sudden contraction of the muscles of the leg (or

back).

*Un coup d'état* = A sudden, unexpected act of policy;  
A violent change in the Government (*e.g.* 18  
brumaire 1799, or 2 décembre 1851).

*Un coup de fion* (fam.) = A finishing touch.

*Donner le coup de grâce* = To give the finishing  
stroke.

*Il gagna mille francs tout d'un coup* = He won £40  
at one shot, all at once, at one "go."

*Il s'en alla tout à coup* = He went away suddenly,  
abruptly.

[*Tout d'un coup* and *tout à coup* are frequently used indiscriminately,  
even by French people.]

*Un coup de tête* = A moment of passion; a rash  
action.

*Donner un coup de main* = To give a helping hand.

*J'ai manqué mon coup* = I missed my shot; I failed.

*Ils l'ont moulu de coups* = They beat him black and  
blue.

[A well-known quotation from Corneille runs:

"Mes pareils à deux fois ne se font pas connaître  
Et pour leurs coups d'essai veulent des coups de maître."—  
*Le Cid*, ii. 2.]

\**Il y a loin de la coupe aux lèvres* = There is many a **Couper**  
slip 'twixt the cup and the lip.

[The Greek πολλά μεταξύ πέλει κύλικος καὶ χεῖλεος ἄκρου is said to  
have had its origin in the following circumstances:—Anceaus, an  
ancient King of Samos, treated with extreme cruelty his slaves who  
were planting a vineyard for him; until at length one more ill-used  
than the rest prophesied that for his cruelty he should never drink of  
its wine. When the first vintage was over the master bade this slave  
fill him a goblet, and, taking it in his hands, he taunted him with the  
failure of his prophecy. The slave answered with these words; and  
as he was speaking news was brought of a huge wild boar that was

wasting the vineyard. Setting down the untasted cup and snatching up a spear the master went out to meet the wild boar and was slain in the encounter. Compare the Latin: *Inter calicem et os multa cadunt*; and the Spanish: *De la mano a la boca se pierde la sopa*.

Other variants in French are:

*Entre la bouche et le verre  
Le vin souvent tombe à terre.  
Vin versé n'est pas avalé.  
En amour, en cour, et à la chasse.  
Chacun ne prend ce qu'il pourchasse.*]

*Mettre en coupe réglée* = (lit.) To cut down periodically (of forests); (fig.) To lay regularly under contribution.

*Il s'est coupé dans ses réponses* = He contradicted **Courage** himself in his answers.

*Il lui a coupé la parole* = He interrupted him.

*Son père lui a coupé les vivres* = His father stopped his allowance.

*Ce verre de bière m'a coupé les jambes* = My legs feel shaky after that glass of beer.

*Couper un cheveu en quatre* = To split hairs.

*Coupons le câble* = Let us take the decisive step.

[Sieyès, June 10, 1789.]

*Cela lui a coupé le sifflet* (pop.) = That stopped his mouth; That shut him up.

*Je vais y couper* (pop.) = I am going to “cut” that; I am not going to do it.

*Prenez votre courage à deux mains* = Summon up all **Courant** your courage.

*Courage! tout finira bien* = Cheer up! all will yet be well.

*Je vous écrirai fin courant* (commercial) = I will **Courir** write to you at the end of the present month.

*Je ne suis pas au courant de l'affaire* = I have not the latest information on the point; I am not up (well posted) in the matter.

*Par le temps qui court* = Nowadays; As times go. **Courrier**

*Être fou à courir les champs* = To be as mad as a March hare.

*Nous courons même fortune* = We are rowing in the same boat.

*“Rien ne sert de courir, il faut partir à point”* = It is no good hurrying if you have not started in time.

[LA FONTAINE, *Le lièvre et la tortue*, vi. 10.]

*Répondez par retour du courrier* = Answer by return **Courroie** of post.

*Faire son courrier* (commercial) = To write one's letters.

*Il faut lui serrer la courroie* = We must curtail his **Cours** allowance; We must keep him on short commons.

*Faire du cuir d'autrui large courroie* = To be generous with other people's money.

*Les pièces des États du Pape n'ont plus cours* = The **Court** coins of the Papal States are no longer legal tender.

*Un capitaine au long cours* = A captain of a trading vessel going to foreign ports.

*Je suis resté court* = I did not know what to say. **Couteau**

*Je l'ai pris à court* = I took him unawares.

*Il se trouve à court (d'argent)* = He is short of money.

*Dites cela tout court* = Say that and no more.

*Il l'a appelé Jean tout court* = He called him simply (or, just) John (without Mr. or surname).

*Ils sont à couteaux tirés* = They are at daggers drawn. **Coûter**

[Formerly: *Ils en sont aux couteaux tirés.*]

*Aller en Flandre sans couteau* = To embark in an enterprise without the necessary resources.

[Also: *Aller aux mûres sans crochet.*]

*C'est comme le couteau de Jeannot* = That is like the Irishman's gun (said of anything that has been mended so often as to have nothing of the original left).

*Rien ne lui coûte* = He sticks at nothing; He spares no trouble. **Coutume**

*Coûte que coûte* = Cost what it may.

*Coûter les yeux de la tête* = To cost a small fortune, a fearful lot of money.

*\*Une fois n'est pas coutume* = It is only this once; **Coutumier**  
One swallow does not make a summer; Once does not count.



*Il est coutumier du fait* = It is not the first time he **Couture** has done it.

*Ils étaient battus à plate couture* = They were beaten **Couvercle** hollow.

*Couvercle digne du chaudron* = The lid matches the **Couvert** caldron; They are a precious pair; *Arcades ambo*.

*Mettez le couvert* = Lay the cloth (for dinner). **Cracher**

*Mettez un couvert de plus* = Put another knife and fork (for another guest); Lay for one more.

*C'est son père tout craché* (fam.) = He is the very **Crémaillère** spit (or, less fam., image) of his father.

*Il a craché en l'air et ça lui est retombé sur le nez* (pop.) = He wished to do harm to another but it recoiled on himself.

*Il ne crache pas dessus* = He does not despise it; He likes it very much.

*Pendre la crémaillère* = To give a house warming. **Crever**

[Crémaillère = tige de fer suspendue au dessus du foyer d'une cheminée garnie de crans, qui permettent de la fixer plus ou moins haut, et terminée par un bout recourbé auquel on accroche une marmite. Compare Longfellow's poem "The Hanging of the Crane."]

*Le roi Jean a crevé les yeux à Arthur* = King John **Cri** caused Arthur's eyes to be put out.

*Je ne voyais pas mon livre, cependant il me crevait les yeux* = I did not see my book, yet it was staring me in the face (right under my nose).

*Il n'y a qu'un cri sur son compte* = There is only one **Cribler** opinion about him.

*Elle poussa les hauts cris* = She screamed at the top of her voice; She complained loudly.

*C'est le dernier cri* = It is the last thing out.

*Criblé de mitraille* = Riddled with grape-shot. **Crier**

*Criblé de dettes* = Over head and ears in debt.

*Crier famine sur un tas de blé* = To cry out for what **Crin** one has in plenty.

*Plumer la poule sans la faire crier* = To fleece a person adroitly, without his perceiving it.

*Un républicain à tous crins* = Every inch a **Crochet** republican.

[Properly of a horse with flowing mane and tail, hence thorough, strong.]

*Il a trente ans, et cependant il vit aux crochets de sa mère* = He is thirty years old, and yet his mother has to keep him. **Croire**

*Il s'en croit beaucoup* = He thinks a great deal of **Croix** himself.

*C'est à n'y pas croire* = It is not to be believed; It is so extraordinary (incredible, preposterous) that we

can hardly believe it.

*A l'en croire il a eu tous les prix* = If he is to be believed he won all the prizes.

*“Et chacun croit fort aisément  
Ce qu’il craint et ce qu’il désire.”*  
= The wish is father to the thought.

[LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, i. 6. Le loup et le renard.

Compare 2 *Henry IV*, iv. 5.

“Fere libenter homines id quod volunt credunt.”—CÆSAR, iii. 18.]

*Aller au devant de quelqu’un avec la croix et la bannière* = To receive any one with great fuss and ceremony (often used ironically).

*Votre enfant est gentil à croquer* = Your child is a charming little fellow.

*Il croquait le marmot* = He was dancing attendance;  
He was cooling his heels.

[Littré gives as the explanation of this obscure expression that artists while waiting for their patrons used to draw pictures of little monkeys (*marmot*) in the vestibule. Others assert that in the antechambers of the rich were to be found dishes of cakes in the form of little monkeys, which visitors used to eat (*croquer*) whilst waiting. But both explanations need confirmation.]

*S’agenouiller à cru* = To kneel on the bare ground, on the cold stone (without a hassock or carpet).

[Literally, to kneel on the bare knee, but the quality has passed from the person to the object.]

*C’est de son cru* = That is of his own creation.

*C’est une vraie cruche* (fam.) = She is a silly goose. **Cuir**

*Pester entre cuir et chair* (fam.) = To fume inwardly. **Cuirasse**

*Faire des cuirs* = To drop one's h's.

[Really these are faults made by uneducated French people in pronunciation, consisting in sounding *s* for *t*, or *vice versa*, when running their words together or in pronouncing these letters when they do not occur, as: *ils étaient zici*, for *ils étaient ici*.]

*Les observations glissent sur lui comme sur une* **Cuire**  
*cuirasse* = Blame slips off him as water off a duck's back.

*Vous viendrez cuire à mon four* = Some day you will **Culbute**  
need my assistance.

*Il vous en cuira* = You will smart for it.

*Avoir son pain cuit* = To have one's bread and  
cheese, a competency.

*\*Au bout du fossé la culbute* = At the end of the run **Cuver**  
comes the fall.

[This expression refers to those who, from carelessness or wrong-headedness, are resigned to the consequences of their bad conduct.]

*Cuver son vin* = To sleep oneself sober.

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## D.

**Dame**                    *Une grande dame de par le monde* = A great lady in the eyes of the world.

[This should be written *Une grande dame de la part du monde*. Littré points out that the error in spelling *par* for *part* is a very old one; it would appear to date from the thirteenth century from the examples he quotes. *De par le monde* must be derived from *de parte mundi*, as *de per* was never used.]

**Damer**                    *Damer le pion à quelqu'un* = To outwit some one.

[From the game of draughts, *dame* = a king, *pion* = a man.]

**Damner**                    *Cet homme est son âme damnée* = That man does his dirty work for him, is his tool.

[The man who does the dirty work knows he is damning his soul by doing it, but does it all the same for the money or interest it brings him.]

**Danger**                    *Il n'y a pas de danger* = No fear of that; Don't you fret!

**Danser**                    *Il ne sait sur quel pied danser* = He does not know which way to turn.

*Il en dansera en l'air* = He will swing for it.

*Danser devant le buffet* = To have nothing to eat.

**Dater**                    *Cet événement date de loin* = That event happened long ago.

|                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Dé</b>         | <p><i>A vous le dé</i> = It is your turn to play (at dice). [See <a href="#">Avoir</a>.]</p> <p><i>Ne nous flattez pas le dé</i> = Speak out without any reserve.</p> <p>[<i>Flatter le dé</i> is to let the dice slide gently out of the box.]</p> <p>“<i>Car madame à jaser tient le dé tout le jour</i>” = Madame engrosses the conversation all day long.</p> <p>[MOLIÈRE, <i>Tartufe</i>, i. 1.]</p> |
| <b>Débandade</b>  | <p><i>Ils laissèrent tout à la débandade</i> = They left all at sixes and sevens, in confusion.</p> <p><i>Fuir à la débandade</i> = To fly helter-skelter.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Débit</b>      | <p><i>Le ministre lui a accordé un débit de tabac</i> = The minister has given him a license to sell tobacco.</p> <p>[The sale of tobacco, snuff, gunpowder, and cards is a Government monopoly in France.]</p>                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| <b>Debout</b>     | <p>*<i>Mieux vaut goujat debout qu’empereur enterré</i> = “A living dog is better than a dead lion.”—Ecclesiastes ix. 4.</p> <p>[LA FONTAINE, <i>La Matrone d’Éphèse</i>. <i>Goujat</i> first meant a soldier’s servant (as here), now it means a hodman, or bricklayer’s apprentice, hence a vulgar, coarse fellow, a bungler.]</p> <p><i>Cela ne tient pas debout</i> = That won’t hold water.</p>      |
| <b>Débrider</b>   | <p><i>Il a écrit vingt pages sans débrider</i> = He has written twenty pages at a stretch.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Déchausser</b> | <p><i>Il ne faut pas se déchausser pour manger cela</i> = It is not worth while sitting down to eat that.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |

[The ancients were in the habit of reclining bare-foot at their meals.]

## Décoiffer

*\*Décoiffer (Découvrir) St. Pierre pour coiffer St. Paul = To rob Peter to pay Paul.*

*On a découvert le pot aux roses = They have discovered the mystery, the secret.*

*Être à découvert = To be unprotected, undisguised.*

*Un décrochez-moi-ça (pop.) = A reach-me-down (second-hand garment).*

*Elle est tout en dedans = She is not communicative.* **Défaire**

*On l'a mis dedans (fam.) = 1. They took him in (i.e. they deceived him). 2. They ran him in (i.e. they put him in prison).*

[The second meaning is more often translated: "On l'a coffré."]

*Comme un nigaud, j'ai donné dedans = Like a goose, I fell into the trap.*

*Je ne sais si je suis dedans ou dehors = I do not know which side to take; I do not know whether I have made a profit or not.*

*Il a le visage défait = He has a pale, worn-out look.* **Défaite**

*Cette marchandise est d'une bonne défaite = These goods have a quick sale.* **Défaut**

*Attaquez-le au défaut de la cuirasse* = Attack him on his weak point. **Défense**

*Défense d'afficher* = Stick no bills.

**Dégainer**

*Défense d'entrer* = No admittance.

*Défense d'entrer sous peine d'amende* = Trespassers will be prosecuted.

*Être brave jusqu'au dégainer* = To be brave until it come to blows. **Dégourdir**

[*Dégainer* = to unsheathe a sword.]

*Ils auront à se dégourdir ou à déguerpir* = They will either have to wake up or to clear out. **Dégoûter**

*Se dégourdir les jambes* = To stretch one's legs; To go out for a run.

*Faire le dégoûté* = To be fastidious, dainty.

**Dehors**

*Si j'avais la fortune de Rothschild, je serais content.*  
—*Vous n'êtes pas dégoûté!* = If I had Rothschild's fortune I should be satisfied.—I should rather think so!

*Sauver le dehors* = To save appearances.

**Délit**

*Il n'a pas de dehors* = His personal appearance is not prepossessing; He looks nobody.

*En flagrant délit* = In the very act; red-handed.

**Déloger**

[Lat. *In flagrante delicto.*]



*Déloger sans tambour ni trompette* = To leave **Demain**  
without beat of drum.

*Avec lui c'est toujours demain* = He always **Demandeur**  
procrastinates.

\**A beau demandeur beau refuseur* = Diamond cut **Démanger**  
diamond.

[i.e. "If you are not ashamed to ask, I am not ashamed to refuse."]

*La langue lui démange* = He longs to speak; He is **Denier**  
dying to put in a word.

*Cet homme n'a pas un denier vaillant* = That man is **Dent**  
not worth a brass farthing.

*Rendre compte à livres, sous et deniers* = To give an  
account to the uttermost farthing.

*J'ai les dents bien longues aujourd'hui* = I am very **Dépense**  
hungry to-day.

*Je suis sur les dents* = I am done up.

*J'ai une dent contre lui* = I have a grudge against  
him.

[Also: *Je lui garde un chien de ma chienne* (pop.).]

*Autant prendre la lune avec les dents* = You might  
just as well try and scale the moon.

*Manger du bout des dents* = To eat without an  
appetite; To eat daintily.

["Dente superbo."—HORACE, *Satires*, ii. 6, 87. Compare: *rire du bout des dents*.]

*Déchirer quelqu'un à belles dents* = To tear a person's reputation to shreds.

[Also more forcibly: *Passer quelqu'un à tabac*.]

*\*Les folles dépenses refroidissent la cuisine* = Wilful waste makes woeful want. **Déplaire**

*Qu'il ne vous en déplaie* = With your permission; By your leave; If you'll allow me; An it please you. **Dépourvu**

[Sometimes shortened to: *Ne vous déplaie*, as in LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, i. 1. The sense is often ironical, and means, "whether you like it or not."]

*Au dépourvu* = Unprepared.

**Dératé**

*Courir comme un dératé* = To go like a shot; To run like mad. **Dernier**

[*Rate*=spleen. The Greeks believed that men and animals ran faster if their spleen was removed. "On sait que l'extirpation de la rate se pratiquait chez les coureurs d'antiquité pour éviter l'essoufflement."—COUVREUR, *Les Merveilles du Corps humain*. Comp. PLINY, xxvi. 13.]

*Une représentation du dernier vulgaire* = A display vulgar to the last degree; A very low show. **Désirer**

[“Ce que vous dites là est du dernier bourgeois.”  
MOLIÈRE, *Les Précieuses Ridicules*, sc. 5.]

*\*Plus on désire une chose, plus elle se fait attendre* = A watched pot never boils. **Désorienter**

*Cela laisse à désirer* = There is room for improvement.

*Je suis désorienté* = 1. I am disconcerted. 2. I am out of my element; I do not feel at home; I have lost my bearings.

*Je n'ai pas desserré les dents* = I never opened my lips.

*Par dessus le marché* = Into the bargain; Over and above.

*Il n'y a rien au dessus de cela* = That beats everything.

*Sens dessus dessous* = All upside down; Topsy-turvy.

*Ils ont eu le dessus* = They got the best of it.

[*Avoir le dessous* = to get the worst of it.]

*Prendre le dessus* = To gain the upper hand.

*J'en ai par dessus la tête* = I am worried out of my life with it.

*Il le fera par dessus l'épaule* = He will never do it.

[Comp. "over the left," in schoolboy slang.]

*Il m'a regardé par dessus l'épaule* = He looked at me contemptuously.

*On n'échappe pas à sa destinée* = He that is born to be hanged will never be drowned.

*Il est dur à la détente* = (fig.) He is close-fisted, miser.

*Il a l'air d'un déterré* = He looks as pale as death, as **Détour**  
pale as a ghost.

*Faire un détour* = To go a roundabout way. **Dette**

*Il est sans détour* = He is straightforward.

*Il est criblé de dettes* = He is head over ears in debt. **Deuil**

[For *criblé* one finds *accablé*, *perdu*, or *abîmé*.]

*Des dettes criardes* = Small debts to trades-people or  
workmen (who are continually asking for their  
money).

*J'en ai fait mon deuil* = I have resigned myself to the **Deux**  
loss of it.

*Maintenant, à nous deux!* = Now I will settle with **Devant**  
you; Now is the time for a private explanation;  
Now to business.

*\*Deux s'amuse, trois s'embêtent* (fam.) = Two's  
company, three's none.

*Tous les deux jours; De deux jours l'un* = Every  
other day.

*Piquer des deux* = To spur on one's horse; To rush  
forward.

*\*Les premiers vont devant* = First come, first served. **Dévider**

*Il faut prendre les devants* = One must be first in the  
field.

*Allons au-devant de lui* = Let us go and meet him.

*Mathurin dévide le jars (pop.)* = Jack Tar is spinning **Devoir**  
a yarn.

*Il doit au tiers et au quart (à Jean et à Paul)* = He **Dévolu**  
owes money to everybody.

*Il doit plus d'argent qu'il n'est gros* = He owes more  
money than he can pay.

\**Qui a terme ne doit rien* = No one need pay before  
a debt is due.

\**Qui ne doit rien n'a rien à craindre* = Out of debt,  
out of danger.

\**A chacun son dû* = Give the devil his due; Every  
man is worth his hire.

\**Fais ce que dois, advienne que pourra* = Do your  
duty, come what may.

*Dussé-je en mourir* = Were I to die for it.

*Chose convenue, chose due* = A promise must be  
kept.

*J'ai jeté mon dévolu sur cela* = I have fixed my **Dévotion**  
choice upon that.

*Il n'est de dévotion que de jeune prêtre* = **Diable**  
Enthusiasm wears out in time; New brooms sweep  
clean. (See [Balai](#).)

*C'est le diable qui bat sa femme et qui marie sa fille* **Dieu**  
= It is raining and the sun is shining at the same  
time.

*Tirer le diable par la queue* = To be always hard up for a living.

*Faire le diable à quatre* = To make a terrible noise; To play all sorts of tricks. (See [Quatre](#).)

*Le diable chante la grand'messe* = He hides his vices under the cloak of religion.

*C'est le diable à confesser* = It is terribly hard to do.

*Il a le diable au corps* = He is never still, quite unmanageable, very energetic.

*C'est un air de porter le diable en terre* = It is an air to conjure up the devil.

*\*Il n'est pas si diable qu'il est noir* = The devil is not as black as he is painted.

[Or: *Le diable n'est pas si noir qu'il en a l'air*.]

*Se démener comme un diable dans un bénitier* = To rush about half-mad.

*Loger le diable dans sa bourse* = To be penniless. (See [Bourse](#).)

["Et logeant le diable en sa bourse,  
C'est à dire, n'y logeant rien."

LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, ix.  
16.]

*Quand le diable fut vieux il se fit ermite* = The devil was sick, the devil a monk would be, The devil was well, the devil a monk was he!

[Compare the Italian:

Passata il punto, gabbato il santo = The peril past, the saint mocked.

Also: The river past and God forgotten.]

*Aller au diable Vauvert* (corrupted into *au vert*) = To go very far away, a devil of a way; To disappear.

[The Carthusians having been given a large building at Gentilly by St. Louis, coveted the abandoned mansion of Vauvert (= *vallon vert*), which they could see from their windows. But to ask for it without a valid reason was to court refusal. So they caused it to be haunted by

evil spirits, and the king was soon glad to get rid of this uncanny possession. It is needless to add that the spirits were exorcised directly the monks took possession. It stood in the *rue de Vauvert*, beyond the Luxembourg, which was until lately called the *rue d'Enfer*. As this was then a remote suburb of Paris, the expression was equivalent to going to the end of the town, and thus, very far off.]

*C'est là le diable* (or, *le hic*) = There is the rub.

*Elle a la beauté du diable* = All her beauty consists in her youth and freshness.

*Fait à la diable* (i.e. *à la manière du diable*) = Done anyhow, in a slipshod way.

*À Dieu ne plaise!* = God forbid!

**Différer**

*Jurer ses grands dieux* = To affirm vehemently; To swear by all that one holds sacred.

*\*Ce qui est différé n'est pas perdu* = All is not lost  
that is delayed.

**Diligence**

[German: Aufgeschoben ist nicht aufgehoben.]

*Voyager par la diligence d'Adam* = To travel on  
shanks' nag.

**Dindon**

[German: Auf Schusters Rappen.]

*C'est un franc dindon* = He is a thorough goose.

**Dire**

*Être le dindon de la farce* = To be the dupe.

*Pour tout dire* = In a word.

**Discrétion**

*C'est tout dire* = That is saying all, enough.

[e.g. "Cet homme est-il honnête?"—"Je lui ai prêté 500 fr. il y a deux ans et il n'a jamais voulu me rendre un sou. C'est tout dire."]

*Pour ainsi dire* = So to speak.

*Je ne vous dis que ça* = I cannot tell you any more,  
but it is a fact.

[This can also be translated: "I can tell you!" as in "Je me suis bien  
amusé, je ne vous dis que ça!"]

*Pour mieux dire* = Or rather.

*Je me le suis tenu pour dit* = I took it for granted.

*Soit dit entre nous* = Quite between ourselves.

*Cela est bon à dire, mais...* = That is all very well for  
a speech, but...; That is all very fine, but...

*Il est sensible au qu'en dira-t-on* = He is sensitive to  
public opinion; He is easily influenced by what  
people say about him, by what Mrs. Grundy will  
say.

*Il était dit que j'arriverais trop tard* = The Fates had  
willed that I should come too late.

*Quand je vous le disais!* (or, *Je vous l'avais bien  
dit!*) = I told you so!

*Ah! vous m'en direz tant!* = 1. Well, that alters the  
case! 2. Ah! now I understand, why did you not  
say so at first? 3. There's no going against such a  
reason as that.

[This expression has almost as many meanings as *n'est-ce pas*. The  
above are a few of them. It is often used ironically.]

*A qui le dites-vous?* = Am I not perfectly aware of it?  
Don't I know it?

*Au dire de tout le monde* = According to what  
everybody says; According to the general opinion.

*Je l'irai dire à Rome* = It is so unlikely, that if it  
happens I will undertake a pilgrimage to Rome;  
I'll eat my hat.

[Comp. RACINE, *Épigramme III. Sur Andromaque*.]



*Cela ne me dit rien* = That has no effect upon me; I  
have no desire for it.

*On nous donna du vin à discrétion* = They gave us as **Distance**  
much wine as we wanted (wine *ad libitum*).

*La distance grandit tout prestige* = **Doigt**  
“’Tis distance lends enchantment to the view,  
And robes the mountain in its azure hue.”  
[CAMPBELL, *Pleasures of Hope*, i. 7.]

*Je lui ai donné sur les doigts* = I rapped his knuckles **Domage**  
(lit. and fig.).

*Il y met les quatre doigts et le pouce* = (lit.) He eats  
greedily; (fig.) He acts clumsily.

*Ils sont comme les deux doigts de la main* = They are  
hand and glove together, inseparable.

*Vous avez mis le doigt dessus* = You have hit the  
right nail on the head; You have touched the spot.

*Mon petit doigt me l’a dit* = A little bird told me so.

*Il était à deux doigts de la mort* = He was at death’s  
door, within an ace of death.

*Se fourrer le doigt dans l’œil jusqu’au coude* (pop.)  
= To deceive oneself most blindly; To put one’s  
foot in it.

*Savoir sur le bout du doigt* = To know perfectly; To  
have at one’s finger-ends.

*Il lui obéit au doigt et à l’œil* = He is at his beck and  
call.

*Un doigt de vin* (fam.) = A toothful of wine.

*C'est dommage!* = What a pity.

**Donner**

*Ils lui en ont donné tout du long de l'aune* = They **Dormir**  
beat him black and blue.

*Je vous le donne en dix* = I bet you ten to one you  
will not guess it.

*\*Qui donne tôt donne deux fois* = He gives twice  
who gives in a trice.

[“Bis dat qui celeriter dat.”—PUBLIUS SYRUS. *Cito*, which is now used  
instead of *celeriter*, appears to be a later alteration.]

*Le régiment a donné* = The regiment has engaged.

*On ne lui donnerait pas quarante ans* = You would  
not take him for forty.

*On t'en donnera des tabliers propres pour les salir* =  
You ask too much.

*J'ai passé quinze jours à Paris et je m'en suis donné*  
= I spent a fortnight in Paris, and I thoroughly  
enjoyed myself.

[This idiom implies movement, excitement, &c.]

*Dormir sur les deux oreilles* = (lit.) To sleep soundly; **Dos**  
(fig.) To have no cause for anxiety.

*Dormir comme une marmotte, comme un sabot,*  
*comme une souche, les (or, à) poings fermés* = To  
sleep like a top, like a log.

*Dormir la grasse matinée* = To lie late in bed.

*Il nous a dit des contes à dormir debout* = He told us  
tedious, nonsensical tales, old wives' tales.

[“Γραῶν ὕθλος.”—PLATO, *Rep.* 350 E.

“Aniles fabellae.”—CICERO.]

*\*Qui dort dîne* = Sleeping is as good as eating.

*\*Qui a renommée de se lever matin peut dormir jusqu'à midi* = A good reputation covers a multitude of sins.

*Dormir en gendarme* = To sleep with one eye open.

*\*Il ne se laisse pas manger la laine sur le dos* = He **Double** is not the man to let himself be made a fool of; He will not allow people to take the food out of his mouth; He will not tamely submit to any imposition.

*Le juge les a renvoyés dos à dos* = The judge nonsuited them both.

*Il fait le gros dos* = He gives himself airs.

*En dos d'âne* = Sloping on both sides, sharp-ridged.

*Je me suis mis le juge à dos* = I have made an enemy of the judge.

*J'en ai plein le dos* (pop.) = I am sick and tired of it.

*Il a bon dos* = His back is broad enough to stand a good deal.

*C'est un double coquin* = He is a thorough rascal. **Douceur**

*C'est un homme double* = He is a double-faced man.

*\*Plus fait douceur que violence* = Kindness does **Doute** more than harshness; More flies are caught with honey than with vinegar.

[LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, vi. 3.]

*Il faudra le prendre en douceur* = You must tackle him gently.

*Cela ne fait aucun doute* = There is no doubt about **Douter** it.

*Dans le doute abstiens-toi* = When in doubt, do nothing.

*Je ne me doutais de rien* = I did not suspect **Douzaine** anything.

*Je m'en doutais* = I thought so.

*C'est un poète comme on en trouve à la douzaine* = **Dragée**  
He is a very minor poet.

[RÉGNIER, *Sat.* iv.]

*Tenir la dragée haute à quelqu'un* = To make a **Dragon** person pay well (or, wait a long time) for what he desires.

*Cette femme est un vrai dragon* = 1. That woman is a **Drap** virago. 2. That woman is very masculine (in appearance and manners).

*Je suis dans de beaux draps* = I am in a fine mess, in **Drapeau** a pretty pickle.

*Il voudrait avoir le drap et l'argent* = He would like to have his cake and eat it too.

*Elle a déjà un fils sous les drapeaux* = She already **Droit** has a son in the army.

*Remettez ceci à qui de droit* = Give this to the proper person, to the person who has a right to it. **Drôle**

*Il fera droit à votre demande* = He will accede to your request.

*Il fait son droit* = He is studying for the bar.

*C'est un drôle de corps* = He is a queer fish. **Dru**

*C'est un mauvais drôle* = He is a downright scamp.

*Frapper fort et dru* = To strike with might and main.

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## E.

### Eau

*\*Il n'est pire eau que l'eau qui dort* = Still waters run deep.

*\*C'est porter de l'eau à la mer (or, rivière)* = It is carrying coals to Newcastle.

[The Greek equivalent was Γλαῦκος εἰς Αθήνας = Owls to Athens; the Hebrew "Enchantments to Egypt," and the Late Latin "Indulgences to Rome."]

*Cet homme aime à pêcher en eau trouble* = That man likes fishing in troubled waters.

*\*Ils se ressemblent comme deux gouttes d'eau* = They are as like as two peas.

*Tout va à vau l'eau* = All is going to wreck and ruin.

[*A vau l'eau* = With the current.]

*Pendant l'inondation le toit de cette maison était à fleur d'eau* = During the flood the top of that house was on a level with the water.

*C'est un donneur d'eau bénite de cour* = He makes empty promises.

*Les eaux sont basses chez lui* = He is hard up; He is in low water.

*C'est donner un coup d'épée dans l'eau* = It is useless trouble, an unsuccessful attempt.

[“Ὑδατι γράφειν.”—PLATO, *Phaedrus*, 276 C.]

*Faire venir l'eau au moulin* = To bring grist to the mill.

*Faire venir l'eau à la bouche* = To make one's mouth water.

**Échapper**      *Ce mot m'est échappé* = That word escaped me inadvertently (i.e., I did not mean to say it).

*Ce mot m'a échappé* = I have forgotten that word.

**Échéant**      *Le cas échéant* = Should such a thing happen; If such should be the case.

**Échelle**      *Faire la courte échelle à quelqu'un* = To allow some one to climb on one's shoulders to scale a height; To give a lift to some one.

*Après lui il faut tirer l'échelle* = One cannot do better than he has (or, does); He beats the record, takes the cake.

**École**      *Faire l'école buissonnière* = To play truant.

*Faire une école* = To make a blunder.

*Faire école* = To found (or, to be a leader of) a school of art, literature, music, &c.

**Écolier**      *Faire un tour d'écolier* = To play a schoolboy trick.

*Faire une faute d'écolier* = To make a foolish mistake.

**Économie**      *\*Il n'y a pas de petites économies* = A penny saved is a penny earned; Take care of the pence and the pounds will take care of themselves.

[Also: *Les petites économies font les bonnes maisons.*]

**Écorcher**

*\*Jamais beau parler n'écorcha la langue* = Fair **Écorner**  
words never did harm; Civility costs nothing.

*Il écorche le français* = He murders French.

*Il écorche l'anguille par la queue* = He sets (goes)  
the wrong way to work.

*Il fait un vent à écorner (or, décorner) un bœuf* = The **Écot**  
wind is enough to blow one's head off.

*Chacun a payé son écot* = Each paid for himself. **Écouter**

*Comme cet homme s'écoute!* = What care that man **Écrire**  
takes of himself!

*C'est un écoute s'il pleut* = He is a man who cannot  
be relied upon.

[Mills were so called which depended for their motive-power on rain-  
water and consequently were continually stopping.]

*Il n'écoute que d'une oreille* = He pays very little  
attention.

*Écrire de bonne encre à quelqu'un* = To write to **Écuelle**  
some one in strong terms.

*Être propre comme une écuelle de chat* = To be very **Écurie**  
dirty.

*\*Fermer l'écurie quand les chevaux sont dehors* = **Effet**  
To lock the stable door when the steed is stolen.

*C'est un cheval à l'écurie* = It is a white elephant.



*Cela fait de l'effet* = That looks well; That is showy;**Égal**  
That makes a fine display.

*Cela me fait cet effet* = That seems so to me.

*Cela m'est égal* = It is all the same to me; I don't**Église**  
care.

*Tout lui est égal* = Everything is the same to him.

*D'égal à égal* = 1. Between equals. 2. On equal  
terms.

*C'est égal, je me suis joliment amusé* = Anyhow (All  
the same), I enjoyed myself very much.

*\*Près de l'église, loin de Dieu* = The nearer the**Élan**  
church, the farther from God.

*Gueux comme un rat d'église* = As poor as a church  
mouse.

*Prendre son élan* = To take one's spring (before a**Embarras**  
jump).

*Ne faites donc pas tant d'embarras* = Do not make**Emblée**  
such a fuss.

*Ce n'est pas l'embarras* = There is no great  
difficulty in it; After all; For the matter of that.

*Elle n'a que l'embarras du choix* = She has only too  
much to choose from.

*La loi passa d'emblée* = The law passed straight off,**Embrasser**  
by acclamation.

*Il a été reçu d'emblée* = He passed his examination  
the first time he went up, without any difficulty.

\**Qui trop embrasse mal étreint* = Grasp all, lose all. **Employer**

[“Qui totum vult totum perdit.”—PUBLIUS SYRUS.

Qui tout convoite tout perd.

L'avarice rompt le sac.

Too much is stark naught.

“Oh, the little more, and how much it is!

And the little less, and what worlds away!”

BROWNING, *Dramatic Lyrics*, ‘By the Fireside,’ 39.]

*Il a employé le vert et le sec pour y parvenir* = He **Emporter**  
left no stone unturned to secure success.

*S'emporter comme une soupe au lait* = To be very **Empressé**  
hasty-tempered.

*Ne faites pas attention à ses menaces, autant en  
emporte le vent* = Pay no attention to his threats,  
they are as light as air.

*Emporter ses cliques et ses claques* = To clear off,  
bag and baggage.

*C'est une réponse à l'emporte-pièce* = It is a very  
cutting answer, and to the point.

[À l'emporte-pièce = Cut out by a machine-punch.]

*Cela m'emporte la bouche* = It burns my mouth (i.e.  
it is too highly spiced).

*Il fait l'empresé auprès de sa vieille tante* = He pays **Emprunter**  
marked attention to his old aunt.

*Elle a un air emprunté* = She looks awkward, **Encensoir**  
embarrassed, affected.

*Ne choisit pas qui emprunte* = Beggars cannot be choosers.

[“Qui emprunte ne choisit mie.”

*Maistre Pierre Pathelin, 79.]*

*Casser le nez à quelqu'un à coups d'encensoir* = To **Enchère** flatter some one fulsomely to his face. (See [Casser.](#))

*Payer la folle enchère* = To pay for one's rashness, **Enclume** for one's folly.

[When a man bids at an auction and does not pay for what he has bought, the lot is put up again and he has to pay the difference (if any) between the price it is then sold at and the price he bid for it.]

*Enchère au rabais* = A Dutch auction.

*Je suis entre l'enclume et le marteau* = I am in a **Endroit** dilemma; I am between the devil and the deep sea.

\**Il frappe toujours sur la même enclume* = He is always harping on the same string.

\**A dure enclume marteau de plume* = The strokes of adversity find the wise man unmoved.

[“Impavidum ferient ruinae.”

*HORACE, Odes, iii. 3.]*

*Frapper au bon endroit* = To touch the right spring; **Endimancher** To hit the right nail on the head; To hit the mark; To touch the spot.

*Des gens endimanchés* = Folk rigged out in their **Enfant** Sunday best.

*Des enfants perdus* (military) = A forlorn hope. **Enfiler**

*Un enfant terrible* = A child who tells awkward truths.

[Gavarni, the caricaturist, published a series of sketches in 1865 under the title of “Les Enfants Terribles.”]

*Elle a deux enfants du premier lit* = She has two children by her first husband.

*C'est un enfant de la balle* = He is his father's son; He follows the profession of his father. (See [Balle](#).)

*C'est bien l'enfant de sa mère* = He is the very image of his mother.

*Faire l'enfant* = To behave childishly (on purpose).

*Je ne suis pas ici pour enfiler des perles* = I am not **Enfonceur** here to waste my time.

*Cela ne s'enfile pas comme des perles* = That is by no means an easy matter.

*C'est un enfonceur de portes ouvertes* = 1. He is a **Engrenage** braggart. 2. He takes a deal of trouble to solve a difficulty which does not exist.

*Être pris dans l'engrenage* = To be caught in the **Enlever** toils.

*On enleva les journaux comme du pain* = The papers **Ennemi** sold like hot rolls, like wild-fire.

*Il n'y a pas de petit ennemi* = Every enemy is to be **Enseigne** feared.

[“Croire qu’un faible ennemi ne peut pas nuire, c’est croire qu’une étincelle ne peut pas causer un incendie.” Sa’adi.]

*Nous sommes logés à la même enseigne* = We are **Entendre** both in the same predicament, in the same boat.

[“ἐν γὰρ τῷ αὐτῷ ἐσμεν σκάμματι.” St. Clement’s Epistle to the Church of Corinth.]

*À telles enseignes* = In proof whereof; So much so that.

*Je ne le croirai qu’à bonnes enseignes* = I shall only believe it upon good authority.

*Il entend à demi mot* = He can take a hint. **Entente**

\**À bon entendeur, salut* = A word to the wise is enough; *Verbum sap.*

[“A bon entendeur ne fault qu’une parole.”—RABELAIS, *Pantagruel*, v. 7.]

*Il n’entend pas de cette oreille* = (fig.) He will listen to nothing on that subject.

*Vous ne vous y entendez pas* = You do not know how to set about it, how to manage it.

*Il n’entend pas raillerie là-dessus* = 1. You must not speak lightly of that before him. 2. He will not be trifled with on that point.

*Entendre la raillerie* = To know how to be witty; To be a good hand at chaff.

*Entendre raillerie* = Not to be offended at a joke; To stand chaff well.

*Il n’y entend pas malice* = 1. He does not mean any harm; He means no more than he says. 2. He takes it innocently.

*Faire l’entendu* = To put on a knowing look.

*\*Il n'est pire sourd que celui qui ne veut pas entendre* = None so deaf as those who will not hear.

*Un mot à double entente* = A word (or, remark) with **Enter** two meanings.

*\*Mieux vaut goudat debout qu'empereur enterré* = A **Envie** living dog is better than a dead lion.

*J'ai bien envie d'aller à Paris avec vous* = I have a **Envoyer** good mind to go to Paris with you.

*Il ne porte envie à personne* = He envies no one.

*Il ne fait envie à personne* = No one envies him.

*Si l'envie m'en prend* = If I feel inclined to do it.

*Je l'ai envoyé promener* (or, fam., *paître*) = I sent **Épée** him about his business.

*C'est son épée de chevet* = 1. That is his trusty **Épervier** counsellor. 2. That is what he is always talking about.

[Literally, a sword that hung at the head of a bed to guard one from nocturnal attacks.

“Voilà leur épée de chevet, de l'argent.”—MOLIÈRE, *L'Avare*, iii. 5.]

*Passer au fil de l'épée* = To put to the sword.

*Qui porte épée porte paix* = One sword keeps another in its scabbard; *Si vis pacem, para bellum*.

*\*Mariage d'épervier, la femelle vaut mieux que le mâle* = The grey mare is the better horse. **Épine**

*Tirer une épine du pied à quelqu'un* = To take a thorn out of some one's side; To get some one over a difficulty. **Épingle**

*Il est toujours tiré à quatre épingles* = He always looks as if he came out of a band-box. **Éponge**

*J'ai tiré mon épingle du jeu* = I have saved my stake; I got well out of a bad job.

[Une locution qui vient d'un jeu de petites filles: elles mettent des épingles dans un rond, et, avec une balle qui, lancée contre le mur, revient vers le rond, elles essayent d'en faire sortir les épingles: quand on fait sortir sa mise, on dit qu'on retire son épingle du jeu.]

*Une épingle par jour fait huit sous par an* = A pin a day is a groat a year.

*Passons l'éponge là-dessus* = Let us say no more about it; Let us forget all about it; Let bygones be bygones. **Épreuve**

*C'est un ami à toute épreuve* = He is a well-tried, faithful, trusty friend. **Épuiser**

*L'édition est épuisée* = The book is out of print. **Équipée**

*Oh! la belle équipée!* = Here's a pretty kettle of fish! **Ergot**

*Se dresser sur ses ergots* = To stand on one's dignity. **Esprit**

*Je suis bien dans son esprit* = He has a good opinion  
of me. **Essuyer**

*Où avez-vous donc l'esprit?* = What are you thinking  
of?

*Il a l'esprit aux talons* = He shines at the wrong end;  
He is not witty.

*Il a l'esprit de l'escalier* = He never thinks of the  
right answer at the proper moment.

[i.e. He thinks of the right answer going down the staircase, after  
leaving the room.]

*Faire de l'esprit* = To try and be witty.

*Il a de l'esprit comme quatre* = He is very witty.

*L'esprit court les rues* = Wit is a drug in the market.

*Avoir l'esprit bien fait* = To be good-tempered.

*Les grands esprits se rencontrent* = Great wits  
always jump together; We both said the same thing  
at the same moment.

*Essuyer les plâtres* = To move into a newly-built  
house before the walls are dry; (fig.) To experience  
the disadvantages of a beginning. **Estomac**

*Avoir l'estomac dans les talons* = To be as hungry as  
a hunter. **État**

*Nous faisons peu d'état de cet homme* = We consider  
that man very little; We take little account of that  
man. **Étoffe**

*De son état* = By profession, by trade.



*Je l'ai mis hors d'état de vous nuire* = I have put it out of his power to harm you.

*Pour un rien il se met dans tous ses états* (fam.) = He gets very excited over a mere trifle.

*L'État, c'est moi!* = The State! I am the State.

[CHÉRUVEL, *Histoire de l'Administration monarchique en France*, Livre II. p. 32.]

*Il y a de l'étoffe dans cet enfant* = There is grit in **Étoile** that boy.

*Voir des étoiles (la lune) en plein midi* = To receive a **Étourdir** violent blow in the eye, so as to "see stars."

*Étourdir la grosse faim* = To take the edge off one's **Être** appetite.

*Je n'y suis pour personne* = I am not at home to **Étrenne** anybody.

*Je n'y suis pour rien* = I have nothing to do with it; I have no hand in it.

*Vous n'y êtes pas* = You do not understand it; "You are out of it."

*J'y suis, j'y reste* = Here I am, here I stop.

[Marshal MacMahon in the trenches before the Malakoff, Sept. 9, 1855.]

*Cette fois, ça y est* = Now it is done, and no mistake.

*Je n'en suis plus* = I am no longer one of the party; I no longer belong to it.

*Il n'en a rien été* = Nothing came of it.

*Il en a été pour sa peine* = He had his trouble for nothing.

*Il en sera ce qu'il vous plaira* = It shall be just as you please.

*Je ne sais plus où j'en suis* = 1. I have lost the place where I left off (in reading, etc.). 2. I do not know what I am about.

*Je suis très bien avec lui* = I am on very good terms with him.

*Êtes-vous de la noce?* = Are you one of the wedding party?

*Êtes-vous des nôtres* = Are you one of our party? Are you one of us? Do you think as we do?

*Voilà ce que c'est que de se mettre en colère* = That is the consequence of losing one's temper.

*Je suis à l'étroit* = I am cramped for room.

*\*On ne peut pas être et avoir été* = One cannot have one's cake and eat it. (See [Drap.](#))

*Tu n'en auras pas l'étréne* = You will not be the **Étrier** first to use it.

*Il a le pied à l'étrier* = He is ready to start. **Évangile**

*Buvez le coup de l'étrier* = Drink the stirrup-cup.

*A franc étrier* = At full speed. (See [Bride](#) and [Train.](#))

*C'est l'Évangile* (or, *c'est parole d'Évangile*) = It is **Excuser** gospel truth.

\**Qui s'excuse, s'accuse* = If you try to excuse yourself you practically acknowledge that you have done wrong; A guilty conscience needs no accuser. **Exemple**

*Excusez du peu* (ironic.) = Only that? How modest!

*Il prêcha d'exemple* = He practised what he preached; He set the example. **Expérience**

\**Peu de leçons, beaucoup d'exemples* = Precepts lead, examples draw; It is easiest learning at another's cost.

\**Expérience passe science* = Experience is the best master; **Extrême** *Experientia docet.*

[“Experience is the best of schoolmasters, only the school fees are heavy.” CARLYLE, *Misc. Essays*, i. 137.]

*Les extrêmes se touchent* = Extremes meet; Too far east is west; Too much care may be as bad as downright negligence.

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## F.

### Fabrique

*C'est de sa fabrique* = That is of his invention.

*Marque de fabrique* = Trade-mark.

### Face

*Il fera face à tout* = He will meet every demand.

*Ce portrait est pris de face* = That portrait is taken full face.

*Jouer à pile ou face* = To play at heads or tails, pitch and toss.

*Il le regarda bien en face* = He looked him straight in the face.

### Façon

*Donner un ouvrage à façon* = To put out a job to be done.

*On travaille à façon* (of small tailors, etc.) = People's own materials made up.

*C'est un conte de sa façon* = It is a story of his own invention.

*Maintenant qu'il est riche, il s'en donne de la bonne façon* = Now he is rich, he refuses himself nothing.

*Je lui dirai ma façon de penser* = I'll give him a piece of my mind.

*Une façon de parler* = A form of speech; A way of speaking (not to be taken literally).

[e.g. "Quand je dis qu'il n'est jamais venu en Angleterre c'est une façon de parler, car il a passé huit jours à Douvres il y a dix ans."]

*Cet homme n'a ni mine ni façon* = That man has neither grace nor good looks; That man is as awkward as he is ugly. **Fagot**

*C'est lui qui fait les sottises et c'est moi qui en paye la façon* = He commits the mistakes and I have to pay for them.

*Il a bonne façon* = He has good style; He is well got up.

*De toute façon il a tort* = At any rate he is wrong; Whichever way you look at it, he is wrong.

*Sans façon* = Without ceremony, without fuss.

*De façon ou d'autre* = Somehow or other.

*C'est un vrai fagot d'épines* = He is a regular bear. **Fagoter**

*\*Il y a fagots et fagots* = There are men and men; All men are not alike.

[MOLIÈRE, *Le Médecin malgré lui*, i. 6.]

*Sentir le fagot* = 1. To be tainted with heresy (obsolete). 2. Not to be quite honest.

*Comme vous voilà fagotée!* = How awkwardly you are dressed! What a fright (or, dowdy) you look! **Faillir**

[“Pour moi, quand une femme a le don de se taire,  
Eût-elle en vrai magot tout le corps fagoté,  
Je lui voudrais donner le prix de la beauté.”

CORNEILLE, *Le Menteur*.]

*J'ai failli tomber* = I very nearly fell. **Faim**

*C'est la faim qui épouse la soif* = They are both very poor; It is one beggar marrying another. **Faire**

*\*La faim chasse le loup hors du bois* = Hunger tames the lion; Hunger will break through stone walls.

*Rien n'y fait* = Nothing has any effect upon him (or, **Faiseur** on it); It is all of no use.

*Comment est-il fait?* = What sort of a man is he?

*\*Ce qui est fait est fait* = It is no good crying over spilt milk.

*\*On ne peut faire qu'en faisant* = Practice makes perfect.

*Faire la Saint-Lundi* = To do no work on Monday.  
(See [Lundi](#).)

[Colloquially: *Faire le Lundi*.]

*Tâchez de faire quelques provisions* = Try and collect some provisions.

*Faire dix ans de travaux forcés* = To undergo ten years' penal servitude.

*Il est bon de se faire à la fatigue* = It is good to accustom oneself to fatigue.

*Coquelin fait le rôle principal* = Coquelin is taking the principal part.

*On le fait riche* = He is said to be rich.

*Cela ne me fait ni chaud ni froid* = It is all the same to me.

*Je n'ai que faire de vos conseils* = I do not care a jot for your advice; I do not want your advice.

*\*Qui bien fera, bien (se) trouvera* = Who works well will have a good reward.

*Il ne faut pas me la faire* (pop.) = You must not try that on with me.

*Combien faites-vous cette étoffe?* = How much are you asking for this stuff?

*Il aime à ce qu'on fasse cas de lui* = He likes to be made a fuss of.

*Il fait bien son chemin* = He is getting on in the world.

*Ils ne font qu'un* = They are hand and glove together.

*Cela fait beaucoup* = That makes a great difference.

*Cela me fait sortir des gonds* = That exasperates me.

*Il faut faire mousser sa marchandise* = One must puff one's goods.

*Qu'est-ce que cela me fait?* = What is that to me?

*Faire huit kilomètres à pied, à cheval, en voiture* = To walk, ride, drive, five miles.

*Le vert fait bien avec le rose* = Green goes well with pink; Pink and green are fit for a queen.

*Faire des siennes* = To be at one's old tricks.

*Il n'en fait qu'à sa volonté* = He is self-willed.

*C'est à faire à vous de réussir* = You are the man to succeed.

*C'en est fait de lui* = He is done for; It is all up with him.

*Ce qui est fait n'est pas à faire* = Better to finish it now than to leave it.

*Ce n'est ni fait ni à faire* = It is done, but badly, (in a slovenly fashion).

*Il fait cher vivre à Londres* = Living in London is dear.

*Que faire?* = What am I (or, are we) to do? What is to be done?

*Pourquoi faire?* = What for?

*Comment faire?* = What is to be done?

*Que voulez-vous que j'y fasse?* = How can I help it?  
What would you have me do? It is no business of mine.

*Je ne saurais qu'y faire* = I cannot help it.

*A chose faite point de remède* = What is done cannot be undone.

*Laissez-le faire* = Do not interfere with him.

*Si faire se peut* = If possible.

*Cela ne fait rien* = That does not matter.

*Il n'en fera rien* = He will do nothing of the sort.

*Je m'y fais* = I am getting used to it.

*C'est bien fait* = It serves him (or, her, you) right.

*Quel temps fait-il?* = What is the weather like?

*Quel temps il fait!* = What weather this is!

*Paris ne s'est pas fait en un jour* = Rome was not built in a day.

*Il s'est fait jardinier* = He became a gardener.

*Elle se fait vieille* = She is getting old.

*Pour se faire la main* = To get one's hand in (i.e. to get accustomed to the work).

*Se faire jour à travers la foule* = To force one's way through the crowd.

*Je me fais fort de le faire* = I feel quite confident of doing it.



*Coquelin sait le mieux se faire une tête* = Coquelin is the cleverest at altering his features, at making up.

*Cela se fait maintenant* = That is the fashion now.

*Cela ne se fait pas* = That is not proper; That is not the correct thing.

*C'est un faiseur d'embarras* = He is a fussy **Fait** personage.

*Cela est de mon fait* = That is my doing. **Falloir**

*Venons au fait* = Let us come to the point.

*Mettez-moi au fait de ce qui s'est passé* = Tell me what happened.

*Il lui a dit son fait* = He told him what he thought of him (not complimentary); He gave him a bit of his mind.

*Si fait!* = Yes, indeed! On the contrary!

*Cette place est votre fait* = That situation is just the thing for you.

*Je suis sûr de mon fait* = I am sure of what I am saying; I know what I am about.

*C'est un fait accompli* = It is done and cannot be undone.

*Travailler à prix fait* (or, *à forfait*) = To work at an agreed price; To work by the piece.

*Prendre quelqu'un sur le fait* = To take any one in the act.

*Il a pris fait et cause pour moi* = He stood up for me; He took my part.

*L'homme qu'il faut* = The very man (for a post). **Farine**

*Il le faut* = It must be so.

*Il fallait voir comme il était content* = You should have seen how happy he was.

*Peu s'en fallut qu'il ne fût reçu* = He was all but received; He failed for a few marks.

[Latin: Haud multum abfuit quin....]

*C'est un homme comme il faut* = He is a perfect gentleman.

*C'est un homme comme il en faut* = He is one of the right sort.

[Sometimes in bad sense: He is the sort of man we want to do that dirty work.]

*C'est un homme comme il en faudrait beaucoup* = I wish more men were like him (because of his straightforward or courageous nature).

*S'il n'est pas un fripon, il ne s'en faut guère* = If he is not a rascal, he is precious near it.

*Il s'en faut beaucoup que l'un ait autant de mérite que l'autre* = There is a great difference in merit between the two.

*Il s'en faut de beaucoup que leur nombre soit complet* = Their number is far from being complete.

[The former of these two idioms should refer to quality, the latter to quantity.]

*Des gens de même farine* = Persons of the same **Fat** kidney (generally in a bad sense); People tarred with the same brush.

*“Le bruit est pour le fat, la plainte pour le sot,  
L’honnête homme trompé s’éloigne et ne dit mot,”* **Faute**

= Rows are for muffs, ’tis only fools complain.

The gentleman deceived will grin and bear the pain.

[LA NOUE, *La Coquette corrigée*, i. 3 (1756).]

*Rien ne vous fera faute* = You will want for nothing. **Faux**

*Il ne se fait faute de rien* = He denies himself nothing.

*C’est une faute d’inattention* = It is a slip.

*C’est une faute d’impression* = It is a misprint.

*Il ne se fait pas faute de se plaindre* = He complains freely.

*Faute de mieux* = For want of something better.

*Chanter faux* = To sing out of tune. **Fée**

*Faire un faux pas* = (lit.) To stumble; (fig.) To make a slip; To commit a mistake.

*Vous faites fausse route* = You are taking the wrong road; You are on the wrong track.

*Cette poutre porte à faux* = That beam does not rest properly on its support.

*Cette remarque a porté à faux* = That remark was not to the point, was not conclusive.

*Faux comme un jeton* = As false as Judas; As false as a die.

*Je m’inscris en faux contre cette assertion* = I emphatically deny the truth of that assertion.

*C'est la fée Carabosse* = She is an old hag.

**Fêler**

*\*Les pots fêlés sont ceux qui durent le plus* = **TheFemme**  
door with the creaking hinge hangs longest; The  
cracked pitcher goes oftenest to the well.

*\*Femme qui parle comme homme et geline quiFenêtre*  
*chante comme coq ne sont bonnes à tenir* =  
A whistling woman and a crowing hen  
Are good for neither cocks nor men.

[“C’est chose qui moult me deplaist,  
Quand poule parle et coq se taist.”

*Roman de la  
Rose.*

“La poule ne doit pas chanter devant le coq.”

*MOLIÈRE, Les Femmes Savantes, v.  
3.]*

*\*Prends le premier conseil d’une femme et non le  
second* = A woman’s instinct is better than her  
reason.

[Montaigne coined the phrase *l’esprit primesautier* to describe this  
feminine peculiarity of either seeing a thing at once or not at all.]

*Femme sottte se connaît à la cotte* = A foolish woman  
is known by her finery.

*Ce que femme veut Dieu le veut* = Woman must have  
her way.

*\*Souvent femme varie,  
Bien fol est qui s’y fie* =  
Between a woman’s yes and no,  
There’s no room for a pin to go.  
A woman’s mind  
And winter wind  
Change oft.

[These words are said to have been written by François I. on two little  
leaded panes in his room at the castle of Chambord, about ten miles

from Blois. Brantôme says that while talking with his sister, Marguerite d'Angoulême, he engraved the saying with a diamond ring. Report has it that Louis XIV. broke the glass with his stick at the request of Mademoiselle de la Vallière. However that may be, the visitor to Chambord will see that the words have been rewritten on the window.]

*Ciel pommelé et femme fardée ne sont pas de longue durée* = A mackerel sky, not long wet and not long dry.

*Il faut passer par là ou par la fenêtre* = It is **Fer** absolutely inevitable.

*\*Il faut battre le fer pendant qu'il est chaud* = You **Féir** must strike while the iron is hot.

[“Ce pendant que le fer est chault il le fault battre.”—RABELAIS, *Pantagruel*, ii. 31.]

*Cela ne vaut pas les quatre fers d'un chien* = That is not worth a rap, a fig (i.e., nothing, for a dog is not shod).

*Il tomba les quatre fers en l'air* = (lit.) He fell on his back; (fig.) He was struck all of a heap.

*Il y a quelque fer qui cloche* = There is a hitch somewhere. (See [Clocher](#).)

*Sans coup férir* = Without striking a blow. **Ferré**

*Il est ferré sur la géographie* = He is well up in **Fête** geography.

*\*Ce n'est pas tous les jours fête* = Christmas comes **Feu** but once a year.

*Faire fête à quelqu'un* = To welcome some one heartily.

*Je me fais une fête de passer huit jours à la campagne* = I look forward with pleasure to the idea of spending a week in the country.

*Il n'a ni feu ni lieu* = He has neither house nor home. **Fève**

*L'ennemi mit le pays à feu et à sang* = The enemy put the country to fire and sword.

*Je n'y ai vu que du feu* = It was impossible for me to find out how the thing was done (as it was done so quickly); It was done so quickly (or, cleverly) that I could not make head or tail of it.

*Vous me faites mourir à petit feu* = You are killing me by inches; You are torturing me to death.

*Il ne faut pas jouer avec le feu* = One should not play with edged tools.

*Il n'est feu que de bois vert* = None are so active as the young.

*Il jette feu et flamme* = He frets and fumes; He is in a great rage.

*Faire feu des quatre pieds* = To strain every nerve.

*Ce n'est qu'un feu de paille* = It is only a flash in the pan; It will not last.

*Il a jeté tout son feu* = 1. His anger is over now. 2. He has used up all his ideas.

*C'est le feu et l'eau* = They are as opposite as fire and water.

*Faire feu* = To fire (rifles, guns).

*Faire du feu* = To light a fire.

\**Il a trouvé la fève au gâteau* = He has hit the mark;**Fier**  
He has made a lucky discovery.

[It was (and is still in many places) the custom to hide a bean in the cake on Twelfth Night, and the person who found it was the king of the revels.

“Pensent avoir trouvé la fève du gâteau.”

RÉGNIER, *Satires*,  
vii.]

\**Donner un pois pour avoir une fève* = To give a  
sprat to catch a herring. (See [Euf.](#))

*Fier comme Artaban* (or, *comme un Écossais*) = As**Fièvre**  
proud as a peacock.

[Artaban was the hero of *Cléopâtre*, a romance by La Calprenède, a Gascon. The phrase is also said to be derived from Artabanès, King of Parthia. “Plus fier que tous les Artabans.”—ROSTAND, *Cyrano de Bergerac*, i. 2.]

\**Tomber de fièvre en chaud mal* (or, *de la poêle dans***Figure**  
*la braise, de Charybde en Scylla*) = To fall out of  
the frying-pan into the fire.

[“Incidit in Scyllam cupiens vitare Charybdim.”—Compare HOMER,  
*Od.* xii. 85.

“Thus when I shun Scylla, your father, I fall into  
Charybdis, your mother.”—SHAKESPEARE,  
*Merchant of Venice*, iii. 5.]

\**Moitié figue, moitié raisin* = 1. Partly willingly,**Fil**  
partly by force. 2. Half one thing and half another.  
3. Half in jest, half in earnest.

[This expression is often used of a remark that may be complimentary  
or not.]

*Je lui donnerai du fil à retordre* = I will cut out his **Filer** work for him; I will give him a deal of trouble.

*Ce sont des finesses cousues de fil blanc* = Those tricks are easily found out.

\**A toile ourdie Dieu envoie le fil* = God sends thread for a begun web.

*Au fil de l'eau* = With the stream.

*Au fil de l'épée* = To the edge of the sword.

*Filer à l'anglaise* = To leave without saying good-**Fille** bye, without attracting attention; To take French leave.

\**Du temps que Berthe filait* = When Adam delved and Eve span; In the good old times.

[Berthe was the mother of Charlemagne. She was known as *Berthe au grand pied* from her club foot.]

*Filer doux* = To sing small.

*Il faut filer* (or, *Filons!*) (fam.) = We must be off, trot off.

*La plus belle fille du monde ne peut donner que ce* **Fils** *qu'elle a* = No man can give more than he has; A man cannot give what he has not got.

\**Quand on a des filles, on est toujours berger* =  
My son is my son till he gets him a wife,  
My daughter's my daughter all the days of her life.

\**Fille oisive, à mal pensive* = An idle brain is the devil's workshop.

["For Satan finds some mischief still  
For idle hands to do."]



|                         |       |                      |
|-------------------------|-------|----------------------|
| <i>Fille trop vue,</i>  | } = { | A maid often seen, a |
| <i>robe trop vêtue,</i> |       | garment often worn,  |
| <i>N'est pas chère</i>  |       | Are disesteemed and  |
| <i>tendue.</i>          |       | held in scorn.       |

*Il est bien le fils de son père* = He is a chip of the old **Fin (adj.)** block.

*Être le fils de ses œuvres* = To be a self-made man.

Fin (subst.)

*À la fin vous voilà!* = Here you are at last!

*À la fin des fins* (or, *en fin finale*) *vous nous direz quelque chose* = At last you will tell us something.

*À telle fin que de raison* = At all events; At any rate.

\**La fin couronne l'œuvre* = The end crowns all; All's well that ends well.

\**Qui veut la fin veut les moyens* = Where there is a will there is a way; If you want the end you must not stick at the means.

\**La fin justifie les moyens* = Success justifies the means by which it has been attained.

*Il touche à sa fin* = He is nearing his end; It is nearly over.

\**En toutes choses il faut considérer la fin* = We must always look to the end; Look before you leap.

[LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, iii. 5. The motto of the Kennedy family is "Look to the end," or "Avisé la fin."]

*C'est fin de siècle* = That is smart, up to date.

[This expression came to the front in Paris about the time of the 1889 Exhibition. In 1890 appeared a play called "Paris fin de siècle," by Blum and Toché, in which occur these words: "C'est un mot nouveau qui dit très bien ce qu'il veut dire. Le siècle n'a plus que

dix ans à vivre et, vois-tu, il veut les passer gaiement.” The saying, however, has lost its sense, and is becoming obsolete now that a new century has begun.]

*Il sait le fort et le fin de son art* = He knows every **Finir** trick of his trade.

*Plus fin que lui n'est pas bête* = He who can take him in is no fool.

*J'arrive du fin fond de l'Afrique* = I have come from the very depths of Africa.

*C'est une fine mouche* (or, *lame*) = He is a cunning fellow, a sly dog. (See [Compère](#).)

*C'est fin contre fin* = It is diamond cut diamond.

[Also: *Fin contre fin ne vaut rien pour doublure*.]

*Fin contre fin gare la bombe* = “When Greeks joined Greeks, then was the tug of war.”

[NATHANIEL LEE, *Alexander the Great*, iv. 2.]

*Dites nous le fin mot* = Tell us the secret.

*Il a le nez fin* = 1. He has a good nose. 2. He is far-sighted, sagacious.

*Jouer au plus fin* = To vie in cunning.

*Ce sont des disputes à n'en plus finir* = Those are **Flamber** endless quarrels.

*C'est un homme flambé* = He is a ruined man, a lost **Flanc** man.

*Il s'est battu les flancs pour rien* = He gave himself **Flétrir** all that trouble for nothing.

*Il est sur le flanc* = He is laid up, on his back.

*Prêter le flanc à des reproches* = To lay oneself open to reproaches.

*\*De rose flétrie nul ne soucie* = The fading rose has **Fleur** no suitor.

*C'est la fine fleur de l'armée* = It is the cream of the **Fleurette** army.

*L'affaire passa à fleur de corde* = The matter only just succeeded.

*Les yeux à fleur de tête* = Goggle eyes (i.e. on a level with the cheek-bone and fore-head).

*À fleur de terre* = On a level (or, flush) with the ground.

*À la fleur de l'âge* = In the prime of life.

*Il a les nerfs à fleur de peau* = His nerves are always on the twitch; He is extremely sensitive.

*Conter fleurettes* = To say soft nothings. **Flûte**

*\*Ce qui vient de la flûte s'en va au tambour* = **Foi**  
Lightly come, lightly go; What is dishonestly acquired is easily dissipated.

*C'est un homme sans foi ni loi* = He is a man without **Foin** honour or honesty.

*Il est de peu de foi* = He is not to be trusted.

*Ses ouvrages en font foi* = His works prove it.

*\*C'est avec la bonne foi qu'on va le plus loin* =  
Honesty is the best policy.

*La foi du charbonnier* = Blind faith.

*Je ne puis ajouter foi à ce qu'il dit* = I cannot believe what he says.

*Ma foi!* = Upon my word!

*Mettre du foin dans ses bottes* = To feather one's **Folie** nest.

[Literally, to place hay in one's wooden shoes to keep one's feet warm.  
Another saying is *Mettre du beurre dans ses épinards*.]

*Avoir du foin dans ses bottes* = To be well off.

*Quand il n'y a pas de foin au râtelier, les chevaux se battent* = When poverty comes in at the door, love flies out at the window.

*Ce qui me lie, c'est ma folie* = Straw bands will tie a **Fond** fool's hands.

*Je fais fond sur vous* = I rely on you. **Fonds**

*Il sait cette langue à fond* = He knows that language thoroughly.

*Il est ruiné de fond en comble* = He is utterly ruined.

*Au fond, il a tort* = He is wrong in reality.

*Courir à fond de train* = To run at the top of one's speed.

*Article de fonds* = Leading article (in a newspaper). **Fontaine**

*Il possède une fortune en bien-fonds* = He has a fortune in landed property.

*Il a placé son argent à fonds perdu* = He sank his money in an annuity.

\*“*Travaillez, prenez de la peine;  
C’est le fonds qui manque le moins*” =  
Work and take pains, *that* you can always  
do.  
Hard work and pain  
Are ne’er in vain.

[LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, v. 9.]

\**Il ne faut pas dire, “Fontaine, je ne boirai pas de***Force**  
*ton eau*” = One must never be sure of not wanting  
some one (*or*, something).

[Compare the proverb that Alfred de Musset took for the title of one of  
his Proverbes: “Il ne faut jurer de rien.”]

*Tu me payeras de gré ou de force* = You shall pay**Forgeron**  
me, whether you like it or not.

*Hugo est un romantique dans toute la force du terme*  
= Hugo is a romanticist in the full sense of the  
word.

*Je suis à bout de force* = I am exhausted, played out.

*Je ne suis pas de votre force* = (lit.) I am not so  
strong as you are; (fig.) I am no match for you.

*Force m’est de partir* = I am compelled to go.

*Il faut à toute force l’empêcher de sortir* = You must  
prevent him going out by all the means in your  
power; We must do all we can to prevent him  
going out.

*Il y avait force badauds* = A quantity of loafers were  
there.

\**La force prime le droit* = Might is right. (See [Fort.](#))

*C’est un joueur de première force* = He is a first-rate  
player.

*Force est restée à la loi* = The police proved the stronger; Order was restored.

*C'est un cas de force majeure* = It is a case of absolute necessity; It is an utter impossibility.

[e.g. "Le témoin n'a pu venir parce qu'il est dangereusement malade; son absence est due à un cas de force majeure."]

*Faire force de voiles* = To crowd on all sail.

*Faire force de rames* = To row with all one's might.

\**Tout par amour, rien par force* = Sweet words will succeed where mere strength will fail; You may row your heart out if wind and tide are against you.

*À force de travailler* = By dint of working.

*À force de bras* = By strength of arm.

*De vive force* = By main force.

*Un tour de force* = A feat (of strength or skill).

\**À force de forger on devient forgeron* = Practice**Fort** makes perfect; Drawn wells are seldom dry.

[Lat. *Fit fabricando faber.*]

*Cela est trop fort* (or, *raide*) = That is too bad; That**Fortune** is beyond a joke.

*Cela est par trop fort* = That is really too bad.

[This *par* is derived from the Latin intensive particle *per*, as in *perhorridus*. In French one finds such words as *parfaire*, *parachever*, and in old French this prefix was separable. Thus, *tant il est passage* might be written *tant il par est sage*. So, *Cela est par trop fort* = *Cela est trop parfort*.]

*C'est un esprit fort* = He is a freethinker.

*Voilà qui est fort* = That is rather strong.

*Ça, ce n'est pas fort* = That is very tame; There is not much in that.

*A plus forte raison* = All the more reason; A fortiori.

*Il faut que je parle, c'est plus fort que moi* = I must speak, I cannot help it.

*Le plus fort est fait* = The worst is over; The most difficult part is done.

*Savoir le fort et le faible de l'affaire* = To know the ins and outs of the matter.

*Le fort portant le faible* = One thing with another; On an average.

\*“*La raison du plus fort est toujours la meilleure*” = Might is right; There is no arguing with a large fist.

[LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, i. 10, *Le loup et l'agneau*.]

*Fort comme un Turc* = As strong as a horse.

“*Ou tôt ou tard, ou près ou loin,  
Le fort du faible a besoin*” =  
The lion had need of the mouse.

[GÉNIN, *Récréations*, ii. 250.]

*Chacun a dans sa vie un souris de la fortune* = **Fou**  
Fortune knocks once at every man's door.

*La fortune rit aux sots* = Fools have the best luck.

[“*Fortuna fortes adjuvat*.”—LIVY, xxxiv. 37.]

*Voulez-vous accepter la fortune du pot?* = Will you take pot-luck with us?

*Faire contre fortune bon cœur* = To bear up against misfortune; To make the best of a bad job.

*Cela lui a coûté un argent fou* (fam.) = That cost him **Fouet**  
a heap of money.

\**Combattre un fou est temps perdu* = Fools are not to  
be convinced.

[Schiller says: "Heaven and Earth fight in vain against a dunce" ("Mit der Dummheit fechten Götter selbst vergebens."—*Jungfrau von Orleans*), and the Chinese say: "One never needs his wit so much as when one argues with a fool."]

*Ne faites pas messagers des fous* = "He that sendeth  
a message by the hand of a fool cutteth off the feet  
and drinketh damage." Prov. xxvi. 6.

*Un fol ou bête  
Fait bien conquête,  
Mais bon ménage  
C'est fait du sage* =  
A fool may meet with good fortune, but  
the wise only profit by it.

\**Plus on est de fous plus on rit* = The more the  
merrier.

\**Qui ne sait pas être fou n'est pas sage* = He is not  
wise who does not sometimes make merry; It takes  
a wise man to make a fool.

\**Les fous sont aux échecs les plus proches des rois* =  
In chess the fool stands next to the king. (RÉGNIER,  
*Sat.* xiv.)

[This implies that it is not only at chess that the king is surrounded by  
fools, but at court too. It must not be forgotten that *le fou* is called  
*the bishop* in the English game.]

*Il est fou à lier* (or, *fou furieux*) = He is raving mad.

*Il vaut mieux être fou avec tous que sage tout seul* =  
"One had as good be out of the world as out of the  
fashion."

[COLLEY CIBBER, *Love's Last Shift*, Act ii.]



*La Folle du Logis* = Fancy, imagination.

*Il ne marche qu'à coups de fouet* = He works only **Fouetter** when he is compelled.

*Fouette, cocher!* = Fire away! Go ahead! **Four**

*Il fait noir comme dans un four* = It is as dark as **Fourchette** pitch.

[MOLIÈRE, *Le Sicilien*, ii.]

*Faire un four* = To make a blunder.

*Cette pièce a fait four* = That piece was a failure, a frost.

*On ne peut être au four et au moulin* = One cannot be in two places at the same time.

*Une bonne fourchette* = A good trencherman. **Fourgon**

\**La pelle se moque du fourgon* = The pot calls the **Fourreau** kettle black.

\**L'épée (or, la lame) use le fourreau* = The mind is **Fourrer** too active for the body.

["A fiery soul, which, working out its way,  
Fretted the pigmy body to decay."

DRYDEN, *Absalom and Achitophel*, i.]

*Il ne savait où se fourrer* = He did not know where **Frais** to hide his head.

*Il faut qu'il fourre le doigt (or, more fam., nez) partout* = He must have a finger in every one's pie.

*En être pour ses frais* = To have lost one's money **Français**  
(or, pains) for nothing.

*Faire des frais* = (lit.) To go to expense; (fig.) To  
make efforts to please.

*Faire ses frais* = To cover one's expenses.

*Faire les frais de la conversation* = 1. To keep a  
conversation going. 2. To be (oneself) the subject  
of conversation.

*En bon français* = (lit.) In good French; (fig.) In **Franquette**  
plain English (i.e. without mincing matters).

*Parler français comme une vache espagnole* = To  
speak French very badly.

[This is said to be a corruption of *comme un Basque espagnol*  
(formerly written *Vace*). The Basques speak French with a very bad  
accent, owing to their language having no relation whatever to the  
Romance tongues.]

*Recevoir quelqu'un à la bonne franquette* = To treat **Frein**  
a person without ceremony.

*Ronger son frein* = To put up with annoyance in **Friandise**  
silence.

*A vieille mule frein doré* = Old women have the  
finest clothes.

*Aimer les friandises (chatteries)* = To have a sweet **Friser**  
tooth.

*Elle frise la quarantaine* = She is just upon forty. **Froid**

*Cela se mange froid* = (lit.) That is eaten cold; (fig.) **Front**  
That is a matter of no importance; That is easily  
done.

*Il n'a pas froid aux yeux* = He is a plucky fellow.

*Il fait un froid de loup* = It is terribly cold.

*Vous heurtez de front tous ses préjugés* = You run **Frotter**  
counter to (or, openly attack) all his prejudices.

*Il mène plusieurs affaires de front* = He carries on  
several schemes simultaneously; He has many  
irons in the fire.

*Marcher de front* = To walk abreast.

\**Qui s'y frotte s'y pique* = Whoever meddles with it, **Fuite**  
will smart for it.

[Compare the motto of the Order of the Thistle: Nemo me impune  
laccessit.]

*Je ne vous conseille pas de vous y frotter* = I advise  
you not to meddle with it.

*On l'a frotté d'importance* (or, *comme il faut*) = He  
got a good drubbing.

*Une bonne fuite vaut mieux qu'une mauvaise attente* **Fumée**  
= Discretion is the better part of valour.

*Manger son pain à la fumée du rôti* = To see others **Fur**  
enjoying themselves without joining in.

*Il n'y a pas de feu sans fumée* = There is no smoke  
without fire.

[Though the French form is not exact, it is preferred to “*il n’y a pas de fumée sans feu*” for rhythmical reasons. Compare PLAUTUS, *Curculio*, i. 1, 53, “*Flamma fumo est proxima.*”]

*Au fur et à mesure* = In proportion as.

**Fureur**

*Cela fait fureur maintenant* = That is quite the rage  
now; That is all the go now.

*Changer son fusil d’épaule* = To change one’s  
opinion, profession, tactics.

[A more familiar expression is *retourner sa veste* = to be a turn-coat.]

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## G.

- Gaffe**            *Faire une gaffe* = To put one's foot in it; To make a stupid blunder.
- Gageure**        \**La gageure est la preuve des sots* =  
                         "Most men (till by losing rendered sager),  
                         Will back their own opinions with a wager."  
                         [BYRON, *Beppo*, 27.]
- Gagner**        \**Qui épargne gagne* = A penny saved is a penny earned.  
  
                         *Il gagne à être connu* = He improves upon acquaintance.
- Gai**             *Il est gai comme un pinson* = He is as merry as a grig, as a lark.  
  
                         *Il est gai comme un bonnet de nuit* (ironic.) = He is as dull as ditchwater. (See [Bonnet](#).)
- Gaieté**        *De gaieté de cœur* = Out of pure wantonness.
- Gaillard**       *Être sur le gaillard d'avant* = To serve before the mast; To be a common seaman.
- Galère**        *Vogue la galère!* = Happen what may! "Go it, ye cripples!"

\*“*Que diable allait-il faire dans cette galère?*” =  
Whatever induced him to get into that fix? **Galeux**  
Whatever business had he there?

[MOLIÈRE, *Fourberies de Scapin*, ii. II, imitated from a scene of *Le Pédant joué* by Cyrano de Bergerac, as is noted by M. Edmond Rostand in his play, “Cyrano de Bergerac,” v. 6:

*Rag.* Hier on jouait *Scapin*  
Et j’ai vu qu’il vous a pris une scène.  
*Le Bret.* Entière!  
*Rag.* Oui, Monsieur, le fameux: “Que diable allait-il faire?”

In Molière, Scapin, the amusing but rascally servant of farce, in order to obtain more money out of G ronte, the father of his young master, L andre, pretends that the latter has been taken prisoner on board a Turkish galley and that the captain demands 500 crowns as ransom. G ronte in the dilemma of losing either his money or his son, at last parts with his treasured gold, but not without repeating several times in heartfelt sorrow, “*Que diable allait-il faire dans cette gal re?*”]

\**Il ne faut qu’une brebis galeuse pour infecter tout* **Galon**  
*un troupeau* = One scabby sheep will taint a whole  
flock.

\**Qui se sent galeux, se gratte* (fam.) = If the cap fits,  
wear it. (See [Morveux](#).)

*Quand on prend du galon on n’en saurait trop* **Gant**  
*prendre* = As well be hanged for a sheep as a lamb;  
One cannot make too much of a favourable  
opportunity.

[This is a parody of a line in Quinault’s *Roland*, ii. 5: “Quand on prend de l’amour, on n’en saurait trop prendre.”]

*Il s’en donne les gants* = He takes the credit of it. **Gar on**

[It was the custom to give a pair of gloves to the messenger who first brought a piece of good news.]

*Cela me va comme un gant* = That fits me to a T;  
That suits me down to the ground.

*Vous voilà joli garçon!* = A pretty fellow you are!      **Garde**

*Mon chien est de bonne garde* = Mine is a good **Garder**  
watch-dog.

*Ces poires sont de bonne garde* = These pears will  
keep well.

*Il n'a garde de venir* = He will take care to keep  
away; There is no chance of his coming.

*Il vous en garde une bonne (pop.)* = He is keeping a **Gaspiller**  
rod in pickle for you.

*Gardez-vous en bien!* = Mind you do not do it!

*Ce garçon gaspille son temps* = That boy fools his **Geler**  
time away.

*Geler à pierre fendre* = To freeze very hard.      **Gémir**

*Faire gémir la presse (ironic.)* = To print one's **Gêne**  
writings.

*Il est sans gêne* = He is free and easy (casual, off-**Gêner**  
hand); He makes himself too much at home.

*\*Où il y a de la gêne il n'y a pas de plaisir (ironic.)*  
= There is nothing like making one's self at home  
everywhere.

*Il a connu la gêne* = He knows what want is.

*Est-ce que je vous gêne?* = Am I in your way? **Gens**

*Ne vous gênez pas!* = Do not stand upon ceremony!  
Make yourself at home! Don't mind me!

*Il ne se gêne guère* = Doesn't he make himself at home! Well, he is a cool customer!

*Il est plus gênant que gêné* = His free and easy manners are unpleasant to others, but he does not mind that.

\**A gens de village, trompette de bois* = Rough tools **Gésir**  
for rough work.

\**C'est là que gît le lièvre* = That is the main point; **Gibier**  
There's the rub.

*C'est un gibier de potence* = He is a gallows-bird. **Gloire**

"J'aime mieux, n'en déplaie à la gloire,  
Vivre au monde deux jours que mille ans dans l'histoire."  
MOLIÈRE, *La Princesse d'Élide*, i.  
2. **Gond**

Contrast:

"One crowded hour of glorious life  
Is worth an age without a name."  
SIR WALTER SCOTT, *Old Mortality*, Chap. 34.

*Cela me fait sortir des gonds* = That exasperates **Gorge**  
(unhinges) me.

*Cette fumée me prend à la gorge* = That smoke **Gourme**  
makes me cough, chokes me.



*Il cria à pleine gorge* = He cried out as loud as he could.

*Il fera des gorges chaudes du malheur de sa tante* = He will chuckle over (or, make fun of) his aunt's misfortune.

[*“Prétend qu'elle en fera gorge chaude et curée.”*

LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, iv.  
12.]

*Rendre gorge* = To have to pay back money unjustly acquired; To disgorge one's ill-gotten gains.

*Ce jeune homme jette sa gourme* = That young man **Goût** is sowing his wild oats.

*\*Des goûts et des couleurs il ne faut (pas) discuter* = **Goutte**  
There is no disputing about tastes.

*\*À chacun son goût* = Tastes differ.

[Colloquially the *à* is omitted and the phrase becomes *chacun son goût*. The Dictionnaire de l'Académie gives: *Chacun a son goût*.]

*Je n'y vois goutte* = I cannot see at all. **Grâce**

*\*Goutte à goutte on emplît la cuve* = Many a little makes a mickle.

*\*Ils se ressemblent comme deux gouttes d'eau* = They are as like as two peas.

*C'est une goutte d'eau dans la mer* = It is a drop in the ocean.

*Boire la goutte* (fam.) = To have a drop; To take a nip.

*Payer la goutte* (fam.) = To stand something to drink.

*Faites-moi grâce de vos observations, je vous en***Grain**  
*prie* = Pray spare me your remarks.

*Veillez au grain* = Keep a sharp look-out. **Graine**  
*Avoir un grain de folie* = To be a little cracked.

*Ces plantes sont montées en graine* = Those plants**Grand**  
have run to seed.

*C'est de la graine de niais* = That is something to  
deceive fools with.

*\*Les grands sont les plus exposés aux coups du sort***Grandeur**  
= High winds blow on high hills.

*Faire quelque chose en grand* = To do something on  
a large scale.

*Un buste de grandeur naturelle* = A life-size bust. **Gré**

*\*Bon gré, mal gré* = Whether you wish or not;**Grelot**  
Nolens volens; Willy-nilly.

*Cette maison a été vendue de gré à gré* = That house  
was sold by private contract.

*Il le fera de gré ou de force* = He will have to do it  
whether he likes it or not.

*Il venait moitié de gré, moitié de force* = He came  
somewhat reluctantly.

*De son plein gré* = Of his own accord.

*De plein gré* = Voluntarily.

*Nous vous en saurons bon gré* = We shall be obliged to you for it.

*Je me sais bon gré de ne l'avoir pas fait* = I am thankful I did not do it.

*\*Attacher le grelot* = To bell the cat.

**Grenier**

[This phrase arises from the fable (LA FONTAINE, ii. 2) of the rats who held a council as to how they might best defend themselves from the cat. They resolved to hang a bell round his neck, so that they might hear him coming and run away. But the difficulty was to find a volunteer "to bell the cat." In Scottish history Archibald Douglas, 5th Earl of Angus (1449-1514), was called Bell-the-Cat. James III. used to make favourites of architects and masons. The Scotch nobles held a council in the Church of Lauder for the purpose of putting down these upstarts. Lord Gray asked who would bell the cat. "That will I," said Douglas, and fearlessly he put the minions to death in the King's presence. Compare SCOTT, *Marmion*, v. 14. The Greek equivalent, *Ευρεῖν λέοντα* (= to shave the lion) occurs in Plato, *Republic*, 341 C. The refrain of Eustace Deschamps' Ballade 58 is: "Qui pendra la sonnette au chat?"]

*Il va de la cave au grenier* = 1. He rambles in his **Grippe** talk. 2. He writes very unevenly (up and down).

*Il m'a pris en grippe* = He has taken a dislike to me. **Gris**

*Il en a vu de grises* = He had an unpleasant time of **Grive** it.

*Il lui en a fait voir de grises* = He plagued him terribly.

*\*Faute de grives on mange des merles* = Half a loaf **Gros** is better than no bread. (See [Aimer.](#))

*Ils se sont dit de gros mots* = They came to high words; They insulted (slanged) one another.

*La servante fait le gros de la besogne* (or, *la grosse besogne*) = The servant does the heavy work.

*Il n'a qu'un gros bon sens* = He has only plain common-sense.

*Vous avez touché la grosse corde* = You have come to the main point.

*Vendre en gros et en détail* = To sell wholesale and retail.

*Il m'a fait faire le pied de grue pendant deux heures* = He made me wait two hours for him; I was dancing attendance on him for two hours.

[“Faites vous sus un pied toute la nuit la grue?”]

RÉGNIER, *Sat.* xi.]

\**À la guerre comme à la guerre* = One must take things as they come; We must take the rough with the smooth.

*Je l'ai fait de guerre lasse* = Weary of resistance I did it for the sake of peace and quiet.

\**Qui terre a, guerre a* = Much coin, much care; Much land, many lawsuits.

[Voltaire's variant was: “Qui plume a, guerre a.”]

*Ça, c'est de bonne guerre* = He has only used fair means to defend himself (or, attack you); He has acted within his rights, you cannot complain.

*Mener la vie à grandes guides* = (lit.) To drive life four in hand; (fig.) To live a very fast life.

\**Qui croit guiller Guillot, Guillot le guille* =

**Guisse**

“He that seeks others to beguile  
Is oft overtaken in his wile.”

The biter bit.

[“For often he that will begyle  
Is gyled with the same gyle,  
And thus the gyler is begyled.”

GOWER, *Confessio Amantis*,  
135.

“For ’tis the sport to have the enginer  
Hoist with his own petar.”

*Hamlet*, iii. 4.]

*Il fait* (or, *agit*) *toujours à sa guise* = He always goes  
his own way; He always acts according to his own  
sweet will.

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## H.

|                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Habit</b>   | <p><i>*L'habit ne fait pas le moine</i> = The cowl does not make the friar; The coat does not make the gentleman.</p> <p><i>Prendre l'habit</i> = To become a monk or a nun (of the latter, To take the veil).</p>                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Habitué</b> | <p><i>Ce monsieur est un de nos habitués</i> = That gentleman is one of our regular customers.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Hache</b>   | <p><i>Cela est fait à coups de hache</i> (or, <i>serpe</i>) = That is done clumsily, roughly.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| <b>Hacher</b>  | <p><i>Je les hacherais menu comme chair à pâté</i> = I would make mincemeat of them.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| <b>Haleine</b> | <p><i>J'ai couru à perte d'haleine</i> = I ran until I was out of breath.</p> <p><i>Ce sont des phrases à perte d'haleine</i> = Those are very long-winded sentences.</p> <p><i>Il faut tenir les gens en haleine</i> = One must keep the ball rolling.</p> <p><i>C'est un ouvrage de longue haleine</i> = It's a long job, a heavy piece of work.</p> |
| <b>Halle</b>   | <p><i>Le langage des Halles</i> = Billingsgate.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |

[Also: *des injures de carrefour*.]

## Hallebarde

*Cela rime comme hallebarde et miséricorde* = That **Hanter**  
does not rhyme at all.

[The usual explanation of this expression is, that, on the death of the verger of St. Eustache, one of his friends—a small shopkeeper of the neighbourhood—wished to write an epitaph for his tomb. Being entirely ignorant of the rules of verse, he composed the following:

—  
“Ci-gît mon ami Mardoche  
Il a voulu être enterré à Saint Eustache  
Il y porta trente-deux ans la hallebarde  
Dieu lui fasse miséricorde.”

(Par son ami, J. Cl. Bombet,  
1727.)

But in reality the proverb is much older. It dates from the time of the old versifiers, one of whose rules was that two consonants followed by an *e* mute were sufficient to form a feminine rhyme. This led to abuses like the above, and this rule was superseded by another, that the vowel preceding the two consonants must be alike in both cases.]

*Dis-moi qui tu hantes, je te dirai qui tu es* = A man is **Haro**  
known by his company; Birds of a feather flock  
together.

*Crier haro sur quelqu'un* = To raise an outcry **Hasard**  
against any one.

[“À ces mots on cria haro sur le baudet.”

LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, vii.  
1.

The origin of the word *haro* is disputed; Littré quotes Diez, who connects it with O.H.G. *hera* = here. The old opinion was that it was derived from *Ha-Raoul*, an appeal to Rollo, or Hrolf, first Duke of Normandy, and a mighty lawgiver. However, within living recollection the cry of *Ha-Ro! à l'aide, mon Prince!* was used in the Channel Islands as a protection against force and fraud, when no other defence was possible. See a curious tale in “The Gossiping Guide to Jersey,” by J. Bertrand Payne, London, 1863, p. 15.]

*Il corrige le hasard* = He cheats at play.

**Hâte**

[“La fortune est redevenue mauvaise, il faut la corriger.”

HAMILTON, *Mémoires de Grammont*, iii.]

\**Trop de hâte gâte tout* = The more haste, the less speed. **Hâter**

[Also: *Plus on se hâte, moins on avance*; *Hâtez-vous lentement* (Lat. *Festina lente*); *Assez tôt si bien*; and the English popular proverb, “Do nothing hastily save catching of fleas.”]

\**Ouvrage hâté, ouvrage gâté* = Haste makes waste. **Haut**

*Tomber de son haut* = (fig.) To be thunder-struck. **Herbe**

*Regarder de haut en bas* = To treat contemptuously;  
To look down upon with contempt.

*Il y a du haut et du bas dans la vie* = Life has its ups and downs.

*Haut le pied!* = Be off!

\**Mauvaise herbe croît toujours* = Ill weeds grow apace. **Heure**

*Votre rival vous coupera l’herbe sous le pied* = Your rival will cut you out, will take the wind out of your sails, will cut the ground from under your feet.

*L’herbe sera bien courte s’il ne trouve à brouter* = It will go hard if he does not pick up a living; He would live on nothing.

*C’est un avocat en herbe* = He is studying for the bar; He is a sucking barrister.



*A l'heure qu'il est on ne le fait plus* = Nowadays it is **Histoire** no longer done.

*A l'heure qu'il est il doit savoir la nouvelle* = By this time no doubt he has heard the news.

*Faites-le sur l'heure* = Do it this very minute.

*Je partirai tout à l'heure* = I will start presently.

*Je l'ai vu tout à l'heure* = I saw him just now, not long ago.

*A la bonne heure!* = Well done!; That's right!; Capital!; That is something like!

*Le quart d'heure de Rabelais* = The moment of payment (or, suspense).

[On returning from Italy, Rabelais found himself in the south of France with no more money to continue his journey to Paris. He had dined well at an inn, and while waiting for his reckoning, he packed up some dust in small packets which he labelled, "Poison for the King," "Poison for the Dauphin," and so on. The innkeeper noticing these packets and their terrible inscriptions, informed the police, who took Rabelais to Paris free of charge to suffer the penalty of treason. When he was brought before the King, the monarch laughed heartily at the tale and let him go free.]

*Passer un mauvais quart d'heure* = To have a bad time of it.

*Voilà bien des histoires pour si peu de chose!* = What **Hommage** a fuss about nothing.

*Voilà bien une autre histoire!* = That is quite another thing.

*Histoire (or, Chansons) que tout cela!* = That is all stuff and nonsense.

*Le plus beau de l'histoire c'était qu'il n'en savait rien* = The best of the joke was he knew nothing about it.

*Histoire de rire* = 1. For the fun of the thing. 2. It was only a joke.

*Hommage de l'auteur* = With the author's **Homme** compliments.

\**L'homme propose et Dieu dispose* = Man proposes, **Honneur** God disposes.

[Also: "*L'homme s'agite et Dieu le mène.*"

FÉNELON, *Sermon pour la Fête de l'Épiphanie*, 1685.

"A man's heart deviseth his way, but the Lord directeth his steps."—  
PROVERBS xvi. 9.

"There's a divinity that shapes our ends,  
Rough hew them how we will."—*Hamlet*, v. 2.

German: Der Mensch denkt, Gott lenkt.]

\**Le style c'est l'homme* = Style is the man himself;  
Like author, like book.

[*"Ces choses sont hors de l'homme, le style est l'homme même."*—  
BUFFON, *Discours de Réception à l'Académie*, 1753. There has been much discussion as to what Buffon really did write, whether *le style est l'homme même* or *le style est DE l'homme même*. In most editions after that of Didot (1843) the latter form will be found, whilst in editions from 1800-1843 the phrase is absent altogether. In the *Recueil de l'Académie* it is printed *le style est l'homme même*, and of this the proofs were probably corrected by Buffon himself. There is a small pamphlet, *Discours prononcé dans l'Académie française, par M. de Buffon, le samedi 25 août 1753*, which is probably earlier still, in which it is also printed thus. However this may be, the phrase "*le style c'est l'homme*," which Buffon assuredly did *not* write, has become a French proverb, and is in everyday use.]

*Nous jouons pour l'honneur* = We are playing for **Honte** love.

\**Un homme d'honneur n'a que sa parole* = An honest man's word is as good as his bond.

*Il fait honneur à ses affaires* (comm.) = He meets all his engagements.

*Il ne prétend à votre fille qu'en tout bien tout honneur* = He has honourable intentions towards your daughter.

*Nous lui avons fait honte* = 1. We caused him to feel **Honteux** ashamed of himself. 2. He was ashamed of us.

\**Jamais honteux n'eut belle amie* = Faint heart never **Hors** won fair lady.

\**Il n'y a que les honteux qui perdent* = Nothing ask, nothing have.

*Hors ligne* = Standing out from the rest; Out of the **Hôte** common run; Beyond comparison; Incomparable.

*Ce peintre est hors concours* = That artist is no longer a competitor (having already received the highest award).

\**Qui compte sans son hôte compte deux fois* = He **Huile** who reckons without his host must reckon again.

*Sentir l'huile* = To smell of the lamp (of poetry, etc.). **Huis**

*Il tirerait de l'huile d'un mur* = He would skin a flint, get blood from a stone. (See [Cheveux](#) and [Euf.](#))

[Aquam a pumice postulare.—PLAUTUS.]

*De l'huile de bras* = Elbow grease.

*A huis clos* = With closed doors; in camera.

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## I.

|                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|-------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Image</b>      | <i>Cette petite fille est sage comme une image</i> = That little girl is very quiet, is as good as gold.                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Importance</b> | <i>Faire l'homme d'importance</i> = To play the consequential; To give oneself airs; To be pompous.                                                                                                                                               |
| <b>Importer</b>   | <i>Qu'importe?</i> = No matter! It is of no consequence.<br><i>Que m'importe?</i> = What is that to me?<br><i>Peu importe</i> = It does not much matter.<br><i>Venez n'importe quand</i> = Come at any time, no matter when, whenever you please. |
| <b>Impossible</b> | <i>*A l'impossible nul n'est tenu</i> = There is no doing impossibilities; No living man all things can.                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Index</b>      | <i>Les grévistes mirent cette boutique à l'index</i> = The strikers boycotted that shop.<br>[The <i>Index Expurgatorius</i> is a list of books compiled for the Pope which Roman Catholics are forbidden to read.]                                |
| <b>Injure</b>     | <i>Ils se sont dit mille injures</i> = They abused one another like pickpockets.<br><i>Vous lui faites injure</i> = You wrong him.                                                                                                                |

**Inscrire**      *Je m'inscris en faux contre cette assertion* = I emphatically deny the truth of that assertion.

**Insu**      *Il sortit à mon insu* = He went out without my knowing it.

**Intelligence**      *Vivre en bonne intelligence avec quelqu'un* = To live on good terms with some one.

**Intention**      \**L'intention est réputée pour le fait* = The will is taken for the deed.  
  
*J'ai mis ce livre de côté à voire intention* = I put that book on one side especially for you (to read, to see).

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## J.

- Jamais**      *Au grand jamais* = Never, no never.
- Jambe**      *Il court à toutes jambes* = He is running as fast as his legs will carry him.  
[Compare: *à toute bride, à toute vapeur, à toute vitesse.*]  
*Il a pris ses jambes à son cou* = He took to his heels.  
*Il a joué des jambes* = He took to flight.  
*Il a des jambes de quinze ans* = He still walks well.  
*Cela ne lui rend pas la jambe mieux faite!* (ironic.) =  
And a lot of good that will do him!  
*Cela vous ferait une belle jambe* (ironic.) = A fine lot  
of good that will do you.  
*Il a les jambes en manche de veste* (fam.) = He is  
bow-legged.  
*Il le fera par dessous la jambe* = He will do it with  
the greatest ease (or, carelessly).  
*Il a des fourmis dans les jambes* = He is fidgety,  
restless.
- Jaune**      *Jaune comme un coing* = As yellow as a guinea.
- Jean**      *Être gros Jean comme devant* = To be no better off  
than one was before, in spite of all one's efforts.  
[RABELAIS, *Pantagruel*, iv. second prologue, and LA FONTAINE, *Fables*,  
vii. 10.]

**Jeter**            *Il jette son argent par les fenêtres* = He plays ducks and drakes with his money.

*C'est jeter de l'huile sur le feu* = It is adding fuel to the fire (flames).

**Jeu**            \**Jeu qui trop dure ne vaut rien* (Charles d'Orléans)  
= Too much of a good thing is bad.

*C'est vieux jeu* = That is quite old-fashioned.

*Ne me mettez pas en jeu* = Do not mix me up in it.

*Cela passe le jeu* = That is beyond a joke.

\**Jeu de mains, jeu de vilains* = 1. Horse-play is not gentlemanly. 2. Rough play often ends in tears.

*Il fait bonne mine à mauvais jeu* = He puts a good face on the matter; He makes the best of a bad job.

\**A beau jeu beau retour* = One good turn deserves another.

*Nous sommes à deux de jeu* = We are even; We are a match for each other; Two can play at that game.

*Je vous donne beau jeu* = (lit.) I give you good cards;  
(fig.) I give you a good opportunity; I play into your hands.

*Jouer gros jeu* = (lit.) To play for high stakes; (fig.)  
To risk very much in an attempt.

*Cela n'est pas du jeu* = 1. That is not fair, not cricket; You are not playing the game. 2. That was not agreed upon.

**Jeune**            \**Qui jeune n'apprend, rien ne saura* = An old dog will learn no tricks. (See [Jeunesse](#).)



## Jeunesse

*\*Si jeunesse savait, si vieillesse pouvait* = If only the young had experience and the old strength; If things were to be done twice, all would be wise.

*Ce que poulain prend en jeunesse, il le continue en vieillesse* =

“’Tis education forms the common mind.  
Just as the twig is bent the tree’s inclined.”

[POPE, *Moral Essays*, i. 149.]

Youth and white paper take any impression.

[Also: *Vieil arbre mal aisé à redresser*. Compare the English, “Old dogs are hard to train.” (See [Jeune](#).)

“Train up a child in the way he should go, and when he is old he will not depart from it.”—PROVERBS xxii. 6.]

*Il faut que jeunesse se passe* = Boys will be boys.

## Joie

*Un rabat-joie* = A mar-joy; A wet blanket.

## Jouer

*Il joua de son reste* = He played his last card; He was on his last legs.

[Carefully distinguish this from *Jouir de son reste* = To make the most of one’s remaining time.]

*Il joue au plus sûr* = He plays a safe game.

*Jouer de malheur* = To have a run of ill-luck.

*Jouer serré* = To act cautiously; To leave nothing to chance.

## Jour

*Ces gens vivent au jour le jour* = Those men live from day to day, from hand to mouth.

*\*À chaque jour suffit sa peine* = Sufficient unto the day is the evil thereof.

*Je suis à jour* = I am up to date; I am not behind in my work.

**Juge**

\**Tôt ou tard la vérité se fait jour* = Sooner or later the truth will come out.

*C'est le jour et la nuit* = They are as different as chalk and cheese.

*Il n'est si long jour qui ne vienne à vêpres* =  
"Be the day weary, be the day long,  
At length it ringeth to evensong."

[From a poem by Stephen Hawes, a poet of the reign of Henry VII.

Compare:

"Come what come may,  
Time and the hour runs through the roughest day."  
*Macbeth*, i.  
3.

And:

Come day, go day,  
God brings Sunday.]

*A bon jour, bonne œuvre* = The better the day, the better the deed.

\**Ce n'est pas tous les jours fête* = 1. Christmas comes but once a year. 2. One cannot always have "a high old time," but must work as well. 3. Life is not all beer and skittles.

*D'aujourd'hui en huit* = This day week.

*Il y a aujourd'hui huit jours* = This day last week.

*En plein jour* = In broad daylight.

*Il y a quinze ans jour pour jour* = It was fifteen years ago to the very day.

*Prendre jour* = To agree upon a day for an appointment.

*\*De fou juge brève (brève) sentence* = A fool's bolt **Juger**  
is soon shot.

*Juger sur l'étiquette du sac* = To judge by **Jurer**  
appearances, by the exterior.

*Au juger* = At a guess.

*Le vert jure avec le jaune* = Green does not match **Juste**  
with yellow; Green clashes with yellow.

*Jurer comme un templier (charretier, païen)* = To  
swear like a trooper.

*Au plus juste prix* = At the lowest price. **Justice**

*Comme de juste* = Rightly enough.

[Littré condemns this expression as ungrammatical, giving the correct  
form as: *comme il est juste*. It is, however, almost universally used.]

*Passer à pleines voiles à travers les mailles de la  
justice* = To drive a coach-and-four through an Act  
of Parliament.

[Also: *Il est facile de donner une entorse à la loi*.]

*La justice ne connaît personne* = Justice is no  
respector of persons.

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## L.

**Là**                    *Je jette là mon soufflet avec dépit* = I fling aside my bellows in disgust.

[É. SOUVESTRE, *Le Philosophe sous les toits*.]

**Laine**                *Nous sommes allés chercher de la laine et nous sommes revenus tondus* = We went out to shear and returned shorn; The biter bit.

**Laisser**            *Cela laisse à désirer* = There is room for improvement; It is not quite the thing.

*Je ne laisse pas d'être inquiet* = In spite of all that, I am anxious.

[Here we have the old meaning of *laisser* (= *laxare*) to leave off. Hence, I do not leave off being anxious.]

*C'est à prendre ou à laisser* = You must take it or leave it; It's a case of Hobson's choice.

*Il se laissa faire* = He offered no resistance.

**Langage**            \**“Je vis de bonne soupe et non de beau langage”* = “Fair words butter no parsnips.”

[The French is found in MOLIÈRE, *Les Femmes Savantes*, ii. 7, and the English equivalent in WYCHERLEY, *Plain Dealer*, v. 3.

Also: *C'est un bel instrument que la langue*.]

**Langue**            *Ils tiraient la langue* = (lit.) They put their tongues out; (fig.) They showed signs of distress.

*Il a la langue trop longue* = He cannot hold his tongue.

**Lanterne**

*Il a la langue bien pendue* = He has the gift of the gab.

*Jeter sa langue aux chiens* = To give up guessing (conundrums, etc.). (See [Chat](#).)

*La langue lui a fourché* = He made a slip of the tongue.

*Il veut nous faire prendre des vessies pour des lanternes* = He would have us believe that the moon is made of green cheese.

**Large**

*Prendre le large* = To run for the offing (nav.); To run away.

**Larron**

*Au large* = In the open sea. (See [Plein](#).)

*Ils s'entendent comme larrons en foire* = They are as thick as thieves.

**Latin**

*\*L'occasion fait le larron* = Opportunity makes the thief; Keep yourself from opportunities and God will keep you from sins.

["How oft the sight of means to do ill deeds  
Makes ill deeds done."] SHAKESPEARE, *King John*, iv. 2.]

*Latin de cuisine* = Dog Latin.

**Lettre**

*J'y perds mon latin* = I cannot make it out; I am nonplussed; I can make neither head nor tail of it.

*Être au bout de son latin* (or, *rouleau*) = To be at one's wits' end; Not to know what to do, or say, next.

*Je lui ai dit la chose en toutes lettres* = I told him the **Lever** matter plainly.

*Ne prenez pas ce que je dis au pied de la lettre* = Do not take what I say literally.

*J'en lèverais la main* = I would swear to it; I would **Lèvre** take my oath to it.

[The oath in courts of justice is taken in many countries with the right hand raised, palm outwards. In England we kiss a Bible.]

*Le président leva la séance* = The chairman dissolved the meeting; The Speaker left the chair.

\**À qui se lève matin Dieu prête la main* = It is the early bird that catches the worm.

*J'avais le mot sur le bord des lèvres* (or, *au bout de la langue*) = I had the word at the tip of my tongue.

*Il n'a pas un rouge liard* = He has not a brass **Lièvre** farthing. (See [Radis](#).)

*C'est là que gît le lièvre* = That is the main point; **Ligne** There's the rub.

\**Il ne faut pas courir deux lièvres à la fois* = You must not have too many irons in the fire.

*Il a une mémoire de lièvre* = He has a memory like a sieve.

[Also: *Il est comme les lièvres, il perd la mémoire en courant*.]

*Il veut prendre les lièvres au son du tambour* = He makes a great noise about what should be kept

secret; He divulged a plan which to succeed had to be kept secret.

*C'est un homme hors ligne* = He is a first-rate man. **Linotte**  
(See [Hors.](#))

*Il est en première ligne* = He is in the front rank.

*Il a une tête de linotte* = He is a hare-brained fellow. **Livre**

*Traduire à livre ouvert* = To translate at sight. **Loin**

*Revenir de loin* = 1. To come back from a distant place. 2. To recover from a very severe illness. **Long**

*De loin en loin* = At long intervals.

*\*Tout s'use à la longue* = Everything wears out in time. **Longer**

[*Tout passe, tout casse, tout lasse.*]

*Il se promenait de long en large* = He was walking up and down, to and fro.

*Il en sait trop long* = He knows too much.

*Il m'a raconté la chose tout au long* = He told me every detail of the affair.

*Il était étendu tout de son long* = He was lying at full length.

*Longer la côte* = To hug the shore. **Longueur**

*Ce procès traîne en longueur* = That lawsuit is **Louer** dragging on slowly.

\**Qui se loue s'emboue* = Self-praise is no **Loup** recommendation.

*Il marche à pas de loup* = He walks stealthily. **Lundi**

*Il est connu comme le loup blanc* = He is known to every one.

\**Quand on parle du loup, on en voit la queue* (or, *il sort du bois*) = Speak of angels and you hear their wings; Talk of the devil, he is sure to appear.

\**Le loup mourra dans sa peau* = A bad thing never dies; A bad man will die a bad man.

[*Lupus pilum mutat non mentem*. Erasmus (Adagia 989) gives the Greek origin of this saying, ὁ λύκος τὴν τρίχα οὐ τὴν γνώμην ἀλλάττει, but he quotes no author.]

*Tenir le loup par la queue* = To have hold of the sow by the wrong ear.

*On fait toujours le loup plus gros qu'il n'est* = A tale never loses in the telling.

\**Il faut hurler avec les loups* = When we are at Rome we must do as Rome does; You must do as others do; He who kennels with wolves must howl.

["Evil communications corrupt good manners" (1 Cor. xv. 33). Paul quoted this iambic line form Menander's "Thais," "φθείρουσιν ἥθη χρηστὰ ὁμιλίας κακάι."

The proverb about Rome is said to have originated with St. Ambrose, who, when he was asked by St. Augustine whether he should fast on Saturday or not when he was at Rome, although he was not accustomed to do so when at home, replied: "When I am at home I do not fast on Saturday; but when I am at Rome I do, and I think you should follow the custom of every city you visit, if you would avoid scandal." From this reply originated the hexameter: Cum



Romæ fueris Romano vive more = When you shall be at Rome, live after the Roman fashion.]

*Tenir le loup par les oreilles* = To be in a critical situation; To have caught a Tartar.

[“Auribus lupum teneo.”—TERENCE, *Phormio*, iii. 2, 21.]

*Il fait un froid de loup* = It is terribly cold.

\**Les loups ne se mangent pas entre eux* = Dog does not eat dog; There is honour among thieves. (See [Corsaire](#).)

*Renfermer le loup dans la bergerie* = To set the fox to keep the geese.

*Ils se sont mis dans la gueule du loup* = They rushed into the lion’s mouth.

*C’est un vieux loup de mer* = He is an old sea dog.

*Faire la Saint-*

*Lundi*

*Fêter Saint Lundi*

*Faire le Lundi*

} = To do no work on  
Monday.

**Lune**

*Faire un trou à la lune* = “To shoot the moon”; To flee from one’s creditors. (See [Cloche](#).)

*Vouloir prendre la lune avec les dents* = To attempt impossibilities.

[“Prendre la lune aux dents serait moins difficile.”

LA FONTAINE, *Le Roi Candaule*.]

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## M.

**Mâcher**      *Je ne lui ai pas mâché la chose* = I did not mince matters with him.

*Je lui ai donné sa besogne toute mâchée* = I gave him his work all ready cut out; I made his work as easy as possible for him.

**Madame**      *Elle fait la Madame* = She gives herself airs (of little girls).

**Mai**      *Mi-mai, queue d'hiver* = The middle of May has usually three cold days (called *Les saints de glace*, May 11, 12, and 13).

**Maigre**      *Faire maigre* = To abstain from meat.

*Faire maigre chère* = To have poor fare.

*Maigre comme un clou* = As thin as a lath.

**Maille**      *Il n'a ni sou ni maille* = He has not got a rap, a brass farthing.

*Avoir maille à partir avec quelqu'un* = To have a bone to pick (a crow to pluck) with some one.

[*Maille* (= mite) was the smallest coin in France, and therefore could not be divided. Hence the saying means to have a quarrel with some one. Notice the old meaning of *partir* in this idiom = to divide (Lat. *partiri*).]

**Malheur** \**À quelque chose malheur est bon* = It is an ill wind that blows no one any good.

[“À quelque chose sert le malheur.”

MONTAIGNE, *Essais*, ii.  
17.]

*Pour surcroît (or, comble) de malheur il tomba malade* = To crown his misfortunes he fell ill.

\**Un malheur ne vient jamais seul* = Misfortunes never come singly; It never rains but it pours.

[Ital. *Benedetto è quel male, che vien solo* = Blessed is that misfortune which comes alone.]

*Il n'est qu'heur et malheur* = That's the way of the world.

**Manant** *C'est un manant* = He is a coarse, ill-educated boor.

[From *manens* = one remaining fixed to the soil, a villein, serf.]

**Manche (m.)** *Il branle dans le manche (or, au manche)* = He is no longer firmly established in his post; He is irresolute.

\**Jeter le manche après la cognée* = To throw the rope after the bucket; To give up in despair.

**Manche (f.)** *Je ne me ferai pas tirer par la manche* = I shall not require much pressing.

*C'est une autre paire de manches* = That is quite another thing; That is a horse of another colour, another pair of shoes.

*J'ai gagné la première manche* = I won the first game (out of two or more).

*Je l'ai dans ma manche* = I have him at my disposal.

**Manger**      *Il mange comme quatre* = He eats like an ogre.  
*Il a mangé son pain blanc le premier* = He had the happiest part of his life first. (See [Pain](#).)  
*Manger son blé en herbe* = To anticipate one's revenue.  
*Il a mangé de la vache enragée* = He has suffered many privations.  
*Il est très inquiet, il en perd le boire et le manger* = He is very anxious, he has lost his appetite.

**Manière**      *Je l'ai rossé de la belle manière* (fam.) = I gave him a sound thrashing.

**Manquer**      *Vous me manquez* = I miss you.  
*Je vous manque* = You miss me.  
*Il a manqué d'être pris* = He was nearly caught.  
*C'est un avocat manqué* = He is a would-be barrister; He is a failure as a barrister.  
*C'est un garçon manqué* = She is a tomboy.  
*Ce serait manquer d'usage* = That would be a breach of good manners.  
*Il ne manquait plus que cela!* = That crowns all! That is the last straw!

**Marchand**      *C'est un marchand de soupe* = He is a regular Squeers.

[This is said of a private schoolmaster who, far from regarding his profession as an honourable one, follows it solely with a view to profit, by having few and inferior assistants and by feeding his pupils cheaply and badly (thus making a profit on the *soup*). He

looks upon teaching as the least important part of his work. Of course, this race of men is now entirely extinct.]

## **Marché**

*Par dessus le marché* = Into the bargain; Over and above. **Marée**

*Il m'a mis le marché à la main* = He told me I could take it or leave it; He made me decide one way or the other.

*Est-ce marché fait?* = Is it a bargain?

*Vous en êtes quitte à bon marché* = You came off cheaply.

*Vous aurez bon marché de lui* = You will easily get the better of him.

*Je fais bon marché de cela* = I hold that very cheap.

*On n'a jamais bon marché d'une mauvaise marchandise* = A bad thing is dear at any price; The best is the cheapest in the end.

\**Ce qui vient de flot s'en retourne de marée* = **Mariée**  
Fortune is as quick in going as in coming. (See [Flûte.](#))

*Il se plaint que la mariée est trop belle* = He **Marmite**  
complains that he has got too good a bargain.

*Faire bouillir la marmite* = To keep the pot boiling. **Marotte**

*Chacun a sa marotte* = Every one has his hobby. **Mars**

[Marotte is a kind of sceptre or rattle with a head on the end, furnished with bells, which jesters carry.]

*\*Mars venteux et Avril pluvieux*

**Marteau**

*Font le Mai gai et gracieux =*

March winds and April showers

Make way for May flowers.

*\*Mieux vaut être marteau qu'enclume = Better be***Martel**  
striker than struck.

*Être entre l'enclume et le marteau = To be in a*  
dilemma; To be between the devil and the deep  
sea.

*Graisser le marteau = To tip the porter.*

[There is the same idea in "Palm oil."]

*Il s'est mis martel en tête = He made himself very***Massacrer**  
uneasy.

*Il est d'une humeur massacrante = He is as cross as***Matière**  
two sticks.

*Il est bien enfoncé dans la matière = He is very***Matin**  
coarse, very prosaic.

*La table des matières = The table of contents (of a*  
book).

*Il partira un de ces quatre matins = He will start one***Maure**  
of these fine days.

*Traiter quelqu'un de Turc à Maure = To treat a***Mèche**  
person brutally.

[As the Turks treated the Moors when they conquered the north of Africa. See MOLIÈRE, *Précieuses Ridicules*, 10.]

\**À laver la tête d'un Maure* (or, *d'un âne*, or, *d'un nègre*) *on y perd sa lessive* = To endeavour to teach a fool is a waste of time.

*Il a éventé* (or, *vendu*) *la mèche* = He has let the cat **Médaille** out of the bag; He has blown the gaff.

*Il n'y a pas mèche* (pop.) = "It's no go"; There is no doing it.

*C'est le revers de la médaille* = That is the dark side **Médard** of the picture.

*S'il pleut le jour de St. Médard,* **Médecin**  
*Il pleut quarante jours plus tard.*  
*S'il pleut le jour de St. Gervais,*  
*Il pleut quarante jours après =*  
"St Swithin's day, gif ye do rain  
For forty days will it remain."

[Le jour de St. Médard = June 8.  
Le jour de St. Gervais = June 19.  
St. Swithin's Day = July 15.]

*Voilà trois médecins qui ne vous trompent pas:* **Méfiance**  
*Gaîté, doux exercice et modeste repas =*  
The best physicians are Dr. Diet, Dr. Quiet, and Dr. Merriman.

\**La méfiance est mère de la sûreté* = Safe bind, safe **Même** find.

[LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, iii. 18.]

*Il buvait à même la bouteille* = He was drinking out of the bottle itself. **Ménage**

[This is an inversion for *à la bouteille même*. *Boire à même* is not usually used of cups or glasses, but of bottles, jugs, streams, etc. For it implies that the containing vessel itself is being used to drink out of, and not any smaller vessel. Thus *boire à même le verre* would suggest that a spoon or smaller receptacle was not used.]

*Il est à même de vous comprendre* = He is able to understand you.

*Cela revient au même* = That comes to the same thing.

*C'est cela même* = That is the very thing.

*Faites de même* = Do the same.

*Ils font bon ménage* = They live happily together. **Ménager**

*Elle fait le ménage* = She is doing her housework.

\**Qui veut voyager loin ménage sa monture* = Who wishes to go far spares his horse; He who wishes to live long avoids excess. **Mentir**

[RACINE, *Plaideurs*, i. 1.]

\**A beau mentir qui vient de loin* = A traveller may lie with impunity; Travellers tell fine tales. **Méprendre**

*Quasi et presque empêchent les gens de mentir* = Almost and very nigh save many a lie.

*Québec, c'est Saint-Malo à s'y méprendre* (Max O'Rell) = You could easily mistake Quebec for St. Malo. **Mer**



\**Ce n'est pas la mer à boire* = It is not an impossibility; It is not so very difficult after all. **Mérite**

\**Porter de l'eau à la mer* = To carry coals to Newcastle.

*Remplir son mérite* = To act up to one's reputation. **Merle**

\**On ne prend pas les vieux merles à la pipée* = Old birds are not to be caught with chaff. **Merveille**

*Il se porte à merveille* = He is in splendid health. **Messe**

\**Près du moultier, à messe le dernier* = The nearer the church, the farther from God. **Métier**

*Il nous a servi un plat de son métier (or, de sa façon)* = He played us one of his tricks. **Mettre**

\**“À chacun son métier et les vaches seront bien gardées”* (FLORIAN, *Fables*, i. 12) = Let the cobbler stick to his last.

[“Ne sutor ultra crepidam” (judicet).]

*Mettez cent francs* = Make it £4. **Midi**

*Il se mettrait en quatre pour ses amis* = He would do anything for his friends.

*Il se met bien* = He dresses well.

*On veut nous mettre dedans* (fam.) = They want to entrap us, to take us in.

*Chercher midi à quatorze heures* = To make (or, **Mien** seek) difficulties where there are none; To look for grapes on thorns.

[This expression has its origin in the old custom, still in use in some parts of Italy, of reckoning the hours of the day consecutively from 1 to 24, beginning at sunset. Hence, noon may vary from the 16th to the 20th hour, but is never the 14th. Voltaire's epigram for a sundial is very well known, but may bear repetition:—

“Vous qui vivez dans ces demeures,  
Êtes-vous bien? tenez-vous y,  
Et n'allez pas chercher midi  
À quatorze heures.”]

*Chacun connaît midi à sa porte* = Each one knows his own business best.

*J'y ai mis du mien, mettez-y du vôtre* = I have given **Mieux** way a bit, meet me half-way; I have done my share at it, now it's your turn.

*\*Le mieux est l'ennemi du bien* = Leave well alone. **Milieu**

*Ils criaient à qui mieux mieux* = Each was trying to shout louder than the other; Each tried to drown the others' voices.

*Je ne demande pas mieux* = Nothing would give me greater pleasure.

*Elle est mieux que sa sœur* = She is prettier than her sister.

*Faute de mieux* = For want of something better.

*Tant mieux* = So much the better.

*Il est au mieux avec son médecin* = He is on the best terms with his doctor.

*On ne peut mieux* = As well as possible; It could not be better.

*Vous arrivez on ne peut mieux* = You could not have come at a more opportune moment.

*Le juste milieu* = The golden mean.

**Mine**

*Au beau milieu* = In the very midst.

*Vertu gît au milieu* = Do not rush into extremes.

[In medio tutissimus ibis = *Allez par le milieu et vous ne tomberez pas.*  
Compare the English: When slovenly girls get tidy, they polish the bottoms of saucepans.]

*Faire bonne mine à mauvais jeu* = To put a good face on the matter; To make the best of a bad job.

*Il fait mine de ne pas comprendre* = He pretends not to understand.

*Il nous a fait mauvaise (or, grise) mine* = He looked black (sour) at us; He did not receive us well.

*Cet homme a très mauvaise mine* = 1. That man looks a regular ruffian. 2. That man looks very ill.

*Il ne paye pas de mine* = His appearance is against him.

*Ne jugez pas sur la mine* = Do not judge by appearances.

[“Garde-toi, tant que tu vivras,  
De juger des gens sur la mine.”

LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, vi.  
5.]

*Elle fait la mine* = She is sulking.

*Elle est ma tante à la mode de Bretagne* = She is my father's (or, mother's) first cousin; She is my first cousin once removed.

*Elle est ma nièce à la mode de Bretagne* = She is the daughter of my first cousin.

[These phrases are used of any very distant relationship.]

*C'est là son moindre défaut* = That is not a great **Moineau** weakness of hers (*or, his*); That is the last thing you can reproach her (*or, him*) with.

[LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, i. 1.]

*Deux moineaux sur même épi ne sont pas longtemps* **Mois** amis = Two of a trade seldom agree.

[“Καὶ κεραμεὺς κεραμεῖ κοτέει καὶ τέκτονι τέκτων  
Καὶ πτωχὸς πτωχῷ φθονέει καὶ αἰοιδὸς αἰοιδῶ.”

HESIOD, *Opera et dies*,  
25.]

*Il tire sa poudre aux moineaux* = He wastes his trouble for nothing.

*Tous les 36 du mois* = Once in a blue moon.

**Monde**

*C'est vieux comme le monde* = It is as old as the **Monnaie** hills.

*Vous dites des choses de l'autre monde* = You say most out-of-the-way things.

*Il y a un monde fou* = There is a terrible crowd. (See [Fou](#).)

*Vous moquez-vous du monde de parler ainsi?* = Are you making fun of people (are you serious) in speaking thus? Do you take people for a pack of fools?

*Si vous obtenez cinq francs, c'est le bout du monde* = If you get five francs, it is the utmost; You will get five francs at the very outside.

*Si elle a trente ans c'est tout le bout du monde* = She may be thirty at the very outside.

*On ne peut contenter tout le monde et son père* =  
One cannot satisfy everybody, all the world and his  
wife.

[“Parbleu, dit le meunier, est bien fou du cerveau  
Qui prétend contenter tout le monde et son père.”

LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, iii. 1.]

*Il lui a rendu la monnaie de sa pièce* = He paid him **Mont**  
back in his own coin.

*Par monts et par vaux* = Up hill and down dale. **Montée**

*À grande montée grande descente* = The higher the **Montrer**  
rise, the greater the fall; He who climbs too high is  
near a fall.

[“Vaulting ambition which o’erleaps itself.”

SHAKESPEARE, *Macbeth*, i.  
7.

Also: *La Roche Tarpéienne est près du Capitole.*]

*Montrer le soleil avec un flambeau* = To paint the **Mordre**  
lily; To hold a farthing rushlight to the sun.

*Se mordre les doigts* = To repent what one has done. **Mort**

*Se mordre la langue* = To repent what one has said.

*Il est mort de sa belle mort* = He died a natural **Morveux**  
death.

*Il est à l'article de la mort* = He is at the point of  
death, at death's door.

*Quand on compte sur les souliers d'un mort on  
risque de marcher pieds nus* = It's an ill thing to

wait for dead men's shoes; He pulls with a long rope that waits for another's death.

[Also: *Qui s'attend à l'écuelle d'autrui risque fort de mal dîner.*]

*Avoir la mort dans l'âme* = To be grieved to death;  
To be overwhelmed with grief.

\**Qui se sent morveux se mouche* (pop.) = If the cap **Mot** fits, wear it. (See [Galeux](#).)

*Ils en sont venus aux gros mots* = They came to high **Mouche** words.

\**Qui ne dit mot consent* = Silence gives consent.

*Il a toujours le mot pour rire* = He is ever ready with a joke; He is full of fun.

*Il a 40,000 francs de rente au bas mot* = He has £1600 a year at the very least.

\**À bon entendeur demi-mot suffit* (or, *salut*) = A word to the wise is enough; *Verbum sap.*

*Il entend à demi-mot* = He can take a hint.

*Ils se sont donné le mot* = They have passed the word round; They have agreed before-hand what to say.

*Tranchons le mot* = In plain English; Not to mince matters; To put it plainly.

*C'est mon dernier mot* = That is the last concession I can make; I will not take less.

*Il sait le fin mot de tout cela* = He understands the upshot of all this.

*Ne soufflez pas mot!* = Do not breathe a word!

*En deux mots* = To cut a long story short.

*Des mots longs d'une toise* = Words as long as your arm.

[RACINE, *Plaideurs*, i. 1.]

*Je ne mâche pas mes mots* = I don't mince matters; I call a spade a spade.

*Les grosses mouches passent à travers la toile de la***Moudre**  
*justice, mais les petites y sont prises* = One man may steal a horse, while another dare not look over the hedge; Justice will whip a beggar, but bow to a lord; One does the scath, another has the harm; The crow gets pardoned, and the dove has the blame.

["Où la guêpe a passé, le moucheron demeure."]

LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, ii.  
16.

"Quidquid delirant reges, plectuntur Achivi."

HOR., *Ep.*, i.  
2.

Italian: Un fa il peccato, l'altro la penitenza.]

\**Vous faites d'une mouche un éléphant* = You make a mountain out of a molehill.

["Parturiunt montes, nascetur ridiculus mus."]

HORACE, *Ars Poetica*.]

*Quelle mouche vous pique?* = What irritates you?  
What whim have you got into your head?

*Il a pris la mouche* = He is in a huff; He got offended.

\**On prend plus de mouches avec du miel qu'avec du vinaigre* = More is done by kindness than by harshness.

*C'est une fine mouche* = He is a sly dog, a deep one.

*C'est la mouche du coche* = He is a regular busybody; The worst wheel makes the most noise.  
(See [Coche](#) and [Bruit](#).)

*Faire mouche* = To hit the bull's eye.

*Il viendra moudre à notre moulin* = He will be in **Moulin**  
want of us some day.

*C'est un vrai moulin à paroles* = She is a regular **Moutarde**  
chatterbox; He is a regular windbag.

*Il m'a fait monter la moutarde au nez* = He irritated **Moutardier**  
me; He made me lose my temper.

*C'est de la moutarde après dîner* = It comes too late  
to be of any use; It is a day after the fair.

[“Depugnato proelio venire.”—PLAUTUS, *Menaechmi*, v. 6, 30.

“Κατόπιν τῆς ἐορτῆς ἦκεις” = You have come after the feast.—PLATO,  
*Gorgias*.]

*Il se croit le premier moutardier du pape* = He thinks **Mouton**  
no small beer of himself.

\**Revenons à nos moutons* = But to return to our **Moyen**  
subject.

[From an old farce of the fifteenth century, *Maistre Pierre Pathelin*,  
verse 1191, attributed without foundation to Pierre Blanchet. M. F.  
Génin in his edition (1854) gives 1460 as the date, and Antoine de  
la Sale as the author. It was adapted in 1706 by Brueys and Palaprat,  
under the title of *L'Avocat Patelin*. See also RÉGNIER, *Sat.*, ii.]

*Il n'y a pas moyen* = It cannot be done. **Mur**

*Il fait valoir ses moyens* = 1. He makes the best of  
his talents. 2. He boasts of his talents.

*Cet enfant a peu de moyens* = That child is not  
clever.



*Je l'ai mis au pied du mur* = I drove him into a **Muraille** corner; I made him decide one way or the other.

\**Muraille blanche, papier de fou* = Fools write their **Musique** names on walls.

[Late Latin: Stultorum calami, carbones mœnia chartae.]

*Il est réglé comme un papier de musique* = He is as regular as clockwork.

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## N.

- Nage**      *Je suis tout en nage* = I am in a thorough perspiration; I have not a dry thread on me.
- Navette**      *Faire la navette* = To go to and fro between two places several times.
- Nèfle**      *Avoir quelque chose pour des nèfles* (fam.) = To buy something for a mere song.
- Nerf**      *Vous me donnez sur les nerfs* = You get on my nerves; You rile me (fam.).
- Net**      *Mettez cela au net* = Make a fair copy of that.  
*Il a les mains nettes* (fig.) = He is honest; His hands are clean.  
*Refuser net* = To refuse point-blank.
- Nez**      *Il a un pied de nez* (fam.) = He pulls a long face, looks foolish.  
[Also: *Il fait un nez.*]  
*Il a fait un pied de nez* (fam.) = He put his fingers to his nose; “He cut a snook.”  
*Ce coup l’a fait saigner du nez* = That blow made his nose bleed.

*Il a saigné du nez* = (lit.) His nose bled; (fig.) His heart failed him.

**Nid**

*A vue de nez* = By rule of thumb.

*Il veut toujours fourrer son nez partout* (fam.) = He wants to have his finger in every pie. (See [Fourrer](#).)

*On voulait lui tirer les vers du nez* = They wished to pump him.

*Vous vous y casserez le nez* = 1. You will fall on your face. 2. You will knock up against something. 3. You will fail in that.

*Porter le nez au vent* = To stare about aimlessly.

*Il me regarda sous le nez* = He stared me in the face.

*Il me l'a jeté au nez* = He cast it in my teeth.

*Il a le nez fin* = 1. He has a good nose. 2. He is far-sighted, sagacious.

*Qui coupe son nez dégarnit son visage* = It is an ill bird that fouls its own nest; He who cuts off his nose spites his own face.

[Also: *S'arracher le nez pour faire dépit à son visage*.]

*Il me ferma la porte au nez* = He shut the door in my face.

*Il lui en pend autant au nez* = He may expect as much (something unpleasant); He will fare no better.

*On n'a plus trouvé que le nid* = They found the birds  
flown. **Nitouche**

*Elle fait la sainte Nitouche* = She plays the innocent; **Noce**  
She looks as if butter would not melt in her mouth;

She looks very demure.

[*Sainte Nitouche* is derived from *sainte n'y touche*, shortened from *une sainte qui n'y touche pas*. See [Toucher](#).]

*Je n'ai jamais été à pareille noce* (or, *fête*) = I never **Noël**  
had such a time of it.

*Il a fait la noce toute la semaine* = He has had a high  
old time of it all the week; He has been on the  
spree all the week.

[Literally, to enjoy oneself as if one were *a guest at a wedding*, where  
there is plenty of merriment, food, and drink.]

*Je ne suis pas à la noce* = I am not enjoying myself  
at all.

\**Tant crie l'on Noël qu'il vient* (Villon) = Long **Noir**  
looked for comes at last; That is coming—like  
Christmas.

*Quand Noël est vert, les Pâques seront blanches* =  
When the winter is mild, the spring will be wintry.

*Voir tout en noir* = To look on the black side of **Nom**  
things; To have the blues.

[Opposite to: *voir tout en rose*, or, *voir tout couleur de rose*.]

*Broyer du noir* = To have the blues; To feel very sad.

*Nom d'un petit bonhomme!* (fam.) = By Jingo! **Nombre**

*Voilà un nom à coucher dehors (avec un billet de  
logement dans la poche)* = That's a name too ugly  
for words; That's an outlandish name if you like.

*Tout fait nombre* = Every little helps. **Normand**

*C'est répondre en Normand* = That is an evasive answer. **Nourrice**

*Elle dit qu'elle a vingt ans.—Et les mois de* **Nouvelle**  
*nourrice!* (fam.) = She says she is twenty.—And  
the rest!

*Goûtez-moi ce vin; vous m'en direz des nouvelles* **Nue**  
(fam.) = You just taste this wine, you don't get  
wine like that every day; What do you think of that  
for wine, my boy?

*Tomber des nues* = To be astounded. **Nuire**

*\*Ce qui nuit à l'un sert à l'autre* = What is one  
man's meat is another man's poison. **Nuit**

*\*La nuit porte conseil* = Time will show a plan;  
Sleep upon it; Seek advice of your pillow.

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# O.

## Œil

*Se fourrer le doigt dans l'œil* (pop.) = To deceive oneself blindly.

[Sometimes *jusqu'au coude* is added.]

*Il a les yeux au beurre noir* (pop.) = He has a couple of black eyes; He has his eyes in mourning.

[Also: *Il a les yeux pochés*.]

*Je ne vois pas cela d'un bon œil* = I do not look favourably upon that.

*Cela saute aux yeux* = That is evident, obvious; It is as clear as noonday.

*Je l'ai regardé entre les deux yeux* = I looked him straight in the face; I stared at him.

*Entrer à l'œil dans un théâtre* (fam.) = To get into a theatre on the nod (i.e. gratis).

*Avoir le compas dans l'œil* = To have a good eye for distances.

*Elle a des yeux à la perdition de son âme* = Her eyes are so lovely that they will be her ruin.

*Vous ne voyez point votre chapeau? Mais il vous crève les yeux!* = You do not see your hat? Why, it stares you in the face! (it's just under your nose).

*La lumière me tire les yeux* = The light hurts my eyes.

*Il ne le fera pas pour vos beaux yeux* = He will not do it for you for nothing.

*Nous convînmes de cela entre quatre yeux* = We agreed to that between ourselves.

**Œuf**

*Je m'en bats l'œil* (pop.) = I don't care a straw for it.

*Il a les yeux battus* = He has a tired look about his eyes.

*Il a les yeux cernés* = He has dark circles round his eyes.

*Des yeux à fleur de tête* = Goggle eyes. (See [Fleur](#).)

*Ouvrez l'œil, et le bon!* (fam.) = Look out!

*Cela lui a tapé dans l'œil* (pop.) = That took his fancy; He was much struck by that.

*\*Donner un œuf pour avoir un bœuf* = To give a sprat to catch a herring (or, mackerel).

[Also: *Supporter peu pour avoir tout.*]

*\*Faire d'un œuf un bœuf* = To make a mountain out of a molehill.

*Il tondrait sur un œuf* = He would skin a flint. (See [Huile](#) and [Cheveux](#).)

*\*La fin couronne l'œuvre* = The end crowns all; All's well that ends well.

*Mettez la main à l'œuvre* = Put your shoulder to the wheel.

*\*À l'œuvre on connaît l'artisan* = A carpenter is known by his chips; The proof of the pudding is in the eating.

[LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, i. 21, *Les frelons et la mouche à miel*.]

*\*Oignez vilain, il vous poindra:  
Poignez vilain, il vous oindra.*

**Oiseau**

[An old saying used by the French nobles during the middle ages, and found in a collection of proverbs of the thirteenth century.—*Rab.*, i, 21. The Duc de Bourbon, in speaking before the États-Généraux in 1484, said: “Je connais le caractère des vilains. S’ils ne sont opprimés, il faut qu’ils oppriment.”]

Comp. “Tender-handed stroke a nettle,  
And it stings you for your pains;  
Grasp it like a man of mettle,  
And it soft as silk remains.”  
—AARON HILL, *Verses written on a window in Scotland.*]

*Il a battu les buissons, un autre a pris l’oiseau* = **HeOisiveté**  
did the work and another had the profit.

[Donatus in his “Life of Virgil” quotes the famous line: “Sic vos non vobis nidificatis aves.” Hesiod says of drones: “ἀλλότριον κάματον σφετέρην ἐς γαστερ’ ἀμῶνται = Into their own bellies they scrape together the labour of others.” The Talmud says: “One says grace and another eats”; the New Testament: “One soweth, another reapeth.” Henry V. is reported to have said: “Shall I beat the bush and another take the bird?” when it was proposed to him to give up the Duke of Orleans to the Burgundians.]

*\*À tout oiseau son nid est beau* = Home is home, be it ever so homely. (See [Chez.](#))

*“Aux petits des oiseaux il donne leur pâture”* = He that sends mouths sends meat.

[RACINE, *Athalie*, ii. 7.]

*À vue d’oiseau* = A bird’s-eye view.

*À vol d’oiseau* = As the crow flies.

*\*“L’oisiveté est la mère de tous les vices”* = “For**On** Satan finds some mischief still for idle hands to do.”—WATTS, *Divine Songs*, xx. (See [Fille.](#))

[COLLÉ, *La Partie de Chasse de Henri IV.*, iii. 1. Also: *Négligence mène déchéance* = Idle men tempt the devil.]



*On est un sot* = “They-say-so” is half a liar.

**Ongle**

[Note that there is no liaison after *On* here.]

*Il a de l'esprit jusqu'au bout des ongles* = He is **Onguent**  
witty to the tips of his fingers; He is extremely  
witty.

*Il a bec et ongles* = He will fight with beak and claw,  
tooth and nail.

*\*Dans les petites boîtes les bons onguents* = Small **Opiner**  
parcels hold fine wares. (See [Aune](#).)

*Il opine du bonnet* = He agrees with the previous **Oreille**  
speakers without saying a word.

[From the custom of judges who agreed with the decision of a brother  
judge, taking off their caps and saying nothing. It is also said of a  
subordinate who always agrees with his superior.]

*Il se fera tirer l'oreille* = He will require pressing. **Orfèvre**

*Il se retira l'oreille basse* = He went away  
crestfallen.

*J'ai les oreilles rebattues de cela* = I am tired of  
hearing that.

*Il dort sur les deux oreilles* = (lit.) He sleeps  
soundly; (fig.) His mind is quite easy.

*Il n'écoute que d'une oreille* = He pays very little  
attention to what is being said.

*Ne venez pas ainsi me corner aux oreilles* = Do not  
come and din it into my ears in that way.

*Il fait la sourde oreille* = He turns a deaf ear; He pretends not to hear.

*Je n'entends pas de cette oreille-là* = I will not listen to that.

*Par dessus les oreilles* = Over head and ears.

*Autant lui en pend à l'oreille* = He may expect the same (something unpleasant). (Compare *Nez*.)

*Les oreilles ont dû vous corner (tinter)* = Your ears must have burned.

*Je lui froterai les oreilles* = I will twist his tail for him.

\*“*Vous êtes orfèvre, Monsieur Josse!*” = That is a bit **Orgueil** of special pleading; That is not disinterested advice; There's nothing like leather!

[MOLIÈRE, *L'Amour Médecin*, i. 1. This quotation refers to Sganarelle's daughter who suffers from an incurable lowness of spirits. All his neighbours give him advice as to how to cure her; among them, Monsieur Josse, a jeweller, suggests that a fine necklace of diamonds or rubies would undoubtedly cure her. The father, distracted though he be, is not so far gone as not to see through this remark, and he replies in the words that have since become proverbial.]

\**Il n'est orgueil que de sot enrichi* = Set a beggar on **Orme** horseback, he'll ride to the devil.

\**Attendez-moi sous l'orme* = You may wait for me **Ortie** till doomsday.

*Rabelais jeta le froc aux orties* = Rabelais was an **Ôter** unfrocked priest.

*Ôte-toi de là que je m'y mette* = You get out and let **Oublier** me get in.

[Origin unknown; probably le Vicomte de Ségur first used it. Comp. Sancho Panza, "Imitando al juego de los muchachos que dicen 'Salta tu y dámela tu' doy un salto del gobierno."]

*Oublions le passé* = Let bygones be bygones. **Ours**

*C'est un ours mal léché* = He is an ill-licked cub; He **Ouvrier** is an ill-bred [or, ill-shapen] fellow.

[LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, xi. 7.]

*C'est le pavé de l'ours* = Save me from my friends.

["Rien n'est si dangereux qu'un ignorant ami  
Mieux vaudrait un sage ennemi."]

LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, viii.  
10.

An old gardener, feeling lonely, had adopted a bear as a companion. One day, when his master was asleep, he sees a fly on his face; he tries to drive it away, but it declines to move, so he takes up a huge paving-stone and kills the fly—and his master too.]

\**Mauvais ouvrier n'a jamais bons outils* = A bad **Ouvrier** workman always blames his tools.

*Il traduit à livre ouvert* = He translates at sight.

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## P.

### Paille

*Tout y va, la paille et le blé* = He spends all he has.

*Il mourra sur la paille* = He will die in the gutter.

*Il est sur la paille* = He is exceedingly poor.

*Tirons à la courte paille* = Let us draw lots.

*\*Cela enlève la paille* = “That takes the cake.”

[The French is hardly as popular an expression as the English, which might be rendered in French by *décrocher la timbale*. Quitard derives *paille* from *païlle*, a kind of rich cloth given as a prize in athletic contests. Littré imagines it originated with amber, which has the property of raising light objects, such as straw. Madame de Sévigné writes (13th Jan. 1672): “Racine a fait une comédie qui s’appelle Bajazet et qui enlève la paille.” The English expression is said to come from the custom of negroes, when giving a ball, to provide a cake to be given to the best-dressed couple. The competitors walk round and are judged by the other guests. Hence the term cake-walk.]

### Pain

*Cet homme est bon comme le pain* = That man is goodness itself.

*Il a mangé son pain blanc le premier* = He had the best of his life first; His happiest days are over.

[In many parts of the Continent white bread is not the matter of course that it is in England; brown or black bread is the usual fare of the poorer classes.]

*\*Tel grain, tel pain* = What you sow, you must mow.

*On lui a fait passer le goût du pain* (fam.) = They killed him.

*C’est pain bénit* = It serves you (him, her, them) right.

*Il a du pain sur la planche* = He has saved money;  
He has enough to live upon; He has put something **Pair**  
by for a rainy day; There is plenty of work for him  
to do.

\**De tout s'avise à qui pain faut (manque)* =  
Necessity is the mother of invention.

\**Pain tant qu'il dure, vin à mesure* = Eat at pleasure,  
drink by measure.

\**Il ne vaut pas le pain qu'il mange* = He is not worth  
his salt.

*Il sait son pain manger* = He knows on which side  
his bread is buttered.

\**C'est un long jour qu'un jour sans pain* = 'Tis a  
long lane that has no turning.

\**Pain dérobé réveille appétit* = Stolen joys are  
sweet.

[*"Pain qu'on dérobe et qu'on mange en cachette,  
Vaut mieux que pain qu'on cuit et qu'on achète."*

LA FONTAINE, *Les  
Troqueurs.*]

*Je ne mange pas de ce pain-là* = I don't go in for that  
sort of thing.

*Hors de pair* = Beyond all comparison; Above the **Paire**  
level of others.

*Traiter quelqu'un de pair à compagnon* = To be hail-  
fellow-well-met with any one; To treat any one on  
an equal footing.

\**Les deux font la paire* (fam.) = They are well **Paître**  
matched; *Arcades ambo.*

\**Je l'ai envoyé paître* (fam.) = I sent him about his **Paix** business.

*Paix et peu* = Anything for a quiet life.

**Panier**

\**Adieu paniers, vendanges sont faites* = You come **Panneau** too late, it is all over.

[The chorus of an old glee sung by the grape-pickers when their labours were finished. Comp. RABELAIS, *Gargantua*, xxvii.]

*Vous me donnez le dessus du panier* = You give me the best, the pick.

[*Le dessous du panier* = the refuse.]

*C'est un panier percé* = He is a spendthrift.

*Donner dans le panneau* = To fall into the trap.

**Panse**

*Il n'a pas fait une panse d'a aujourd'hui* = He has **Papier** not done a stroke all day.

[*Panse d'a* = the round part of an *a*.]

*Il n'est pas dans mes petits papiers* = He is not in my **Paquet** good books.

["Oh! pourvu que je sois  
Dans les petits papiers du *Mercure François*."

ROSTAND, *Cyrano de Bergerac*, ii. 8.]

*Je lui ai donné son paquet* = I gave him the sack.

**Par**

*Faire un paquet* = To make a parcel.

*Faire son paquet* = To pack up and go.

*De par le roi* = By the king's command.

**Paraître**

[“De par le roi, défense à Dieu  
De faire miracle en ce lieu.”

A cynical couplet that arose when Louis XV. prohibited pilgrimages to the tomb of François de Pâris, behind the Church of St. Médard in Paris, because of the Convulsionnaires.]

*Sans qu'il y paraisse, c'est un homme fort instruit* = **Pareil**

Without making any show he is a very well-informed man.

*A ce qu'il me paraît* = As far as I can judge, see.

*Le livre vient de paraître* = The book is just out, just published.

*Il n'y paraît plus* = There is no trace of it.

*Il n'y paraît pas* = One would not have thought it.

*J'ai le pareil* = I have one like it.

**Paresseux**

*Je vous rendrai la pareille* = 1. I will pay you out. 2.  
I will do the same for you.

*On n'a jamais vu chose pareille* = One never heard of such a thing.

*\*Ce sont les paresseux qui font le plus de chemin* = **Paris**  
Lazy people take the most pains.

*Parier Il y a cent (or, gros) à parier qu'ils ne  
reviendront pas* = The odds are that they will not come back.

*Il prend Paris pour Corbeil, le Pirée pour un homme* **Parler**  
= “He does not know a hawk from a handsaw.”

[*Hamlet*, ii. 2, where “handsaw” is a corruption of hennshaw = heron.  
This was an old proverb, corrupted before Shakespeare’s day.

“Pour grain ne prenant paille ou Paris pour Corbeil.”—RÉGNIER, *Sat.*  
xiv.]

*Le Tout-Paris de ce temps-là* = The fashionable  
world of Paris of that day.

*Nous parlions de la pluie et du beau temps* = We **Parole**  
were not talking of anything important or  
confidential; We were talking of indifferent  
matters.

*Parler de bouche } = Lip worship does not*  
*Au cœur ne touche } = reach the heart.*

*C’est à vous à parler* = It is your turn to speak.

*C’est à vous de parler* = It is your duty to speak.

*Qu’il vienne, il trouvera à qui parler* = Let him  
come, he will find his match.

*Trop gratter cuit, trop parler nuit* = Least said,  
soonest mended; Speech is silvery, silence is  
golden.

[Italian: Chi parla semina, chi tace raccoglie = Who speaks  
sows, who keeps silence reaps.  
*Qui d’autrui parler voudra*  
*Regarde soi et il taira.*]

\**Jamais beau parler n’écorcha la langue* = Fair  
words never did harm; Civility costs nothing.

*Il a son franc parler* = He is free-spoken.

\**Vous avez la parole* = It is your turn to speak; You **Part**  
are allowed to speak (i.e. you have caught the  
Speaker’s eye). See [Avoir](#).

*Je lui coupai la parole* = I interrupted him.



*\*Un homme d'honneur n'a que sa parole* = An honest man's word is as good as his bond.

*Être de parole* = To be as good as one's word.

*Manquer de parole* (or, *manquer à sa parole*) = To break one's word.

*Tenir parole* = To keep one's word.

*En bonne ou mauvaise part* = In a good or bad sense. **Partager**

*Nous le savons de bonne part* = We know it on good authority.

*Il est bien partagé* = The Fates have been kind to **Parti** him.

*Il a pris son parti* = 1. He has made up his mind. 2. **Partie** He has resigned himself to it.

*De parti pris* = Deliberately.

*C'est un parti pris* = His mind is made up; It is a foregone conclusion.

*C'est un parti pris chez lui de toujours contredire* = He will always contradict.

*A parti pris point de conseil* = Advice is useless when a man's mind is made up.

*Il tire parti de tout* = He makes a profit out of everything.

*Il sait tirer parti de la vie* = He knows how to make the best of life.

*Il a épousé un bon parti* = He made a good match.

*Il vous fera un mauvais parti* = He will try and pick a quarrel with you so as to ill-use you, to do you

harm.

*Il m'a pris à partie* = He took me to task; (legally)**Pas**  
He summoned me.

[*Partie* is literally a man who pleads against any one in a lawsuit.  
Compare:

“Va, je suis ta partie et non pas ton bourreau.”

CORNEILLE, *Cid*,  
839.]

*C'était une partie nulle* = It was a drawn game.

*Marcher à pas de géant* = To put on one's seven-**Passe**  
league boots.

*Se tirer d'un mauvais pas* = To get out of an  
awkward fix (scrape).

\**Il n'y a que le premier pas qui coûte* = In  
everything the beginning is the most difficult part;  
The first step downward makes the others easier.

[“*Il n'y a que le premier obstacle qui coûte à vaincre.*”—BOSSUET,  
*Pensées chrétiennes*, 9.]

*Il prend le pas sur moi* = He takes precedence of me.

*J'y vais de ce pas* = I am going there directly.

*Je le mettrai au pas* = I will put him on his good  
behaviour.

*Marquer le pas* = (lit.) To mark time; (fig.) To wait  
for a post to which one has a right.

*Marchez au pas* = Drive slowly; Walk in step.

*Il est en passe de devenir ministre* = He is in a fair**Passer**  
way (he stands a good chance) to become a  
Cabinet Minister.

*Il faut bien que j'en passe par là* = I must submit to **Patte** that; I must put up with it.

*Nous ne pouvons nous passer de cela* = We cannot do without that.

\**Passons au déluge* = We know all about that, let us come to the point; Don't let us go over all that again, we will take it for granted.

[RACINE, *Plaideurs*, iii. 3; where L'Intimé, the lawyer, wishes to relate the history of the world from the creation, and Dandin, the judge, begs him to skip all until the flood.]

*Cette couleur passera* = That colour will fade.

\**Passe-moi la casse (rhubarbe), je te passerai le séné* = Claw me and I'll claw thee; One hand washes the other, and both wash the face.

*Passez-moi ce mot-là* = Excuse the expression.

*J'en passe ... et des meilleurs* = Some of the best I pass over.

[VICTOR HUGO, *Hernani*, iii. 6.]

*On ne passe pas* = No thoroughfare.

[*Rue barrée* = Road stopped.]

*Vous faites des pattes de mouche* = You have a small, **Pauvre** ill-formed handwriting.

*Il marche à quatre pattes* = He walks on all-fours.

*Aux pauvres la besace* = The back is made for the **Pauvreté** burden.

*L'homme pauvre est toujours en pays étranger* = The poor are never welcomed; All bite the bitten dog.

*\*Pauvreté n'est pas vice* = Poverty is no crime. **Pavé**

*Les pavés le disent* = It is in every one's mouth. **Payer**

*Il est sur le pavé* = He is out of work.

*Prendre le haut du pavé* = To take the wall.

*Payer de sa personne* = To bravely expose oneself to danger; To risk one's skin. **Pays**

*Être payé pour savoir* = To know a thing to one's cost.

*Payer d'audace* = To put on a bold face; To brazen a thing out.

*Payer les violons* = To pay the piper.

*Je ne me paye pas de mauvaises raisons* = I will only be satisfied with good reasons.

*Vous vous payez de mots* = You are the dupe of words; You are taken in by empty words.

*Il me la payera* = I will make him smart for it.

*Qui paye ses dettes s'enrichit* = Debt is the worst kind of poverty.

*Payer son écot* = To pay one's share (scot).

*Il veut se payer ma tête* = He wishes to have the laugh of me.

*\*Pays ruiné vaut mieux que pays perdu* = Half a loaf is better than no bread. **Peau**

*Je lui ferai voir du pays* = I will lead him a pretty dance.

*\*Il ne faut pas vendre la peau de l'ours avant de***Péché**  
l'avoir tué = Do not count your chickens before  
they are hatched; First catch your hare.

[*"Il m'a dit qu'il ne faut jamais  
Vendre la peau de l'ours qu'on ne l'ait mis par terre."*  
LA FONTAINE, *Fables*, v.  
20.]

*Il crève dans sa peau* (fam.) = (lit.) He is extremely  
fat; (fig.) He is bursting with pride, spite.

*Faire peau neuve* = To turn over a new leaf.

*\*Péché avoué est à demi pardonné* = A fault**Pécher**  
confessed is half redressed.

*Elle est laide comme les sept péchés capitaux* = She  
is as ugly as sin.

*On est puni par où l'on a péché* = **Peine**  
"The Gods are just, and of our pleasant vices  
Make instruments to scourge us."

[*King Lear*, v. 3.]

*Cela ne vaut pas la peine* = It is not worth the**Peinture**  
trouble; It is not worth while.

*Mourir à la peine* = 1. To die in harness. 2. To work  
oneself to death.

*Je ne peux pas le voir même en peinture* = I hate the**Pelé**  
very sight of that man.

*Il y avait quatre pelés et un tondu* = There were only**Pelle**  
a few people and those of no importance; Only the

tag, rag, and bobtail were there.

*\*La pelle se moque du fourgon* = It is the pot calling **Pelote** the kettle black.

[Another English variant is: "The kiln calls the oven: Burnt house."  
The Italians say: "La padella dice al pajuolo, 'Fatti ni la che tu me tigni'" = The pan says to the pot, "Keep off or you'll smutch me."  
The Germans: "Ein Esel schimpft den andern Langohr" = One ass nicknames another Longears.]

*Remuer l'argent à la pelle* = To have plenty of money.

*Il a fait sa pelote* = He has feathered his nest. **Pendant**

*Cet homme n'a pas son pendant (or, pareil)* = That **Pendre** man has not his match.

*Il a dit pis que pendre de vous* = He said everything **Penser** that was bad of you; According to him, hanging is too good for you.

*À ce que je pense* = To my mind. **Perdre**

*Sans penser à mal* = Without meaning any mischief.

*Rien que d'y penser j'en ai le frisson* = The bare thought of it makes me shudder.

*Cela donne furieusement à penser* = That is very suggestive.

*Sans arrière-pensée* = Without reserve; With no after-thought.

*\*Un de perdu, deux de retrouvés* = When one door **Perdrix** shuts, another opens.

*Je m'y perds* = I am getting bewildered; I cannot make head or tail of it.

*Il perd la carte* = He is getting confused.

*C'est du bien perdu* = It is casting pearls before swine.

*\*Qui perd pêche* = He who loses sins; Nothing succeeds like success.

*\*Toujours des perdrix* = The best things pall in time. **Perle**

*Nous ne sommes pas ici pour enfiler des perles* = We **Pérou** are not here to trifle our time away.

*Ce n'est pas le Pérou* (fam.) = It's no great catch. **Personne**

*C'est la bonté en personne* = He (or, She) is **Perte** kindness itself.

*À perte de vue* = As far as the eye can reach. **Pesant**

*Je suis en perte* = I am out of pocket.

*J'ai fait cela en pure perte* = What I have done is completely useless; All I have done is to no purpose.

*Il vaut son pesant d'or* = He is worth his weight in **Petit** gold.

*Elles sont aux petits soins pour leur vieille mère* = **Pétrin**  
They are all attention to their old mother.

\**Les petits ruisseaux font les grandes rivières* =  
Many a little makes a mickle.

\**Petit à petit l'oiseau fait son nid* = Little strokes fell  
great oaks. (See [Maille](#) and [Ruisseau](#).)

[Also: *Grain à grain amasse la fourmi son pain.*  
*Peu à peu la vieille file sa quenouille.*

Latin: Adde parvum parvo tandem fit magnus acervus.

Italian: A passo a passo se va lontana.  
Little and often fills the purse.]

*En petit* = On a small scale.

\**Petit mercier, petit panier* = A small pack becomes  
a small pedlar.

[“Little boats should keep the shore,  
Larger ships may venture more.”  
Latin: Pauper agat caute.]

\**Petite cervelle, prompte colère* = A little pot is soon  
hot.

*Je suis dans le pétrin* (fam.) = I am in a mess, fix. **Peu**

*Les finances sont en ce moment dans un pétrin impossible* = The finances are in horrible disorder  
just now.

*Si peu que rien* = Next to nothing. **Peur**

*Imaginez un peu!* = Just fancy!

*Pour peu que cela vous ennuie* = However little it  
annoys you.

*Tant soit peu meilleur* = Be it ever so little better; A  
shade better.



*À peu de chose près* = Not far off.

*Elle était mise à faire peur* = She looked a fright. **Phrase**

*Il a eu plus de peur que de mal* = He was more frightened than hurt.

*Faire des phrases* = To speak affectedly. **Pie**

*\*Il a trouvé la pie au nid* = He has found a mare's nest. **Pièce**

*Elle jase comme une pie borgne* = She chatters like a magpie.

*J'ai fait cela de toutes pièces* = I have done that entirely (i.e. every part of it). **Pied**

*Je lui ai donné la pièce* = I gave him a trifle, tip.

*C'est la pièce de résistance* = It is the principal dish (of a meal).

*Il a bon pied, bon œil* = He is hale and hearty. **Pierre**

*Sur le pied où en sont les choses* = Considering how matters stand.

*Il ne sait sur quel pied danser* = He does not know which way to turn.

*Partir du bon pied* = To put one's best foot foremost.

*Je ferai des pieds et des mains pour vous être utile* = I will do my utmost (strain every nerve) to serve you.

*Armé de pied en cap* = Armed from head to foot, cap-à-pie.

*Le pied m'a manqué* = My foot slipped.

*Mettre (quelqu'un) à pied* = (fam.) To dismiss (a functionary); To deprive a cabman of his licence.

*Il a trouvé chaussure à son pied* = He has found just what he wanted; He has found his match.

*Lâcher pied* = 1. To lose ground. 2. To scamper away.

*Lever le pied* = To decamp (of a dishonest banker, etc.).

*Vous m'avez tiré une épine du pied* = (fig.) You have got me out of a difficulty. (See [Épine](#).)

*J'ai fait mon travail d'arraché pied* = I did my work straight off, without stopping.

*De plain pied* = On the same level (of rooms on the same floor, or on a level with the ground).

*Il a le pied marin* = He has got his sea-legs; He is a good sailor.

*Sauter à pieds joints sur quelqu'un* = (fig.) To ride rough-shod over any one.

*Il ne se mouche pas du pied* (pop.) = 1. He is a man of importance; He gives himself airs. 2. He is no fool.

[A favourite trick of a tumbler in olden times was to take one of his feet in his hands and pass it quickly under his nose. Hence the expression would be equivalent to: he is no tumbler or common fellow. "N'est pas un homme, non, qui se mouche du pied." *MOLIÈRE, Tartufe*, iv. 5.]

*Aller du pied* (or, *Courir*) *comme un chat maigre* = To be a good walker.

*Il sèche sur pied* = He is pining away.

*La mort l'a pris au pied levé* = Death took him  
without a moment's notice.

[Literally, just at the moment he was starting to go out.]

*\*Faire d'une pierre deux coups* = To kill two birds **Piété**  
with one stone.

*\*Pierre qui roule n'amasse pas mousse* = A rolling  
stone gathers no moss.

[The Greek form was: λίθος κυλινδόμενος τὸ φύκος οὐ ποιεῖ.]

*Cela ferait rire un tas de pierres* = That would make  
a cat laugh.

*Sa montre est au mont de piété* = His watch is at the **Pignon**  
pawnbroker's. (See [Accrocher](#).)

*Avoir pignon sur rue* = To have a house of one's **Pile**  
own.

*Jouer à pile ou face* = To play pitch and toss, heads **Pilier**  
or tails.

*Il n'a ni croix ni pile* = He has not a rap.

[“Sans croix ne pile.”—LA FONTAINE, *Contes*, ii. “Whacum had neither  
cross nor pile.”—BUTLER, *Hudibras*, ii. 3. *Pile* is literally the  
reverse of a coin.]

*C'est un pilier d'estaminet* (or, *de café*) = He is a **Pilule**  
public-house lounge, a pub-loafer.

*Dorer la pilule* = To gild the pill.

**Pipe**

*Casser sa pipe* (pop.) = To kick the bucket; To hop **Piquer** the twig; To die.

*Piquer la curiosité de quelqu'un* = To rouse some **Place** one's curiosity.

*Il se pique d'un rien* = He takes offence at the slightest thing.

*Il s'est piqué d'honneur* = He made it a point of honour; He was put upon his mettle.

*Piquer des deux* = (lit.) To spur a horse with both heels; To gallop off at full speed; (fig.) To run very fast.

*Piquer une tête* (fam.) = To take a header.

*Voilà un discours qui n'est pas piqué des vers* = That's a fine speech if you like [lit. not worm-eaten.]

*Se piquer au jeu* = (lit.) To continue obstinately to play although losing; (fig.) To go on in an enterprise in spite of all obstacles.

\**Qui va à la chasse perd sa place* = If you leave **Plaider** your place, you lose it.

“*Accordez-vous si votre affaire est bonne,* **Plaie**  
*Si votre cause est mauvaise, plaidez.*”  
[J. B. ROUSSEAU, *Épigrammes*, ii. 19] = If you've a good case, try and compromise; If you've a bad one, take it into court.

*Il ne demande que plaie et bosse* = He seeks quarrels **Plaisanterie**  
only to draw profit from them.

*Il ne cherche que plaie et bosse* = He is always  
hankering after a black eye.

*Une bonne plaisanterie mérite les honneurs du bis* = **Plan**  
A good tale is none the worse for being told twice.

*Reléguer (mettre) au second plan* = To put into the **Planche**  
background.

*Faire la planche* = 1. To show others the way; 2. To **Plancher**  
float on one's back.

*C'est sa planche de salut* = It is his last hope, his  
sheet-anchor.

*Le plancher des vaches* (fam.) = Dry land; *Terra* **Planter**  
*firma*.

*Débarrasse-moi le plancher* (fam.) = Get out of my  
way.

*Vous m'avez planté là* = You left me without any **Plat**  
warning; You left me in the lurch.

*Il nous a servi un plat de son métier* (or, *de sa façon*) **Plâtre**  
= He played us one of his tricks.

*On mit les petits plats dans les grands pour le bien  
recevoir* (fam.) = They spared neither trouble nor  
money to receive him well; They received him  
with much fuss.

*Il a mis les pieds dans le plat* (fam.) = He put his foot in it.

*Ce mari bat sa femme comme plâtre* = That husband **Plein** beats his wife like a dog.

*Essuyer les plâtres* = To live in a newly-built house (and therefore damp). (See [Essuyer](#).)

*Battre son plein* = To be in full swing. **Pleurer**

*Plein comme un œuf* (fam.) = Chock-full.

*En pleine rue* = In the open street.

*En pleine mer* = On the high seas.

*La niaise! pleurer à chaudes larmes pour une vétille* **Pleuvoir**  
= The silly girl! to cry her eyes out for a trifle.

*Pleuvoir des hallebardes* = To rain cats, dogs, and **Pli** pitchforks.

*Cela ne fera pas un pli* = There will not be the **Pluie** slightest difficulty.

*Si vous n'y prenez (pas) garde, il prendra un mauvais pli* = If you are not careful he will get into bad habits.

\**Après la pluie le beau temps* = Every cloud has a **Plus** silver lining.

*Nous parlions de la pluie et du beau temps* = We were talking of indifferent matters.

*Il fait la pluie et le beau temps dans cette maison* =  
His will is law in that house; He is the boss of that  
show (fam.).

*\*Plus on a, plus on veut avoir* = Much would have **Poche**  
more.

*Il connaît Paris comme sa poche* = He knows Paris **Poil**  
perfectly; He knows all the ins and outs of Paris;  
His knowledge of Paris is extensive and peculiar.

*Un brave à trois poils* = The bravest of the brave; **A Point**  
hero of the first water.

[This expression is derived from three-piled velvet. See MOLIÈRE, *Les  
Précieuses Ridicules*, 12.]

*Monter à poil* = To ride barebacked.

*\*Un point à temps en épargne cent* = A stitch in time **Poire**  
saves nine.

[Spanish: Quien no adoba gotera adoba casa entera = Who repairs not  
his gutter repairs his whole house.]

*Cela vient à point* = That comes opportunely.

*La viande est cuite à point* = The meat is done to a  
turn.

*Vous venez à point nommé* = You come in the nick of  
time, at the necessary moment, just when you are  
wanted.

*Mettez les points sur les i* = Be precise, clear (in  
speaking or writing); Cross your t's and dot your  
i's.

*Il vous rendrait des points* = He is more than a match  
for you; He could give you points.

*Il vous rendra des points* = He will give you odds (at a game).

*Il y a un point noir à l'horizon* = There are breakers ahead.

*\*Coupons la poire en deux* = Let us split the **Poisson** difference.

*Elle faisait trop sa poire* (pop.) = She needed pressing; She played the prude (or, disdainful).

[“Il était trop homme pour faire sa poire.”]

*Nous en causerons entre la poire et le fromage* = We will talk it over at dessert.

*Garder une poire pour la soif* = To lay up something for a rainy day.

*On lui a fait un poisson d'avril* = They made him an **Polichinelle** April fool.

*Je suis comme un poisson sur la paille* = I am like a fish out of water.

*C'est le secret de Polichinelle* = It is an open secret; **Politesse** Every one knows it.

*Il a avalé la pratique de Polichinelle* = He is very hoarse.

[*La pratique de Polichinelle* is the squeaker that a Punch-and-Judy man puts in his mouth during a performance.]

*\*Force politesse, trop de finesse* = Full of courtesy, **Pont** full of craft.



*Il se porte comme le Pont Neuf* = He is in splendid **Pontoise** health.

*C'est vieux comme le Pont Neuf* = Queen Anne is dead; It is as old as the hills.

[The Pont Neuf was finished in 1604 during the reign of Henry IV., and is now the oldest bridge in Paris. The statue of Henry IV. in the middle of the bridge was erected originally in 1635, but the present one dates only from 1818.

Another expression is:

*Henri Quatre est sur le Pont Neuf* = That's stale news.]

*Il a l'air de revenir de Pontoise* = He looks down in **Porte** the mouth; He answers in a silly fashion.

[The origin of this expression is said to be that in 1720 and in 1753 the Parlement was exiled to Pontoise, about twenty miles north of Paris, for its rebellion to the King. Perhaps from the fact that when they returned they were besieged with questions, to which they gave confused answers, the saying arose and was applied to anyone that had a simple, idiotic appearance.]

*Ils ont mis la clef sous la porte* = They absconded. **Portée**

*Il faut qu'une porte soit ouverte ou fermée* = You must decide one way or the other.

[The title of one of Alfred de Musset's Proverbes.]

*On l'a mis à la porte* = They turned him out.

*Il a été mis à la porte par les oreilles et les deux épaules* = He was turned out ignominiously, neck and crop.

*On a condamné la porte* = The door is nailed up, blocked up.

*À sa portée* (or, *à portée de sa main*) = Within his **Porter** reach.

*À (la) portée de la voix* = Within call.

*À (une) portée de fusil* = Within gunshot.

*C'est elle qui porte la culotte* = She is mistress in **Poseur**  
this house (not her husband); The grey mare is the  
better horse.

*On le porte aux nues* = They praise him to the skies.

*Ses plaisanteries portent coup* = His jokes hit the  
mark.

*C'est un poseur* = He is a prig (lit. attitudiniser). **Possession**

[There are several varieties of prigs, *e.g.*—

*un savantasse* = a learned prig.

*un collet monté* = a stiff-and-starched prig.

*un cafard* = a Pecksniff.

*un fat* = a conceited ass.

*un freluquet* = a whipper-snapper.

*See Journal of Education, March 1896.]*

*\*En fait de meubles possession vaut titre* = **Possible**  
Possession is nine points of the law.

*Pas possible!* = You don't say so! "Well, I never!" **Pot**

*Il découvrit bientôt le pot aux roses* = He soon found **Potasser**  
out the secret.

*\*Un pot fêlé dure longtemps* = A creaking door  
hangs long: Ailing folk live longest.

*\*Il n'y a si méchant pot qui ne trouve son couvercle*  
= Every Jack must have his Jill.

[Also: *À un boiteux, femme qui cloche.*]

*Il a reçu un pot-de-vin* = He received a bribe, an  
illicit commission.

[A *pot-de-vin* is a gratuity given to B by A because B obtained for A an order from C. It implies the idea of a bribe, for if everything had been fair A would not have obtained his order from C, either because his terms were too high or his wares not good enough.]

*Payer les pots cassés* = To stand the racket; To pay the damage; To face the music.

*Tourner autour du pot* = To beat about the bush.

*C'est le pot de terre contre le pot de fer* = It is a most unequal combat.

*Je vais potasser (piocher) un brin* (students' slang) = **Potin**  
I'm going to swot (mug up) a bit.

*Faire du potin (chambard, boucan)* (pop.) = To kick **Pouce**  
up a row, a shindy.

*Manger sur le pouce* = To take a snack. **Poudre**

*Mettre les pouces* = To give in, to knuckle under.

*Lire du pouce* (or, *doigt*) = To skip in reading (*i.e.* to do more work with the thumb than the brain).

*\*Il n'a pas inventé la poudre* = He will never set the **Poule**  
Thames on fire.

*C'est une poule mouillée* = He is a milk-sop. **Pourpoint**

*Mettre un homme en pourpoint* = To pull a man's **Pouvoir**  
cloak off; To ruin a man.

*Se mettre en pourpoint* = To be ready to fight; To roll  
up one's sleeves.

*Tirer un coup (de pistolet, etc.) à brûle-pourpoint* =  
To fire point-blank.

*Un argument à brûle-pourpoint* = A convincing  
argument.

*Donner à quelqu'un un pourpoint de pierre* = To  
give any one a stone doublet; To imprison any one.

*Je n'y puis rien* = I cannot help it; I can do nothing  
in the matter. **Prêcher**

*Si faire se peut* = If possible.

*Je n'en puis plus* = I am done up, exhausted.

*Je n'en puis mais* = I cannot help it; It is no fault of  
mine. (See [Mais](#).)

*Cela se peut* = That may be.

*Cela ne se peut pas* = It cannot possibly be; It cannot  
be done.

*On fait comme on peut* = We must do the best we  
can; We have done the best we could.

*Il est toujours on ne peut plus aimable* = He is  
always as nice as can be.

*Il prêche dans le désert* = (lit.) He preaches to empty  
benches; (fig.) All his talking will not convince  
any one. **Premier**

*Chacun prêche pour son saint* = Every one has an  
eye to his own interest.

*Nous sommes au premier* = We are on the first floor. **Prendre**

*Nous sommes en première* = We are in a first-class  
railway carriage.

*Le premier venu* = (fig.) No matter who (or, whom);  
The man in the street.

\**Les premiers vont devant* = First come, first served.

[“Whoso first cometh to the mill, first grint.”—CHAUCER.]

*Il prend sur son sommeil pour étudier* = He works **Près**  
far into the night.

*C'est autant de pris sur l'ennemi* = So much saved  
out of the fire; So much to the good.

*Bien lui en prit d'avoir fermé sa porte* = It was lucky  
for him that he shut his door.

*Il prend le chemin de l'hôpital* = He is on the  
highway to ruin.

*Je m'en prends à vous* = I lay the blame at your door.

*Je vous y prends* = I catch you at it.

*Ça ne prend pas* (fam.) = “That’s no go.”

*Je sors d'en prendre* (fam.) = I had rather be  
excused; You will not catch me again so soon.

*Qu'est-ce qui vous prend?* = What is the matter with  
you?

[This is said to persons doing something suddenly without any  
apparent reason, or suddenly becoming bad-tempered, etc., not to  
invalids.]

*Je vais vous montrer comment il faut s'y prendre* = I  
am going to show you how to set about it.

\**Ce qui est bon à prendre est bon à garder* = What is  
worth taking is worth keeping; “Findings,  
keepings.”

*Prenez-vous-en à vous-même* = You have yourself to  
thank for it.

*À tout prendre* = On the whole; Everything considered.

*À cela près il est bon enfant* = Except for that he is a **Presse** good fellow.

*Il n'y a pas presse* = There is no hurry! **Pretentaine**

*\*Plus on se presse, moins on arrive* = The more haste, the less speed.

*Fendre la presse* = To make one's way through the crowd.

*Courir la pretentaine* = To gad about. **Prêter**

*Il prête de l'argent à la petite semaine* = He lends **Primer** money for a short time at a high rate of interest.

*Un prêt pour un rendu* = A Roland for an Oliver.

*Prêter le flanc à ...* = To lay oneself open to...

*Prêter serment* = To take the oath.

*Ce drap prête* = This stuff gives, stretches.

*Elle prime par sa laideur* = She takes the cake for **Princesse** ugliness.

*Aux frais de la Princesse* = At another's expense **Prise** (chiefly of the State Government).

*Ils étaient aux prises* = They had closed; They were **Procès** at close quarters.

*Je les ai mis aux prises* = I have set them one against the other.

*Je leur ai donné prise sur moi* = I gave them a handle on me.

*Lâcher prise* = To let go one's hold.

*Sans autre forme de procès* = Without any more ado. **Promener**

*Je l'ai envoyé promener* (or, *paître*) = I sent him **Promettre** about his business.

*Va te promener!* (fam.) = Go to Jericho! Get along with you!

[Compare: “Βάλλ’ εἰς μακαρίαν” = Go to Glory.—PLATO, *Hipp. Major*, 293A—a euphemism for Βάλλ’ εἰς ᾄδον.]

*\*Chose promise, chose due* = Promises should be **Propos** kept.

*Promettre et tenir sont deux* = It is one thing to promise, another to perform.

*Il est venu fort à propos* = He came very **Propre** opportunely.

*À propos, viendrez-vous ce soir?* = By the way, shall you come this evening?

*L'à-propos fait le mérite* = Seasonableness gives everything its price.

*À propos de bottes* = With reference to nothing in particular; With no reference to the subject in hand.

*Il le dit à tout propos* = He says it on every occasion, at every turn.

*Il l'a fait de propos délibéré* = He did it of set purpose; He had made up his mind to do it.

*Il l'a fait fort mal à propos* = He did it very unseasonably, just at the wrong time.

*C'est du propre* (ironic.) = A fine thing indeed. **Prune**

*Il n'a rien en propre* = He has nothing of his own.

*Un propre-à-rien* = A good-for-naught.

*Propre à tout et bon à rien* = Jack of all trades and master of none.

*Propre comme un sou neuf* = As clean as a whistle;  
As neat as a new pin.

*Je ne le ferai pas pour des prunes* (fam.) = I shall not **Puce**  
do it for nothing.

[Also: *Je ne le ferai pas pour le roi de Prusse*. This latter saying is said to have originated with Voltaire, who, after having been exceedingly intimate with Frederick the Great, King of Prussia, finally quarrelled with him. Both this King and his father, Frederick William I., were known to be exacting and miserly.]

*Je lui ai mis la puce à l'oreille* = I made him feel **Puits**  
uneasy (by rousing his suspicions, etc.); I sent him  
away with a flea in his ear.

*Cet homme est un puits de science* = He is a man of  
deep learning.

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## Q.

**Quand**      *Je le ferai quand même* = I shall do it just the same; I shall do it whatever it may cost.

**Quant**      *Se tenir sur son quant-à-soi* = To stand on one's dignity.

**Quart**      *Le quart d'heure de Rabelais* = The moment of payment. (See [Heure](#).)

*Passer un mauvais quart d'heure* = To have a bad time of it.

**Quatorze**      *Avoir quinte et quatorze* = To have the game in one's own hand.

[This phrase refers to terms used in the game of piquet. *Quinte* is to have five cards of the same colour, which counts fifteen. *Quatorze* is to have four cards of the same value (*i.e.* four knaves, aces, etc.), and counts fourteen.]

**Quatre**      *Il se mettrait en quatre pour un ami* = He would go through fire and water for a friend.

*Faire le diable à quatre* = To kick up a terrible noise; To exert oneself to the utmost.

[This expression originated in the time of the miracle plays, when four performers represented *la grande diablerie*, and less than four *la petite diablerie*.]

*Entre quatre-z-yeux* (fam.) = Between ourselves.

*On le tenait à quatre* = It needed four men to hold him down.

**Que**

*Il se tenait à quatre pour ne pas lui dire des injures* = It was as much as he could do not to abuse him.

*Travailler comme quatre* = To work like a nigger.

*\*Ce que c'est que la vie!* = What a strange thing life is! What poor mortals we are! (See [Ce.](#))

*Ses louanges ne laissent pas que de me faire plaisir* = I cannot help feeling pleased at his kind words.

*La pièce n'est que quelconque* = The piece (*i.e.* the play) is quite an ordinary one.

*C'est une famille où l'esprit est tombé en quenouille* = In that family only the women are clever; In that family the brains are on the distaff side.

*N'épousez pas sa querelle* = Do not take up his quarrel.

*Ils veulent vider leur querelle* = They want to fight it out.

*Il serait bon à aller quérir la mort* = He is very slow.

**Question**

*Mettre en question* = To call in question; To doubt. **Queue**

*Mettre à la question* = To put to the torture.

*Qu'il n'en soit plus question* = Do not bother me about it any more; Let bygones be bygones. (See [Oublier.](#))

*J'ai fait queue au théâtre pendant une heure* = **I Qui**  
waited outside the theatre for an hour (before I  
could get in).

*On fait queue au théâtre* = There is a crowd at the  
door of the theatre (waiting for admittance).

*À la queue gât le venin* = The sting is in the tail.

*Aller à la queue leu-leu* = To go in Indian file.

[*Leu* was the old French form of *loup*, so the phrase means to walk as  
wolves do, one after the other.]

*Tenir la queue de la poêle* = To be the leading spirit  
in an affair.

*Pour qui connaît* = To any one who knows. **Quia**

*Ils s'échappèrent qui par la porte, qui par les  
fenêtres* = Some escaped through the door, others  
through the windows.

*\*Qui s'excuse s'accuse* = A guilty conscience needs  
no accuser.

*C'est à qui le fera* = They all wish to do it; They vie  
with one another to do it. (See [\*Mieux\*](#).)

*Être réduit à quia* = To be reduced to “because....”; **Quitte**  
To be nonplussed.

*Me voilà quitte envers lui* = I owe him nothing now. **Quoi**

*Vous en êtes quitte à bon marché* = You come off  
cheap.

*J'en ai été quitte pour la peur* = I escaped with a  
good fright.

*J'irai, quitte à être grondé* = I shall go, even if I am scolded; I shall go, and chance the scolding.

*J'ai de quoi payer* = I have enough to pay.

*Il n'y a pas là de quoi pleurer* = It is not worth crying about.

*Il n'y a pas de quoi rire* = It is no laughing matter.

*Il n'y a pas de quoi* (fam.) = Pray don't mention it; There is no necessity to apologise. (See [Avoir](#).)

*De quoi vous mêlez-vous?* = What business is that of yours?

*Un je ne sais quoi* = A “something” (I know not what).

[*Elle avait je ne sais quoi de charmant* = She had a vague, indescribable charm.]

*C'est un filou, quoi!* (pop.) = In a word, he's a scamp.

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## R.

|                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Rabais</b>    | <i>Vente au rabais</i> = Sale at reduced prices; “Selling off.”                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| <b>Rabattre</b>  | <i>Rabattre le caquet à quelqu’un</i> (pop.) = To take a person down a peg; To stop his jaw; To cut his cackle.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| <b>Radis</b>     | <i>Il n’a pas un radis</i> (fam.) = He has not a brass farthing. (See <a href="#">Liard</a> .)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>Raillerie</b> | <i>Cela passe la raillerie</i> = That is beyond a joke. (See <a href="#">Entendre</a> .)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| <b>Raison</b>    | <p><i>Il n’entend pas raison là-dessus</i> = He will not listen to reason on that point.</p> <p><i>Se faire raison à soi-même</i> = To take the law into one’s own hands.</p> <p><i>Comme de raison</i> = Rightly enough; As might be expected.</p> <p><i>Plus que de raison</i> = More than is reasonable.</p> <p><i>Raison de plus</i> = All the more reason.</p> <p><i>Avoir des raisons avec quelqu’un</i> = To have words with any one; To quarrel with any one.</p> <p><i>Il faut se faire une raison</i> = We must be guided by reason; We must look at things from a reasonable</p> |

|                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Rompre</b>    | <i>Applaudir un acteur à tout rompre</i> = To applaud an actor so as to bring the house down (to lift the roof).                                                                                                                       |
| <b>Rondement</b> | <i>Il y va rondement</i> = He acts frankly and quickly.<br><i>Il mènera cette affaire rondement</i> = He will not dally about that matter.                                                                                             |
| <b>Rose</b>      | <i>Il n'est point de rose sans épines</i> = Every rose has its thorn; No rose without a thorn.                                                                                                                                         |
| <b>Rôti</b>      | <i>Il ne faut pas s'endormir sur le rôti</i> = We must keep our wits about us; We must not neglect our work; We must not be too slow over it; We must not rest on our laurels.<br>[Literally, to go to sleep whilst cooking the meat.] |
| <b>Roue</b>      | <i>Il fait la roue</i> = He shows off.                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| <b>Rouge</b>     | <i>Se fâcher tout rouge</i> = To get into a passion.<br><i>Voir rouge</i> = To be seized with a sudden thirst for blood.                                                                                                               |
| <b>Roulette</b>  | <i>Cela marche comme sur des roulettes</i> = That is getting on swimmingly.                                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Royaliste</b> | <i>Être plus royaliste que le roi (plus catholique que le pape)</i> = To out-Herod Herod.                                                                                                                                              |

**Royauté**      “*La royauté, place noyée de lumière où toute tache paraît une fange sordide*” =  
“In that fierce light which beats upon a throne  
And blackens every blot.”  
[TENNYSON, *Idylls of the King*, Dedication.]

**Rubis**      *Faire (or, payer) rubis sur l’ongle* = To pay to the last farthing.  
[This expression means literally to drain a tumbler so completely that there just remains in it one drop of wine, which being put on the nail looks like a ruby.  
“Je sirote mon vin, quel qu’il soit, vieux, nouveau;  
Je fais rubis sur l’ongle, et n’y mets jamais d’eau.”  
REGNARD, *Folies Amoureuses*, iii. 4.]

**Ruisseau**      \**Les petits ruisseaux font les grandes rivières* =  
Many a little makes a mickle.

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## S.

### Sac

*\*Autant pèche celui qui tient le sac que celui qui met dedans* = The receiver is as bad as the thief.

[*Wer die Letter hält ist so schuldig wie der Dieb.*]

*Tu sais que je n'ai plus le sac* = You know I have no more money.

*Un homme de sac et de corde* = A regular ruffian.

*Prendre quelqu'un la main dans le sac* = To catch any one in the very act.

*Il m'a laissé voir le fond du sac* = I guessed his intentions in spite of him.

*Juger sur l'étiquette du sac* = To judge by appearances.

*\*Dans les petits sacs sont les fines épices* = Little fellows are often great wits; Small parcels hold fine wares. (See [Aune](#) and [Onguent](#).)

### Saint

*Tout le saint-frusquin* (fam.) = The whole jolly lot (referring to money or clothes).

*Toute la sainte journée* = The whole blessed (or, livelong) day.

### Salut

*\*À bon entendeur salut* = A word to the wise is enough. *Verb. sap.* (See [Avis](#).)

### Sang

*Cela fait faire du mauvais sang* = That causes one to worry.



*Suer sang et eau* (fam.) = To strain every nerve.

\**Bon sang ne peut mentir* = Good breeding always **Sapin** shows itself; Like father, like son.

*Sa toux sent le sapin* = He has a churchyard cough. **Sauce**  
[*Sapin* = deal, of which coffins are made.]

*On ne sait à quelle sauce le mettre* = There is no **Saut** knowing what to do with him.

\**Trop de cuisiniers gâtent la sauce* = Too many cooks spoil the broth.

[Although this may be but a translation of the English proverb, it is of constant use in France.]

*Il fait tout par sauts et par bonds* = He does **Sauter** everything by fits and starts.

*Il s'est fait sauter la tête* (or, *la cervelle*, more fam. **Sauver** *le caisson*) = He blew his brains out.

*Faire sauter la banque* = To break the bank (gambling).

\**Sauve qui peut* = Every one for himself; Run for **Savoir** your lives.

*Je me sauve* = I must be off.

*Je ne sais comment cela est arrivé* = I am at a loss to **Savon** explain how it happened.

*Pas que je sache* = Not to my knowledge.

*Je suis tout je ne sais comment* = I am out of sorts.

*C'est à savoir* = That remains to be seen.

*Il en sait plus d'une* (fam.) = He knows more than one trick; He knows a trick or two.

*Il a beaucoup de savoir faire* = He has his wits about him; He knows how to manage people.

*Il a du savoir vivre* = He knows how to behave; He is well bred.

*Un je ne sais quoi* = A "something" (I know not what).

*\*De savoir vient avoir* = Knowledge is power.

*\*Qui plus sait plus se tait* = A still tongue shows a wise head.

*\*Qui rien ne sait, de rien ne doute* = Who knows nothing, doubts nothing; Ignorance is bliss.

*Je lui donnerai un savon* (fam.) = I will blow him up. **Scène**

[German: *Ich werde ihm den Kopf waschen.*]

*Je lui ai fait une scène* = 1. I had a row with him. 2. I reproached (or, abused) him violently. **Scie**

*Quelle scie!* (fam.) = What a bother! **Séance**

*Séance tenante* = Forthwith; There and then. **Sec**

*C'est un grand sec* = He is a tall, spare man. **Sécher**

*Sec comme un pendu* = As thin as a lath.

*Boire sec* = To drink hard.

*Il est à sec* (pop.) = He is hard up, broke, in low water.

*Sécher sur pied* = To pine away. **Secours**

*Crier au secours* = To cry for help. **Secret**

\**Secret de deux, secret de Dieu,* **Seigneur**  
*Secret de trois, secret de tous* = No secret but between two.

\**À tout seigneur tout honneur* = Honour to whom honour is due. **Sel**

*Mettre du sel sous la queue d'un oiseau* = To put salt on a bird's tail. **Sellette**

*Mettre sur la sellette* = To cross-question; To haul over the coals (fam.). **Semaine**

[*La sellette* was the small wooden seat on which a culprit sat during his trial.]

*Cet officier est de semaine* = He is officer of the week. **Semblable**

*Il dépensa toute sa semaine* = He spent all his week's wages (or, pocket-money).

*Je le ferai la semaine des trois (quatre) jeudis* = I shall do it in a week of Sundays (i.e. never).

[Also: *Je le ferai quand les poules auront des dents.*]

*Prêter à la petite semaine* = To lend money at high interest for a short time.

*A-t-on jamais vu rien de semblable?* = Did you ever **Sembler**  
see such a thing?

*Rien de semblable* = Nothing of the sort.

*Comme bon vous semble* = Just as you please. **Semelle**

*Si bon vous semble* = If you think fit.

*Lever la semelle devant quelqu'un* = To show any **Sens**  
one a clean pair of heels.

*Cela tombe sous le sens* = That is self-evident, **Sentir**  
obvious.

*Sens dessus dessous* = Upside down; Topsy-turvy.

*Sens devant derrière* = Wrong side first.

*À contresens* = Contrary to the meaning; In the  
wrong way.

*Cela ne sent pas bon* = (fig.) I don't like the look of **Service**  
that.

*Je ne me sens pas de joie* = I am beside myself with  
joy.

*Qu'y a-t-il pour votre service?* = What can I do for **Servir**  
you?

*Madame est servie* = Dinner is served. **Seul**

\**À quoi sert de vous mettre en colère?* = What is the  
use of getting angry?

*Cela va tout seul* = That is no trouble; That works of **Si**  
its own accord.

*Il n'y a pas de si qui fasse* = There is no excuse for **Sien**  
it.

*Avec un si on mettrait Paris dans une bouteille* =  
Such suppositions are idle; If wishes were horses,  
beggars would ride.

*Il n'est pas riche.—Oh! que si* = He is not rich.—  
Isn't he, though!

*\*Chacun le sien n'est pas trop* = Let each have his **Singe**  
own, then all is fair.

*Il fait des siennes* = He is up to his old tricks again.

*Il en sera du sien* = He will be a loser by it.

*On n'est jamais trahi que par les siens* = It is always  
one's friends (or, confederates) who betray one.

*Le singe est toujours singe, fût-il vêtu de pourpre* = **Soif**  
An ape's an ape, a varlet's a varlet,  
Though they be clad in silk or scarlet.

*Il l'a payé en monnaie de singe* = He paid him with  
promises; He jeered at him instead of paying him.

[This expression originated in the ordinance of St. Louis regulating the payment of the tolls at the gates of Paris. Showmen were exempted from payment on causing their apes to skip and dance in front of the toll-keeper. Comp. ESTIENNE BOILEAU, *Etablissements des métiers de Paris*, Chapitre del péage de Petit Pont:—"Li singes au marchand doibt quatre deniers, se il por vendre le porte: se li singes est a homme qui l'aist acheté por son déduit, si est quites, et se li singes est au joueur, jouer en doibt devant le péagier, et por son jeu doibt estre quites de toute la chose qu'il achète à son usage et aussitôt le jongleur sont quite por un ver de chanson."]

*\*On ne saurait faire boire un âne s'il n'a soif* = One **Solide** man can take a horse to the water, but twenty cannot make him drink.

*Il songe au solide* = He has an eye to the main **Soleil** chance.

*Montrer le soleil avec un flambeau* = To hold a **Somme (m.)** farthing rushlight to the sun; To paint the lily.

*Je n'ai fait qu'un somme* = I never woke all night. **Somme (f.)**

*Somme toute* = After all; Taking everything into **Songe** consideration; To conclude.

*En somme* = On the whole; In the main.

*“Puisqu'en vous il est faux que songes sont **Sonner** mensonges”* = Since with you, it is untrue that dreams go by contraries.

[MOLIÈRE, *Étourdi*, iv. 3.]

*\*Mal d'autrui n'est que songe* = Other people's woes do not affect us much.

*C'est un songe-creux* = He is full of idle fancies (or, day dreams); He is a wool-gatherer.

*Elle a quarante ans bien sonnés* = She is over forty. **Sornette**

*Il est trois heures sonnées* = It has struck three.

*Payer en bonnes espèces sonnantes (et trébuchantes)*  
= To pay in hard cash.

*Il nous berce de sornettes* = He puts us off with silly **Sort** tales.

*Le sort en est jeté* = The die is cast; *Alea jacta est.* **Sorte**

*Elle lui a jeté un sort* = She cast a spell over him; He is infatuated with her.

*Tirer au sort* = To draw lots (for the army, etc.).

*Je lui ai parlé de la bonne sorte* = I gave it him **Sortie** soundly; I gave him a piece of my mind.

*Il a fait une sortie* = He flew into a passion. **Sot**

*C'est un sot en trois lettres* = He is a thorough fool. **Sou**

*Quelque sot le ferait* = One would be a fool to do that.

\**A sottie question point de réponse* = Answer a fool according to his folly; A silly question needs no answer.

*Un sot trouve toujours un plus sot qui l'admire* = Even a fool will always find admirers.

[BOILEAU, *Art Poétique*, 1.]

*Il n'y a pas de sots métiers, il n'y a que de sottes gens* = People may be petty, but work never is.

*Il a fait de cent sous quatre livres, et de quatre livres **Souche** rien* = He has brought his noble to ninepence, and his ninepence to nothing.

[*Livre* here has nothing to do with our English pound sterling. It is practically the equivalent of the modern franc. Hence the proverb means: He reduced 100 sous to 80 sous.]

*Une affaire de deux sous* = A twopenny-halfpenny affair.

*Cela vaut mille francs comme un sou* = It is worth £40 if it is worth a penny.

*C'est une vraie souche* = He is a regular log. **Soufflet**

*Faire souche* = To found a family.

*Donner un soufflet à Vaugelas* = To murder the King's English; To offend Lindley Murray. **Souhait**

[Vaugelas (1585-1650) was a celebrated writer on French grammar, one of the first members of the Académie Française, and one of the chief contributors to its Dictionary. Comp. MOLIERE, *Les Femmes Savantes*, ii. 7: "Elle y met Vaugelas en pièces tous les jours." *Donner un soufflet à Ronsard* was also used, and, in the Middle Ages, *Casser la tête de Priscien*, from the famous grammarian of the fourth century.]

|                                                                           |                                                           |                                                     |                  |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| <i>*Si souhaits fussent<br/>vrais,<br/>Pastoureaux rois<br/>seraient.</i> | $\left. \begin{array}{l} \} \\ \{ \end{array} \right\} =$ | If wishes were<br>horses,<br>Beggars would<br>ride. | <b>Souhaiter</b> |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|------------------|

[Compare *Si*.]

*Je t'en souhaite!* (pop.) = I wish you may get it. **Soûl**

*Souhaiter la bonne année à quelqu'un* = To wish some one a happy new year.

*\*A merle soûl cerises sont amères* = Plenty makes dainty. **Soulier**



*Parler tout son soûl* (pop.) = To speak to one's heart's content.

*Être dans ses petits souliers* = To be uneasy in one's mind; To be on pins and needles.

*Il faut se soumettre ou se démettre* = One must knuckle under or clear out.

[Gambetta said this to Marshal MacMahon during the crisis of 16th May 1875.]

*S'emporter comme une soupe au lait* = To fly into a passion without warning; To be of a very hasty temper.

*Trempé comme une soupe* = Wet to the skin; Dripping wet.

*C'est un marchand de soupe.* (See [Marchand](#).)

*Sourd comme un pot* = As deaf as a post. **Sourdine**

\**Vous faites la sourde oreille* = None so deaf as those who will not hear.

*Frapper comme un sourd* = To beat unmercifully.

*Il court un bruit sourd* = A rumour is being whispered.

*Ils ont recours à des menées sourdes* = They have recourse to underhand dealings.

*Il fait ses coups à la sourdine* = He acts secretly, in an underhand manner. **Sourire**

*Cela me sourit assez* = I rather like this.

**Souris**

\**Souris qui n'a qu'un trou est bientôt prise* = It is **Souvenir**  
good to have more than one string to one's bow.

\**On entendrait trotter une souris* (or, *voler une mouche*) = One could hear a pin drop.

*Elle est éveillée comme une petite souris* (or, *comme une potée de souris*) = She is as brisk as a bee.

*Autant que je puisse m'en souvenir* = To the best of **Souvent**  
my recollection.

*C'est du plus loin qu'il me souvienne* = 1. I can  
barely remember it. 2. It is as far back as I can  
recollect.

*Plus souvent!* (fam.) = Not if I know it! Twice!

**Sucre**

*Casser du sucre sur la tête de quelqu'un* (pop.) = To **Suite**  
speak ill of any one in his absence.

*Cette maladie peut avoir des suites* = That illness **Sujet**  
may have serious consequences.

*Il n'a pas d'esprit de suite* = He is not consistent; He  
keeps at nothing long.

*Suite* (of a serial story or article) = Continuation;  
Continued.

[Also: *Suite et fin* = Conclusion.

*À suivre* = To be continued.

*La suite au prochain numéro* = To be continued in our next.]

*Être sujet à l'heure* = To be tied to time.

**Supplice**

*Être sujet à caution* = Not to be relied upon. (See [Caution.](#))

*C'est un mauvais sujet* = He is a scamp, "a bad lot."

[This is used in speaking of tiresome children, of flighty young men, and of real rogues.]

*Petit mauvais sujet!* = Little rascal! (to children).

*Être au supplice* = To be on thorns.

**Sûr**

*Pour sûr!* (fam.) = I should think so, indeed!

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## T.

|                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Table</b>     | <p><i>Tenir table ouverte</i> = To keep open house.</p> <p><i>Faire table rase</i> = To make a clean sweep and begin again; To start everything afresh.</p> <p><i>Jouer cartes sur table</i> = To act frankly, above board.</p>                                                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Tâche</b>     | <p><i>Prendre à tâche</i> = To make it one's business.</p> <p><i>Travailler à la tâche</i> = To work by the piece.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Taillable</b> | <p><i>Vilains taillables et corvéables à merci</i> = Serfs taxable and workable at their lord's will and pleasure.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Taille</b>    | <p><i>Il est de taille à se défendre</i> = He is big enough to defend himself.</p> <p><i>"Ils nous ont fait une France à leur taille"</i> (BÉRANGER) = They have brought France down to their level.</p> <p><i>Se tenant par la taille</i> = With their arms round each other's waists.</p> <p><i>Frapper d'estoc et de taille</i> = 1. To cut and thrust. 2. To hit right and left; To lay about one.</p> |
| <b>Talon</b>     | <p><i>Il a l'esprit aux talons</i> = He shines at the wrong end; He is not witty.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |

*La bande se dispersa, les talons aux épaules* = The gang took to their heels.

**Tambour**

*J'ai l'estomac dans les talons* = I am very hungry.

*On l'a mené tambour battant* = They led him with a **Tant** high hand; They played the martinet with him.

*Il sortirent tambour battant, mèche allumée* = They went out with all the honours of war.

*Tous tant que nous sommes* = Every one of us.

**Tapis**

*Être tant à tant* = To be even (in a game).

*Si cela vous ennuie tant soit peu, ne le faites pas* = If that is the least trouble, do not do it.

*Elle n'est pas jolie, tant s'en faut* = She is not pretty, far from it; She is anything but good-looking.

*Vous m'en direz tant* = That alters the case; Ah! now I understand. (See [Dire](#).)

*Est-ce qu'elle est belle?—Elle est comme il y en a tant* = Is she beautiful?—Nothing to stare at; Nothing out of the common.

*Vous l'avez fait tant bien que mal* = You did it in a casual (off-hand) way.

*Je l'ai fait tant bien que mal* = I did it as well as I could, though I know it is not well done.

*Si tant est que ....* = If it be true that....

*Être sur le tapis* = To be the subject of general conversation; To be broached.

**Tapisserie**

*Amuser le tapis* (or, *la galerie*) = To amuse people by talking the time away.

*Faire tapisserie* (fam.) = To be a wall-flower at a **Tard** ball.

\**Mieux vaut tard que jamais* = Better late than never. **Tarder**

[This is first found in Dionysius of Halicarnassus (ix. 11): "It is better beginning late doing our duties than never."]

*Il me tarde de parler* = I am anxious to speak. **Tarte**

*Il ne tardera pas à venir* = It will not be long before he comes.

*C'est sa tarte à la crème* = It is his one constant **Tel** objection.

[MOLIÈRE, *École des Femmes*, i. 1.]

\**Tel maître, tel valet* = Like master, like man; Like **Temps** well, like bucket.

["Selon le clerc est deu le maistre."—VILLON, *Grand Testament*, 568.]

\**Telle vie, telle fin* = Men die as they live.

*Je vous le rends tel quel* = I return it to you just as it was lent to me.

*Je la prendrai telle quelle* = I will take it just as it is.

*Ce sont des gens tels quels* (fam.) = They are "no great shakes," just ordinary people, humdrum people.

*Tel est pris qui croyait prendre* = It is a case of the biter bit.

*Monsieur un tel* = Mr. So-and-so.

*Il se donne du bon temps* = He does not work too hard; He enjoys himself; He has a good time of it. **Tendre**

*Il prend le temps comme il vient* = He takes things easily.

*Cela a fait son temps* = That has had its day.

\**Du temps que Berthe filait* = When the world was young; When Adam delved and Eve span.

*Si le temps le permet* = Wind and weather permitting.

*Le temps est à la pluie* = It looks like rain.

*Le temps perdu ne se répare* (or, *rattrape*) *pas* = Time wasted is gone indeed.

\**Qui a temps a vie* = While there is life, there is hope; *Dum spiro spero*.

*Par le temps qui court* = Nowadays; As times go.

\**Autres temps, autres mœurs* = Manners change with the times.

*Au temps!* = As you were! (military command).

[This is sometimes incorrectly written “Autant,” but military movements were formerly divided into *temps*. When the drill-sergeant makes a mistake in giving the word of command, he says, “Au temps pour moi” = “My mistake, as you were!”]

*Il vaut mieux tendre la main que le cou* = It is better to beg than to steal. **Tendresse**

*L’arc toujours tendu se gâte* = All work and no play makes Jack a dull boy.

[“Neque semper arcum tendit Apollo.”—HORACE, *Carm*, II. x. 20.]

|                                    |   |   |                  |              |
|------------------------------------|---|---|------------------|--------------|
| <i>Tendresse maternelle</i>        | } | = | A mother's truth | <b>Tenir</b> |
| <i>Toujours se<br/>renouvelle.</i> |   |   | {                |              |

[Archbishop Trench quotes the French and German forms as rhyming equally well in both languages; the English, he confesses, is not such a good translation. The German is:

Mutter treu'  
Wird täglich neu.]

*Il ne tint à rien qu'ils ne se battissent* = They were **Terme**  
within an ace of fighting.

*Quand on est bien, on ne s'y peut tenir* = The love of  
change makes us give up even a comfortable  
position.

*Un tiens vaut mieux que deux tu l'auras* = A bird in  
the hand is worth two in the bush.

[Also: *Un bon aujourd'hui vaut mieux que deux demain.*]

*Il tient de son père* = He takes after his father.

*Il tient à ce livre* = He treasures that book.

*Je ne tiens plus à rien* = I no longer care for  
anything.

*Il ne tiendra pas à moi qu'il ne réussisse* = It will not  
be my fault if he does not succeed.

*Je le tiens de bonne source* = I have it on good  
authority.

*Tenir le loup par les oreilles* = To be in a critical  
situation, dilemma.

*On le tient à quatre* = It needs four men to hold him  
down.

*Je me suis tenu à quatre pour ne pas lui dire ses  
vérités* = It was almost more than I could do not to



tell him what I thought of him.

*Il n'y a pas d'amitié qui tienne* = Friendship has nothing to do with the question; It must be done in spite of friendship.

*Qu'à cela ne tienne* = Do not let that be any objection; Never mind that.

*Je n'y tiens pas* = I am not particular about it; I am not keen on it.

*Je n'y tiens plus* = I cannot stand it any longer.

*Je n'y ai pas tenu* = I could not contain myself.

*Je ne sais à quoi m'en tenir* = I do not know what to believe.

*Tenir comme teigne* (pop.) = To stick like wax.

*À quoi cela tient-il?* = What is that owing to?

*Il ne tient qu'à lui de commencer* = It rests entirely with him to begin; He can begin when he likes.

*Cela lui tient au cœur* = He is anxious about it.

*Il n'a pas cédé, il a tenu bon* = He did not give away, he stuck to it.

*Tenez-vous-le pour dit* = Take it for granted; Bear that in mind.

*Il en tient* = 1. He is smitten. 2. He is caught.

*Tenez-vous-en là* = Stop there, go no further in the matter; Be satisfied with what you have already obtained.

*Tiens! c'est vous?* = Hullo! is that you?

*Tiens, tiens!* = Indeed, you don't say so!

*\*Il y a terme à tout* = There is an end to everything. **Terrain**

[A German proverb says: "Everything has an end—a sausage two."]

*\*Qui a terme ne doit rien* = No one is obliged to pay before a debt is due.

*Le terme vaut l'argent* = Time is money.

*Ménagez un peu vos termes* = Moderate your expressions a little; Be a little careful in what you say.

*En mathématiques il est sur son terrain* = He is quite **Terroir** in his element at mathematics.

*Tâter le terrain* = To feel one's way (fig.).

*Il sent le terroir* = He is racy of the soil; He savours **Tête** of his country.

*Il a la tête près du bonnet* = He is hasty, hot-headed. **Tiers**

*\*Ce sont deux têtes dans un bonnet* = They are hand and glove together.

*Cet homme y va tête baissée* = That man rushes blindly into it; That man sets to work energetically.

*C'est un homme de tête* = He has a head on his shoulders; He is a man of resource.

*Il s'est monté la tête* = He got excited over fancied or exaggerated wrongs.

*C'est une tête carrée* = He is an obstinate fellow.

*J'en ai par-dessus la tête* = 1. I am sick and tired of it. 2. I am head over ears in it.

*Je lui laverai la tête* (pop.) = I will give it to him; I will give him a sound drubbing.

*Il ne sait où donner de la tête* = He does not know which way to turn.

[Donner here has the meaning of *heurter, frapper de la tête*.]

*Donner de la tête contre le mur* = To hit one's head against a stone wall.

*La tête me tourne* = I feel giddy; my head swims.

*Il a mauvaise tête* = He is a wrong-headed fellow.

*Il fait à sa tête* = He will have his own way.

*Cet homme a mauvaise tête et bon cœur* = That man is quick-tempered, but kind-hearted.

*Vous lui avez tenu tête* = You did not give in to him.

*Cet homme a de la tête* = That man has his head screwed on the right way.

*Il ne faut pas dire vos affaires au tiers et au quart* = **Timbre**  
You must not tell your business to all the world, to everybody.

*Le tiers et le quart* = Tom, Dick, and Harry.

*Il a le timbre fêlé* (fam.) = He is cracked; He has a **Tirer**  
screw loose.

*Il se fera tirer l'oreille* = He will require pressing. **Titre**

*Il tire le diable par la queue* = He leads a struggling existence.

*Vous ne me tirerez pas les vers du nez* = You will not pump me (i.e. make me tell secrets).

*Cet homme se tirerait d'un puits* = That man would get out of any difficulty, is full of resource.

*Je me ferais tirer à quatre avant de parler* = Wild horses would not make me speak.

*Il tire (touche) à sa fin* = He is on his last legs.

*Je saurai en tirer parti* = I shall be able to turn it to account.

*\*Tirez le rideau, la farce est jouée* = Ring down the curtain, the play is over.

[Words reported to have been said by Rabelais just before his death.]

*On m'a donné cela à titre gratuit (or, gracieux)* = **Toit**  
They gave me that for nothing.

*Cet or n'est pas au titre légal* = This gold is not up to the standard.

*À ce titre (compte) j'y perds* = At that rate I am a loser.

*Crier par-dessus les toits* = To proclaim from the **Tomber** housetops.

*Je tombe d'accord avec vous sur ce point* = I am at **Tordre** one with you on that head.

*Je tombe des nues* = I am astounded.

*Cet homme-là est bien tombé* = That man has fallen on his feet; That man has applied to the right person (or, ironic), to the wrong person.

*L'enfant tombe par terre, mais le fruit tombe à terre*  
= A child falls on the ground, while fruit falls to the earth.

[*Par terre* = from one's own height; *à terre* = from any height.]

*Je me tordais de rire (fam.)* = I was splitting my **Tort** sides (or, convulsed) with laughter.

*Vous vous êtes mis dans votre tort* = You put yourself **Tôt** in the wrong.

*À tort ou à raison* = Rightly or wrongly.

*À tort et à travers* = At random, thoughtlessly.

*\*Le plus tôt sera le mieux* = The sooner, the better.    **Toucher**

*Elle a l'air de ne pas y toucher* = She looks as if **Tour** butter would not melt in her mouth; She is very sarcastic without appearing to mean anything. (Comp. *Nitouche*.)

*C'est un touche-à-tout* = He is a Jack of all trades; He meddles with everything.

*Cela touche à la folie* = That is but one remove from madness; That borders on lunacy.

*Touchez-là* = Here's my hand on it.

*Faire ses quinze (or, trente-six) tours* = To do a **Trac** hundred useless things.

*\*À chacun son tour* = Every dog has his day; Now it is my turn.

*Elle est faite au tour (or, moule)* = She has a splendid figure.

*Il fit cela en un tour de main* = He did that in a moment.

*Un tour de faveur* = Permission to go (or, do anything) before one's turn.

*Avoir le trac* (fam.) = To be funky.

**Train**

*Mettre une affaire en train* = To put a thing in hand. **Trait**

*Pas dans le train* = Not up-to-date; Of an older school.

*Il le mène bon train dans cette affaire* = He drives him hard in that matter.

*Il nous a menés bon train* = He brought us along at a great rate.

*Allez toujours votre train* = Go on as usual.

*Il est en train d'écrire* = He is in the act of writing; He is just writing.

*Je ne suis pas en train ce matin* = I do not feel myself this morning.

*Il est en train* (pop.) = He is slightly intoxicated.

*Faire du train* (pop.) = To kick up a dust.

*Il mène grand train* = He lives like a lord.

*À fond de train* = At full speed.

*Ce que vous dites n'a pas trait à la question* = What **Traite** you say has nothing to do with the question.

*Ce sont là de vos traits* = That is just like you.

*Avaler d'un trait* = To drink off at one gulp, at a draught.

*Tout d'une traite* = At a stretch, without stopping.

**Traiter**

*Il m'a traité de fat* = He called me a fop. **Traître**

*Il m'a traité en roi* = He treated me like a lord.

*Il n'a pas dit un traître mot* = He never spoke a **Tramontane** single word.

*Perdre la tramontane* = Not to know which way to **Trancher** turn; To lose one's head.

[Literally, to lose one's bearings. Tramontane is derived from the Italian *tramontana*, and originally meant the pole-star, which was the star seen from the Mediterranean across the mountains (the Alps). Compare *s'orienter*. See [Boule](#).]

*Cet homme n'est pas très honnête, tranchons le mot*, **Travers** *c'est un coquin* = That man is not very honourable, in plain English, he is a rascal. (See [Mot](#).)

*Trancher la question, la difficulté* = To cut the Gordian knot; To solve the difficulty.

*Trancher du grand seigneur* = To try and play the lord.

*Trancher dans le vif* = (lit.) To cut to the quick; (fig.) To set to work in earnest.

*Il a l'esprit de travers* = He has an awkward temper; **Tréfonds** He does not see things as they are; He is cross-grained.

*Il me regarda de travers* = He looked black (askance) at me.

*Il prend tout de travers* = He takes everything amiss.

*J'en sais le fonds et le tréfonds* = I know the ins and outs of it, the long and the short of it.

[Also: *Je connais les tenants et aboutissants de l'affaire.*]

*Nous fûmes trempés jusqu'aux os* = We were wet to the skin.

*Être sur son trente-et-un* (fam.) = To be dressed up to the nines.

*\*Tricherie revient à son maître* = Curses, like chickens, come home to roost.

*Les soldats de la Garde étaient tous triés sur le volet* = The soldiers of the Guard were all picked men.

[*Volet* is a gardener's board on which he sorts seeds.]

*C'est un triste sire* = He is a despicable, dishonourable fellow.

*Il n'y a pas à s'y tromper* = There is no mistake about it.

*Je ne sais trop* = I don't exactly know. **Trou**

*\*Qui dit trop ne dit rien* = He who wants to prove too much proves nothing.

*Faire un trou à la lune* (fam.) = To shoot the moon; To fly from one's creditors. **Troubler**



*C'est un trouble-fête* = He is a mar-joy, a wet  
blanket. **Trousse**

*Le voleur fuyait, mais nous étions à ses trousses* =  
The thief made off, but we were at his heels. **Trouver**

*Cela se trouve bien* = That is lucky. **Tu**

*Être à tu et à toi* = To be on very familiar terms with. **Tuer**

*Crier à tue-tête* = To shout at the top of one's voice.

---

## U.

- Un**            *Ne faire ni une ni deux* = To make no bones about it;  
                    To make up one's mind quickly.  
*C'est tout un* = It is all the same.
- Union**        *L'union fait la force* = United we stand, divided we  
                    fall.
- Usine**        *Ce ne sont que des usines à bachot* (pop.) = They are  
                    mere cramming shops.  
                    [*Bachot* = *baccalauréat* = matriculation. The French equivalent for our  
                    B.A. is rather *licencié-ès-lettres*, although the examinations in the  
                    two countries are so different that any comparison is very difficult.]
-

## V.

### Vache

*Parler français comme une vache espagnole* = To talk horribly bad French. (See [Français](#).)

*“Un homme qui n’a jamais mangé de la vache enragée n’est jamais qu’une poule mouillée”* (Mme. DE GIRARDIN) = A man who has never roughed it is always a milksop.

*C’est le grand chemin des vaches* = That is the beaten track.

*Le plancher des vaches* (fam.) = Terra firma.

### Vaincre

\**“À vaincre sans péril, on triomphe sans gloire”* = Where there is no danger, there is no glory.

[CORNEILLE, *Cid*, ii. 2. Compare: “Scit eum sine gloria vinci qui sine periculo vincitur.”—SENECA, *De Providentia*, iii.]

### Valet

*Il n’y a pas de grand homme pour son valet de chambre* = No man is a hero to his valet.

*On ne prend pas de valet pour se servir soi-même* = What! keep a dog and bark thyself!

### Valeur

*“Aux âmes bien nées  
La valeur n’attend pas le nombre des  
années.”*

CORNEILLE, *Cid*, ii. 2.

= Really brave men show their valour when quite young.

**Valoir**

*Cela vaut fait* = That is as good as done.

*Vaut bien que mal* = *Vaille que vaille* = At all events;  
For better, for worse.

*Il se fait trop valoir* = He brags too much.

**Veine**

*Je suis en veine de le faire* = I am just in the humour  
to do it.

*J'ai de la veine* (pop.) = I am in luck.

**Velours**

*Faire patte de velours* = To speak smoothly; To draw  
in one's claws.

\**Habit de velours, ventre de son* = Silks and satins  
put out the kitchen fire.

[Compare:

“Dress drains our cellar dry,  
And keeps our larder lean.”

COWPER, *Task*, ii. 614.

An old French dicton says:

“Ne sois paon en ton parer,  
Ny perroquet en ton parler,  
Ny cicogne en ton manger,  
Ny oye aussi en ton marcher.”]

**Vendre**

\**Chose qui plaît est à moitié vendue* = Good wares  
make quick market; Please the eye and fill the  
purse.

[“Chose qui plaist est à demy vendue.”—CHARLES D'ORLÉANS,  
*Rondeau* 194.]

**Venir**

\**Tout vient à point à qui sait attendre* = Everything  
comes to the man who waits.

[The older form of the proverb omitted *à*; for *qui* = *si on*.]

*C'est un beau venir y voir* = A pretty sight indeed!

*Où voulez-vous en venir?* = What are you driving at?

What is your drift?

**Vent**

*Il se vante d'en venir à bout* = He says he is sure to succeed.

*Il fait un vent à décorner (or, écorner) un bœuf* = **Ventre**

There is a wind enough to blow one's head off.

*Autant en emporte le vent* = That is but so much breath spent in vain; It is not of the slightest consequence.

\**Vent au visage rend un homme sage* = Adversity makes a man wise, not rich.

*Celui qui sème le vent récolte la tempête* = He who sows the wind reaps the whirlwind; Those who live in glass houses should not throw stones.

\**Ventre affamé prend tout en gré* =

**Ver**

"They that have no other meat,  
Bread and butter are glad to eat."

\**Ventre affamé n'a point d'oreilles* = A hungry man will not listen to reason; A hungry man is an angry man.

*Cela lui remet du cœur au ventre* (fam.) = That gives him courage again.

*Savoir ce que quelqu'un a dans le ventre* (fam.) = To know what a person is worth, what he thinks; To know the stuff a man is made of.

*Il n'a pas trois mois dans le ventre* (fam.) = He cannot live three months.

*Le cheval courait ventre à terre* = The horse was running as hard as he could tear.

*Il était à plat ventre* = He was flat on his face.

*Nu comme un ver* = Stark naked; As naked as when **Vérité** one was born.

*\*On dit souvent la vérité en riant* = There is many a **Verrier** true word spoken in jest.

*Toute vérité n'est pas bonne à dire* = All truths are not to be spoken at all times.

*La vérité comme l'huile vient au-dessus* = Truth will out; It takes a good many shovelfuls of earth to bury the Truth.

[The Spaniards say: La verdad es hija de Dios = Truth is the daughter of God.]

*C'est une vérité de Monsieur de la Palisse* = It is an evident truth.

[M. de la Palisse is the hero of a lengthy poem, one of the verses of which runs as follows:

“M. de la Palisse est mort  
Mort de maladie  
Un quart d'heure avant sa mort  
Il était encore en vie.”]

*Il court comme un verrier déchargé* = He runs like a **Vers** lamplighter. (See [Chat](#).)

[Glaziers, when carrying glass, have to walk carefully and slowly. When they have got rid of their load they make up for lost time.]

*“Les plus beaux vers sont ceux qu'on ne peut pas **Vert** écrire.”*—(LAMARTINE, *Voyage en Orient*) =  
“Ah! the best prayers that faith may ever think  
Are untranslatable by pen and ink.”

Bishop ALEXANDER.

*Vous ne le prendrez pas sans vert* = You will not **Vessie** catch him napping.

[An old game that used to be played in May was for two people to undertake to be able always to show a green twig; failure to do so lost the game.]

*Une verte vieillesse* = A hale old age.

*Ils sont trop verts* = The grapes are sour.

[LA FONTAINE, *Le Renard et les Raisins*, iii. 11.]

*Mettre un cheval au vert* = To send a horse to grass.

*Il veut nous faire prendre des vessies pour des Vie lanternes* = He wishes us to believe the moon is made of green cheese.

["Me voulez vous faire entendre  
De vecies que ce sont lanternes?"

*Maistre Pierre Pathelin*, 800.]

*Faire vie qui dure* = To live temperately; To husband **Vieux** one's resources.

*Avoir la vie dure* = 1. To have a hard time. 2. To have nine lives.

*Vieux comme les rues, comme le monde* = As old as **Vif** the hills.

*C'est un homme de la vieille roche* = He is a man of the old school; he belongs to the good old stock.

*Un vieux de la vieille* = A veteran of the old Imperial Guard; One of the old brigade.

*Vieil ami et vieux vin sont vraiment deux bons vieux, mais vieux écus sont encore mieux* = Old friends and old wine are good, but old gold is better than both.

[“Alonzo of Arragon was wont to say in commendation of Age, that Age appeared to be best in four things: Old wood best to burn, old wine to drink, old friends to trust, and old authors to read.”—BACON, *Apophthegms*, 101.]

*Trancher* (or, *couper*) *dans le vif* = (lit.) To cut to the **Vigne** quick; (fig.) To set to work in earnest.

*Ce reproche l’a piqué au vif* = That reproach stung him to the quick.

*Il est vif comme la poudre* = 1. He is quick-tempered.  
2. He is bustling, quick at work.

*De vive voix* = By word of mouth; Orally.

*Ce sont des descriptions prises sur le vif* = Those descriptions are life-like.

*Les paysans dans ce tableau sont pris sur le vif* = The peasants in that picture are life-like.

*Il est dans les vignes du Seigneur* = He is in his cups. **Vin**

*Du vin à faire danser les chèvres* = Sour wine not fit **Violent** to drink.

\**À bon vin point d’enseigne* = Good wine needs no bush.

[It was a Roman custom to hang out a branch of ivy at the doors of taverns in honour of Bacchus. Branches of green stuff may still be seen at the doors of wineshops along the Loire and in Burgundy. Kelly traces the word “bosky” (i.e. drunk) to this bush.]

*Être entre deux vins* = To be half seas over (pop.).

\**Le vin entre, la raison sort* = When ale is in, wit is out.

*On ne connaît pas le vin aux cercles* = You can’t judge cigars by the picture on the box.



*Tremper son vin* = To water one's wine.

[*Tremper* = *tempérer*, not to wet, but to moderate.]

*Vous mouillez trop votre vin* = You are drowning the miller.

*Cela est un peu violent* = That is too bad.

**Violon**

*Payer les violons* = To pay the piper.

**Visière**

*Je lui ai rompu en visière* = I attacked (or, contradicted) him openly.

["Je n'y puis plus tenir, j'enrage; et mon dessein  
Est de rompre en visière à tout le genre humain."]

MOLIÈRE, *Le Misanthrope*, i.  
1.

Literally the phrase means: to break one's lance against the visor of one's enemy.]

*Plus vite que ça* (fam.) = Look sharp about it.

**Vivre**

*Je n'ai pas trouvé âme qui vive* = I did not find a soul.

\**Qui vivra verra* = He who lives longest will see most; Time will show (tell).

*Monsieur vit de ses rentes* = The gentleman is independent (i.e. has an income of his own).

*Apprendre à vivre* = To learn manners.

*Je lui apprendrai à vivre* = I will teach him better manners (as a threat).

*Comme c'est vécu!* = How true to life!

*Ils en sont venus aux voies de fait* = They came to blows. **Voilà**

*Il est toujours par voies et par chemins* = He is always on the move, rambling.

*Les affaires sont en voie de hausse* = Things are looking up.

*Être sur la voie* = To be on the scent.

*Je suis en voie de le finir* = I am in a fair way to finish it.

*Comme le voilà sale!* = Just see how dirty he is! **Voir**

*Ne voilà-t-il pas qu'il est revenu* = Who should come back but he?

*Voilà comme vous êtes* = That is just like you.

*Voilà comme je suis* = You must take me as I am; That's my way.

*On n'y voit goutte* = One can see nothing. **Voix**

*J'y vois trouble* = I see dimly; My sight is dim.

*Vous n'avez rien à y voir* = That is no business of yours.

*Au vu et au su de tout le village* = Openly, before the whole village.

*Je vous vois venir* = I see what you are driving at.

*J'ai voulu voir par moi-même* = I wish to see with my own eyes.

*Il nous en a fait voir de toutes les couleurs* = He told us all sorts of tales; He worried us beyond all bearing.

*Je n'ai pas voix au chapitre* = (lit.) I have no right to **Volée** speak; (fig.) My opinion is not listened to.

*Il a obtenu cela entre bond et volée* = He obtained **Voleur** that at a lucky moment.

*À toute volée* = At random; At full swing.

*Il est de la haute volée* = He is a tip-top swell, of the first water, of the upper ten.

Voler (to fly)

*On pouvait entendre voler une mouche* = One could hear a pin drop.

Voler (to steal)

*\*Il ne l'a pas volé* = He richly deserves it.

*\*Quand les voleurs se battent, les larcins se* **Volonté** *découvrent* = When thieves fall out, honest men get their own.

*\*La bonne volonté est réputée pour le fait* = The will **Vôtre** is as good as (is taken for) the deed.

*Je serai des vôtres* = I shall be one of your party; **IVouer** shall be on your side.

*Vous avez fait des vôtres* = You have committed follies yourself; You have played pranks too.

*Je ne sais à quel saint me vouer* = I do not know **Vouloir** which way to turn.

\**Vouloir c'est pouvoir* = Where there's a will there's **Vrai**  
a way.

[Also: *La volonté rend tout possible*.

“Impossible est un mot que je ne dis jamais.”—COLLIN D’HARLEVILLE,  
*Malice pour Malice*, i. 8.

Napoléon I., in a letter to Lemarois, 9th July 1813, wrote: “Ce n’est  
pas possible, m’écrivez vous, cela n’est pas Français.”

“Mirabeau disait un jour à son secrétaire: ‘Impossible! ne me dites  
jamais ce bête de mot.’”—DUMONT, *Vie de Mirabeau*, quoted in  
Carlyle’s *French Revolution*, vol. ii. p. 118.]

*Que voulez-vous?* = 1. What do you want? What can  
I do for you? 2. What was to be done? 3. What can  
you expect?

*Vous l’avez voulu!* = It is your own fault; You would  
have it.

[“Vous l’avez voulu, George Dandin!”

MOLIÈRE, *George Dandin*, i.  
9.]

*On ne peut lui en vouloir* = One cannot be angry  
with him, blame him.

*En veux-tu? en voilà!* = As much as ever you like.

*Il y en avait à bouche que veux-tu* = There was an  
abundant supply of it; There was plenty for every  
one.

*Il sait ce que parler veut dire* = He understands the  
hidden meaning; He takes the hint.

*Je le veux bien* = With pleasure! I have no objection.

\*“*Le vrai peut quelquefois n’être pas vraisemblable*”  
= Truth is stranger than fiction.

[BOILEAU, *Art Poétique*, iii. 48.]

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## Z.

### **Zèle**

*Surtout, messieurs, pas de zèle!* = Above all, gentlemen, don't be too anxious! Don't try to hurry things on.

[Words attributed to Talleyrand on receiving the staff of the Ministère des Affaires Étrangères.]

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*“Trop gratter cuit,  
Trop parler nuit,  
Trop manger n’est pas sage.  
A barbon gris  
Jeune souris:  
L’Amour est de tout âge.  
Enfants de Paris, quel temps fait-il?  
Il pleut là-bas, il neige ici  
Pendant la nuit  
Tous chats sont gris.  
Pour faire route sûre  
Si l’amour va  
Cahin-caha  
Ménage ta monture.”*

CHARLES COLLÉ (1709-1783).

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- “Sa faire la barbe” was changed to “[Se faire la barbe](#)” on page 31.
- “loche” was changed to “[cloche](#)” on page 121.
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